LEARNING IN ACTION

Designing Successful Graduate Student Work Experiences in Academic Libraries

edited by
Arianne Hartsell-Gundy,
Kim Duckett, and
Sarah Morris

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Association of College and Research Libraries
A division of the American Library Association
Chicago, Illinois 2022

The paper used in this publication meets the minimum requirements of American National Standard for Information Sciences–Permanence of Paper for Printed Library Materials, ANSI Z39.48-1992. ∞

Library of Congress Control Number: 2022941615

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Printed in the United States of America.

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Acknowledgements

Special thanks to all our colleagues across the country who worked with us as graduate students and taught us so much, including but not only Rebecca Caudle, Victoria Dawkins, Kevin Klipfel, Caroline Eckardt, Hannah Pope, Claire Cahoon, Kayla Olson, Rolando Rodriguez, Julia Glauberman, Kodi Saylor, Ellen Cline, Megan Boland, Anastasia Forte, Madeline Snipes, and Anna Twiddy.

We'd also like to thank Dr. Amy VanScoy for carefully reviewing our manuscript and championing our project!

INTRODUCTION

Learning in Action:

Designing Successful Graduate Student Work Experiences in Academic Libraries

Origins of the Book

This book arose out of a sincere, practical question: How do you supervise a graduate student working in a library? And how do you do it not just adequately, but well? When the editors found themselves chatting about supervising students at a conference, that single practical question bloomed into many related questions, from philosophical (*What is a valuable and meaningful work experience?*) to pointed (*How can libraries design more equitable positions for students?*) to personal (*How did I learn to be a manager?*). With a bouquet of questions, we turned to our colleagues to hear if they had asked them too, and what they had found.

Over the past decades, the place of work experience in library and information science (LIS) education has been frequently explored. Some of this literature focuses on LIS education itself and how to meaningfully incorporate experiential workplace learning into the curriculum.[1] There have also been notable publications that have explored how to create well-designed paid and unpaid work experiences in particular academic library contexts such as reference and instruction, special collections, and technical services.[2] Other literature has

tackled a range of different issues with a focus on how to make the experiences impactful for both the graduates and library staff they work with.[3] These articles are complemented by adjacent literature on topics such as designing and running postgraduate residency programs that provide useful ideas and strategies that can be applied to work experiences for graduate students.[4] When we explored this literature, much of which is cited by this book's authors, we still found gaps and unconnected ideas. Through this book we set out to bring together a range of topics and perspectives from authors of diverse backgrounds and institutions into conversation and connection with one another—all with the focus on how to create and manage impactful programs as well as meaningful personal experiences for students as well as library staff in academic libraries.

We were grateful for the existing literature but we saw space where our questions were still resounding: How do institutions design structures that are equitable for training graduate students? How do you bridge critical gaps with temporary staff? How should a manager be? What does it look like to have an internship that acknowledges the whole person, their intersecting identities, and their needs? We wanted to see a book that had room and space for all of these questions and more.

Call and Response

In our initial proposal and call for participation, we asked for chapters "examining how academic librarians can best support interns, graduate assistants, and practicum and field experience students (both LIS and other fields)." Throughout the resulting chapters, you will see that the terminology for workplace learning varies a great deal, as institutions have different names and parameters for their student work experiences. We welcomed submissions with all variations of titles for their student positions; for more thinking on the significance of naming when creating positions, look to the piece titled "Internship: What's in a Name?"

We solicited chapters focused on philosophical perspectives, practical strategies, reflective essays, or case studies—calling specifically for chapters related to preparing graduate students for professional roles, logistics and structures of student work experiences, ethical considerations, and managers' and students' perspectives. In our CFP we tried to parse out each of these parts broadly, strategically offering many examples and options to model the expansive mindset we were aiming for in this book. We had hoped that the cluster of questions related to graduate student practicums in libraries would resonate with our colleagues, but the number of responses we received far surpassed our hopes, a happy affirmation that other people in our communities were asking these questions. We received a large number of submissions from public and private colleges and universities across North America, as well as from special libraries, museums, and community colleges! After receiving these submissions, we were eager to

include the valuable perspective pieces we received, but we realized that a chapter format might not suit their anecdotal structure, so we returned to these authors and asked if they would be willing to write smaller, pointed profiles instead.

Navigating This Book

Reading through submissions from our incredibly competitive pool refined our organizational structure, and we refashioned our book to be more nuanced and varied and, we hope, useful. We created the four parts, each of which has a succinct preface designed to highlight chapters' themes and to put the authors in conversation with one another. If you're unsure where to start, we recommend reading these prefaces and diving into the chapters that speak to your interests. While this book offers approaches and models more than tidy resolutions, we did design it to be rewarding to read linearly, and throughout the book we were intentional with our pairing of profiles and chapters. Here is some insight into our thinking:

Parts

In the first part, which we titled "Creating Access Pathways," we feature authors who reckon with questions about whom we design these internships and practicums for, and whom they might exclude. These chapters offer insight into barriers that graduate students may encounter when applying for or participating in work experiences in libraries. Many of these structural challenges may resonate with you—funding, systemic racism, lack of local opportunities or resources—and these authors address them honestly and openly. These chapters also offer practical strategies for designing work experiences that acknowledge and mitigate these barriers, and we think this part is a great place to start reflecting on what we are really asking of our student workforce.

The next two parts can be read in tandem, self-evidently titled "Developing, Running, and Evolving Programs for LIS Students" and "Working with Graduate Students without an LIS Background: Mutual Opportunities for Growth." Part II features chapters that describe programs that explicitly employ LIS graduate students. Some are case studies of thoughtful program components or revisions that support student education, and some include broader reflections based on data from campus- and field-wide surveys. These chapters zoom in to particulars but also zoom out to consider the future of training in our profession.

Part III features chapters discussing programs that offer positions in the library to students who are not expressly seeking a degree in library or information science. These chapters will be useful to any school that does not have a local information school (which is many of us, it turns out). These chapters and profiles consider what our libraries can gain from positioning themselves

in relationship to other fields, on campus and broadly. The lessons in both of these parts touch on many more aspects than the source of student labor, and we invite you to read both of these parts, whether your student workers come from library programs or from other disciplines.

Our last part is titled "Centering the Person," and it features generous and rigorous examinations of management philosophies and culture. The authors of these chapters are deeply interested in holistic approaches to supervising—building empathy, practicing advocacy, sharing authority. The voices in this part bring our book back to perhaps that first essential question, How do you supervise well?

Profiles

Throughout the book you will notice shorter sections, which we call profiles, that are offset in gray. It was important to us, designing this book about graduate student work, to include a host of perspectives, including those of the graduate students themselves, recent graduates, and managers. We are thrilled to showcase their voices and reflections and to offer them as complements to the longer chapters. We intentionally paired profiles with chapters where we felt a resonance. Sometimes the connection is obvious, and sometimes it's more oblique—life experiences don't always fit neatly into categories. We feel there is great deal of wisdom in the anecdotal and personal, and we hope you enjoy these profiles as much as we do.

Conclusion

Any good librarian knows that a question can hold a thousand questions. The ambitious scope of this book and resounding interest from our authors show that there are many more questions to be asked. We hope that you find some practical inspiration here, a model or framework for creating meaningful graduate student work experiences at your institutions. And more than anything, we hope that you find in this book a community to ask those unsolved and newly opened questions with. As April Hathcock, one of our authors, said in a recent panel discussing parts of this book, graduate students are not future colleagues, they *are* our colleagues.[5]

Notes

1. For example, J. Gordon Coleman Jr., "The Role of Practicum in Library Schools," *Journal of Education for Library and Information Science* 30, no. 1 (Summer 1989): 19–27, https://doi.org/10.2307/40323496.
2. Tanner D. Lewey and Hannah Moody-Goo, "Management: Designing a Meaningful Reference and Instruction Internship: The MLIS Student Perspective," *Reference and User Services Quarterly* 57, no. 4 (2018): 238–41, https://doi.org/10.5860/rusq.57.4.6699; Jennifer E. Nutefall, "Structuring a Successful Instruction Internship," *College and Undergraduate Libraries* 19, no. 1 (2012): 80–94, https://doi.org/1

0.1080/10691316.2012.652550; Maggie Gallup Koop, "Internships in Special Collections: Experiential Pedagogy, Intentional Design, and High-Impact Practice." *RBM: A Journal of Rare Books, Manuscripts, and Cultural Heritage* 20, no. 1 (Spring 2019): 12–27, https://rbm.acrl.org/index.php/rbm/article/view/17769/19581; Melanie J. McGurr and Ione T. Damasco, "Improving the Practicum or Internship Experience in Cataloging," *Technical Services Quarterly* 27, no. 1 (2010): 1–16.

3. For example, Nora J. Bird and Michael A. Crumpton, eds., *Short-Term Staff, Long-Term Benefits*(Santa Barbara, CA: Libraries Unlimited, 2018).
4. Lorelei Rutledge et al., *Developing a Residency Program* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2019).
5. April Hathcock, in Sarah Morris et al., "A Prismatic and Strategic Exploration of EDI in Graduate Student Internships and Practicums" (presentation, Association of College and Research Libraries Conference, online, April 16, 2021).

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Part I

Creating Access Pathways

Introduction

We decided to begin this book with the chapters in the part "Creating Access Pathways" because we felt it was important to begin this conversation with an examination of some of the difficulties that may hinder a graduate student's ability to take part in experiential learning opportunities. These barriers can include financial considerations, family obligations, systemic racism, other work commitments, lack of local opportunities, and more. While there is no perfect one-size solution, these chapter authors provide ideas on how to ultimately improve the experiences of all graduate students. Any library or librarian considering creating internships and practicums should consider the potential barriers as early as possible to ensure that opening more doors for more students is not an afterthought, but rather a fundamental part of their program.

The chapters in this part explore creating more access from several different approaches. First, Flota, Lane, and Liu (chapter 1) address the ethical considerations they encountered while creating a summer internship at James Madison University Libraries, particularly in terms of labor considerations and financial barriers. They very aptly demonstrate the value of deliberate and early planning and of being reflective and iterative as they work to improve the experience. The next chapter, from Moreno Ortiz, Flamenco, Dávila, Fernández, and Filar Williams (chapter 2), discusses the Diversity Scholars Program at Oregon State University, a program designed to provide students of color with not just an internship, but opportunities for mentorship, funded professional development, and real-world experiences such as serving on library-wide committees. A real strength of this chapter is the voices of the first three Diversity Scholars, who each provide a candid look into their struggles and their successes. The final chapter, from Bailund and Miskey (chapter 3), argues for the need for more online experiential learning opportunities that are thoughtfully created because of the increase in online master's degree programs. Students in these programs may not be physically close to an academic library and in many cases are more likely to be returning adults with full-time jobs.

This part also includes two profiles that further the conversation around different forms of access: a manager's profile focusing on the creation of a completely online practicum and a student profile advocating for the value of internships at small GLAM (gallery, library, archives, museum) institutions.

If you are thinking about how to increase equity and access in your programs, these chapters will be a good place to start as they provide valuable reflections and practical advice to help you increase opportunities for all graduate students and to create meaningful learning opportunities.

CHAPTER 1

"What If You Don't Have a Library School?"

Ethical Considerations for a Summer Internship at an Academic Library

Brian Flota, Mark Lane, and Juhong Christie Liu

Introduction

Enabling professional working experiences for library and information science (LIS) graduate students is always rewarding. With this chapter, the authors will reflect on the operation, collaborative processes, and results of an academic library's summer internship program. Ethical aspects related to ensuring intern pay, along with individual goal-based learning in a real workplace and the integrity of professional status, will provide insights for others looking to plan or implement similar programs.

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In 2014, James Madison University (JMU) Libraries created the Alternative Summer Break Academic Library Internship (ASB). There is no LIS graduate program in Virginia. Geographically, the closest to JMU, which is located in Harrisonburg, Virginia, are Catholic University and University of Maryland. This means that our out-of-the-way academic library does not have a history of working with library school students. Conceived of as an ethically-based program in response to unpaid LIS internships, ASB provides a stipend and on-campus housing to a current or recently graduated LIS graduate student for six weeks. Interns are hired at the university rank of "instructional faculty nonteaching" and work with libraries faculty and staff to tailor a project according to their career and education goals. As part of the program, these graduate interns conduct informational interviews, attend faculty meetings and job talks, and present a scholarly talk about their project during the last week of their internship. ASB also provides JMU faculty and staff with supervisory and mentorship experience.

This chapter will present a case study that reveals how this ethical approach to the ASB program has unfolded after four iterations (2016–2019) and what serious work remains to be done. In addition to describing in full the components of the program, this essay will highlight scholarly collaborations between ASB committee members and interns. It will also acknowledge areas where the ASB program needs improvement. For example, budget constraints have prevented higher pay and a cohort model. Other concerns include a lack of diversity among interns and summertime scheduling when there is a lack of university activity and faculty presence on campus.

The Beginnings of the Alternative Summer Break Program

The impetus for ASB grew out of conversations over the course of several months in 2013 and 2014 between several JMU librarians, among them a former director of collections, a former associate dean, and a humanities librarian. These discussions focused on the best internship experiences they had as they pursued professional careers within academic librarianship and the strengths that united those experiences. They identified four core qualities: (1) interesting, high-level projects; (2) meetings with staff across many sectors of the host organization; (3) being treated as equals despite their relative lack of experience in the field; and (4) the duration of the internship being long enough to complete a long-term project but not so long that it necessitated uprooting one's life to complete it. Recognizing that JMU Libraries, based in a fairly rural part of Virginia, did not have a library and information science program and that the nearest ones were a two-and-a-half-hour drive away, they felt that hosting such a program would be beneficial to the organization; the innovations within the JMU Libraries and its

educational technology units would also offer interns a one-of-a-kind perspective. They also recognized that to make it worth a prospective intern's time to travel all the way to rural Virginia for such an experience, the internship should provide a stipend and free housing.

Therefore, when a grant program with the JMU Libraries endowment fund was instituted in 2014, these librarians proposed the idea for the Alternative Summer Break Academic Library Internship. Soon after the grant application was successfully approved, a job ad was placed with the intention of recruiting the first ASB intern for the summer of 2015. However, it did not go as planned. That first cycle was riddled with problems. The ad went out too late. Once the ad was out, similar university library internship programs also had ads out, limiting the ASB's applicant pool. Additionally, the building that housed students during the summer at JMU was being razed (as another new building was being constructed). When first offers were made, housing could not be provided, though money was offered to prospective interns to find their own housing during the internship. This was ultimately the undoing of the initial year of the ASB program, as each prospective intern cited the lack of housing as the reason why they chose not to accept the offer.

After failing to hire an intern for the summer of 2015, the ASB committee had an entire year to plan to hire an intern for the following summer. The full year of planning had the benefit of learning lessons from the failure of the first search, including the following:

- Begin planning for the following year as soon as possible.
- Ensure funding is (still) available.
- Secure on-campus housing as soon as possible.
- Place a job ad and conduct phone interviews with candidates much earlier in the calendar year.
- Solicit libraries faculty and staff for long-term projects as soon as possible.

Once these objectives were met, the committee began circulating a job ad in late January 2016. After a greater number of applications were received, phone interviews began in March. Following the interviews, we successfully recruited our first intern, a graduate student from the University of Michigan's School of Information.

Ethical Foundations of ASB

The role of interns in the workplace used to be unclear. During the time when the ASB program was being conceived, the exploitative practice of unpaid internships *finally* began receiving attention in the mainstream press. In a 2012 piece for *The Atlantic*, business writer Derek Thompson asks, "If unpaid internships are the key to better jobs and bigger salaries, should we be concerned about the millions of lower-class students who can't afford to work for free?"[1] Laura Franta-Abdalla, writer for the online magazine *Mic* in 2014, points out several

reasons why unpaid internships are bad, most notably that they "are shaped by privilege," offer "no protection against harassment or discrimination," and are often "actually ILLEGAL."[2] The same concerns are also expressed by Madeleine Schwartz in a 2013 piece for *Dissent*: "The intern's obscurity and uncertainty characterize a labor force that has grown more contingent, relying on part-time, unstable, and insecure work."[3] Even *Forbes*, the generally pro-business magazine, featured a 2014 article by Rachel Burger, "Why Your Unpaid Internship Makes You Less Employable," in which she points out, "Those with unpaid internships tended to take lower-paying jobs than those with no internship experience whatsoever ($35,721 and $37,087, respectively). Students with paid internships far outpaced their peers with an average $51,930 salary."[4]

While the diminished earning power of unpaid internships is a definite drawback, the underlying exploitative nature of them—disproportionately affecting women, LGBTQ+, and BIPOC interns as well as those on the lower end of socioeconomic spectrum and first-generation college (and graduate) students—is the main reason they should be avoided at all costs. As Angela Galvan astutely notes, "Only students with access to money can afford to take an unpaid internship. Galleries, libraries, archives, and museums throughout the United States continue exploiting unpaid labor, [ensuring] the pool of well-qualified academic librarians skews white and middle class."[5] These conversations, marking a shift in the post–Great Recession employment landscape, led to the philosophy that paid internships are not only vital but also a social justice practice within the strictures of late capitalism. These conceptualizations were the bases of setting up and operating the ASB program described in this chapter.

Logistics

Prior to the inaugural internship in June 2016, the ASB committee had to clear numerous hurdles to ensure a smooth, functional, and rewarding six-week experience. The biggest lesson from the scholarship on internships was housing for interns. A collaboration with JMU Conference Services made it possible to secure a room with the grant-allocated funds.

The job ads and hiring process concerned ethics of inclusion and diversity. The committee met with the human resources (HR) coordinator to review ethics in the interview and hiring process, from placing the job ad to screening applications, conducting phone interviews, making an offer to a candidate, and closing out the search once the offer has been accepted. This process included regular training on diversity, inclusion, and access for equal employment opportunity as part of institutional human resources recruitment. This process followed the same hiring and onboarding procedures used for hiring full-time or part-time instructors at the university. One ethical consideration was the resources and opportunities available to the prospective interns at their LIS program. For instance, whether

we should pick the most qualified applicant or a promising one (sometimes both at once) who may not have access to professional, academic-level library work experience in their program reflected our ethical evaluation in the process.

It was vitally important for ASB that potential projects would assist one of the libraries units *and address the needs of our intern*. This was to ensure the equity of professional respect to the intern, which is closely associated with the value of an intern's learning experience in a real job setting in an academic library. For example, our first intern worked with Special Collections to migrate archival metadata to ArchivesSpace. The project was initially to focus on oral history transcription, but was reprioritized when the intern's needs and goals were taken into account. This established a precedent for ASB that allowed interns to have significant input into shaping their projects and internship experiences.

To provide a seamless onboarding experience for the ASB intern, we also learned that other factors needed to be considered. These related to human resources procedures, employee ID, access to physical and virtual spaces, and more. The committee found that completing tasks such as the following prior to the intern's arrival to campus ensured more efficient use of time for the six-week internship and removed unnecessary barriers for the intern to be fully immersed in the academic library settings:

- Information about the campus and surrounding community, including options for dining, recreation, and local areas of interest.
- JMU e-ID for email and other institutional accounts. Starting this process early, if possible, ensures there is not a delay in accessing campus systems.
- JMU identification card for access to libraries workspaces and other campus buildings.
- Keys to appropriate workspaces.
- Office workspace including appropriate furniture and a JMU-owned computer on which the main work of the project can be accomplished.
- Packing list based on what is and is not provided by on campus housing (e.g., JMU Conference Services provides a linen service for a nominal fee that is included in the ASB budget).
- Parking pass.
- Proper payroll classification to ensure intern gets paid in a timely manner and secures faculty status for the duration of the internship.

Having all of these things in place is of vital importance to facilitate a positive, productive, respecting and being respected, and less stressful internship experience.

Structure

The ASB was conceived as a full-time experience consisting of 200 hours of paid work ($10 per hour) over a period of six weeks during the summer. The

majority of the internship, 160 hours, was focused on a major project, like the one mentioned in the previous section, chosen in consultation with the intern prior to beginning the internship. The remaining forty hours were devoted to professional development activities that sought to immerse the intern into the organizational culture of the libraries and university as well as help them pursue further interests aligned with their LIS studies. These activities included approximately twenty informational interviews with faculty and staff from across numerous units within the libraries, attendance at faculty meetings, and attendance at job search presentations. Interns prepared for informational interviews ahead of time and were encouraged to use these opportunities to ask questions about the profession and others' perspectives on their own career paths in libraries and academia. Interns were also asked to give a presentation to the libraries during the final week of their internship. In these presentations, interns provided an overview of their project and major accomplishments, discussed highlights of their learning from the professional development activities, and answered questions from libraries faculty and staff in attendance.

As the ASB internship program has developed, roles and responsibilities have been shaped related to its effective and ongoing administration within the organization. The following list represents the core individuals associated with running the six-week internship each year. This does not include natural collaborators such as human resources, accounts payable, facilities, and others that must be included in decision-making for new hires, on-campus housing, and such.

- *Coordinating committee.* Oversees overall timeline of the internship and ensures deadlines are met. Coordinates recruiting, hiring, and onboarding processes including securing on-campus housing. Conducts onboarding and exit interviews with interns.
- *Intern.* Completes 200 total hours of internship over six weeks. One hundred sixty hours are devoted to a major project selected in consultation with the coordinating committee, and the remaining forty hours are spent completing professional development activities.
- *Internship mentor.* Coordinates forty hours of professional development activities in consultation with intern. Meets regularly with intern throughout the six weeks to check in on how the experience is going and provides assistance as needed. Coordinates with intern's home institution for internship credit as applicable.
- *Project supervisor.* Supervises intern in 160 hours of professional work in the supervisor's area of expertise. Consults with internship mentor on progress.

We learned early on that focusing on one higher-level project sustained over the course of the six weeks was beneficial to the intern and proved to be a natural way to immerse them as professional colleagues into the organizational culture

of a particular department and working team. Projects are intentionally rotated through libraries units (including Academic Engagement, Innovation Services, and Scholarly Resources and Technology) in order to vary the types of experiences offered with ASB as well as to involve a variety of faculty and staff in the program and provide supervision and mentorship experiences for employees. Major ASB projects have included creating online learning materials for first-year students, creating online learning and promotional materials for makerspaces, and creating and editing metadata for a collection of Black comic books held in Special Collections. These are outlined in further detail below.

ASB Projects

The following examples highlight major projects that ASB interns have worked on and the libraries departments that have hosted them. The first ASB intern in 2016 worked with Special Collections to implement the ArchivesSpace information management system. This involved migrating EAD records from a legacy system and using Python scripts to normalize metadata. This intern said the "experience prepared me to work in another academic library in Virginia."[6]

In 2017, the intern worked with liaison librarians in Research and Education Services to create a learning module for a personal wellness course to teach students how to evaluate online health information. The intern also contributed to research with a JMU librarian and created a video about digital object identifiers (DOIs) for the campus community. These resources are still in use by JMU Libraries.

In 2018, the intern worked with the libraries' makerspaces. The libraries support creative lab spaces across the JMU campus. The intern created and edited LibGuides and other instructional materials for the makerspaces and also helped develop programming for students and faculty in these spaces.

In 2019, the internship was overseen by a project team representing several areas of the libraries. The intern cataloged a Black comic book collection held in JMU Special Collections.[7] This included adding and editing holdings on a custom-built Omeka site, searching LC name authorities for content creators, handling the physical comics, and working closely with the humanities librarian and director of metadata strategies on descriptive metadata and related collection decisions. The intern noted, "Perhaps the biggest thing I've gained from this internship is the knowledge that I want to work in an academic or research library or institution."[8]

Scholarly Collaboration

Another intentional component of ASB is to collaborate with current and past interns on scholarly work that can help boost their early careers, especially if

they wish to continue working in academic libraries. After the third iteration, all previous ASB committee members, interns, and project leaders collaborated on a poster about the internship program, which was presented at the 2019 ACRL Conference in Cleveland, Ohio.[9] Additionally, the fourth intern collaborated with her project leader and one of the authors of this chapter to have an essay about their project accepted for publication in a forthcoming issue of the *Journal of Graphic Novels and Comics*.[10] This type of work shows the ASB committee's as well as the libraries' commitment to the interns as emerging professionals and peers in the field and serves to build their network of connections as they continue to professionalize.

Professional Experience for Faculty and Staff

ASB has provided leadership, mentorship, and managerial experience for libraries faculty and staff who have participated in the program. This is an added ethical consideration of the program, that is, mentoring and collaborating with a novice colleague (who might not become a long-term colleague) with equity considerations for engagement opportunities across all libraries employee classifications. For example, not all the coordinating committee members had previous supervision experience within the libraries. Managing the intern's professional development schedule, developing project workflows, problem solving, and conducting weekly meetings with interns provided on-the-job training for these acting supervisors. Additionally, many faculty and staff across the libraries participated in the intern's professional development activities, most notably in one-on-one informational interviews. These are beneficial to the intern, but also provide an opportunity for libraries staff to practice inclusive mentorship and thoughtfully engage with their own professional career paths.

While ASB is primarily focused on making sure interns learn on-the-job skills from the library's faculty and staff, one of the great things about it is that faculty and staff also learn from the interns. Workplace-based learning helps students develop practical skills for completing functional projects and nurtures soft skills when they collaborate with professional librarians in academic libraries. Depending on the project, interns may also have interdisciplinary experience. Furthermore, through programs like ASB, library faculty and staff can learn along with interns while the interns apply the knowledge they are gaining in their LIS curricula. For example, in Lynda Holyoak's qualitative study, she found that mentoring and supervision support was critical to interns' learning satisfaction.[11] Maggie Gallup Kopp also argues that effective LIS internship programs should be well designed with curriculum-oriented assignments and assessment measures, and in alignment with "high-impact practices," which and in alignment with

> 1) are effortful; 2) help students build substantive relationships; 3) help students engage across differences; 4) provide students with rich feedback; 5) help students apply and test what they are learning in new situations; and 6) provide opportunities for students to reflect on the people they are becoming.[12]

ASB, through a combination of project-based learning, collaborative scholarship, and advocacy by libraries faculty and staff on behalf of the interns, realized or approximated these high-impact practices to ideally benefit those who participated.

New Direction for ASB

During the middle of the last iteration of the ASB, a new dean began working at JMU Libraries. One of her goals for her first year was to "Actively explore funding possibilities and best practices for instituting a residency program meant to welcome and support new librarians and library staff of color or members of other under-represented groups."[13] When the dean learned about ASB, she proposed some ambitious new goals for the program, from increasing the number of interns from one to two or three to connecting it to JMU's Furious Flower Poetry Center, the first academic center for Black poetry in the United States, and to JMU Libraries' Andrew W. Mellon Foundation Grant "*Furious Flowerings: Developing a Partnership Model for Digital Library Support of a Living Center for Black Poetry*."[14] Given the need for increased funding to support up to three interns, scaling up ASB from a one-intern model, orchestrating the logistics of such a transition, determining what projects interns could be involved with to serve both the libraries and the Furious Flower Poetry Center, and coordinating with new potential partners from the libraries' Council on Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion, it was decided to put ASB on pause for summer 2020. This pause provided the ASB committee with a chance to reflect on past successes but also to reassess ASB's ethical foundations and identify areas of improvement.

Ethical Reconsiderations

When looking back at the ethical foundations that guided the first four years of ASB, four major areas of improvement were identified to be addressed:

- better compensating our interns
- making a stronger structural commitment to hiring librarians of color
- transitioning the internship to a cohort model
- reconsidering when the internship can take place

While no internship experience is perfect, moving forward, paying attention to these four ethical considerations will make ASB more beneficial to the interns, to the libraries, and to the profession.

Compensation for our interns remains a primary concern. Given the initial budget for the internship (approximately $4,000 for room and board and a stipend), the intern was to make approximately $10 per hour over the course of their six-week experience (or $2,000 for 200 hours of work). The per-hour pay was similar to what graduate assistants were making at the time, and the amount was marginally higher than Virginia's minimum wage ($7.25 per hour). Prior to the first iteration of ASB, Chen and Shen, in a 2012 article, studied the perception of internships by students from twenty universities. Although in a different disciplinary area (hospitality management), the statistics prediction model of using structural equation modeling (SEM) and a reliable instrument did disclose that interns were concerned about compensation according to legal stipulations, reasonable compensation, and compensation comparable to faculty.[15] However, after four years of ASB, we were unable to offer higher pay. Given the nationwide move by states to increase their minimum wages to anywhere from $15 to $20 per hour, the original $10 per hour rate appears both exploitative and uncompetitive by comparison. A revised version of the internship program must strive to pay the intern much more than the current hourly rate. This may be achieved through funding from sources like external donors who are looking for impact on LIS graduate curriculum, or grants for projects related to diversity, equity, and inclusion.

In planning for future internship programs in academic libraries, considerations can include *purposeful* job ad distribution to underrepresented ethnic groups as well as connections through faculty from underrepresented ethnic groups. Librarianship, in general, is a fairly homogenized profession; academic librarianship is even more homogenous. According to a study by the AFL-CIO, 79 percent of all librarians are female. The report also notes, "The librarian profession suffers from a persistent lack of racial and ethnic diversity that shows few signs of abating," with 77 percent of all librarians identifying as white.[16] The numbers are even more stark in academic librarianship. Hui-Fen Chang's oft-cited study shows that, as of 2012, 86 percent of academic librarians identify as white, compared to 1981, when that number was 90 percent, suggesting that in the last forty years, not much has changed.[17] Compared to the demographic shifts in the United States' population over that period of time, the relative stagnation of these numbers is deplorable. Of our four interns, each identified as female, and only one identified as a person of color. The recruitment of interns from diverse cultural backgrounds can lead to stronger bonds between underrepresented students, faculty, and staff when they visit the libraries. As Jaeger, Subramaniam, Jones, and Bertot explain, "Admitting more diverse MLS students will not work

if people from underserved, disadvantaged, and underrepresented groups do not see people like themselves among library professionals and LIS program faculty, staff, and students."[18] These efforts can also help with efforts to decolonize collections and cataloging systems, which tend to privilege Anglo-European, Judeo-Christian, straight, male, cisgender content that has been long entrenched in libraries, content clearly unreflective of the country's shifting demographics.

To date, ASB has had only one intern at a time during each of its six-week iterations, as the funding and logistics enabled the initial implementation.[19] From adult learning perspectives, a cohort model will provide community and peer support that come from a similar and shared background and context.[20] With the individual knowledge bases and developed perspectives of the interns interacting in a professional working environment, self-directed learning will be optimized in the context of work-based learning and learning-based work. This social capital can be mobilized through a cohort model. As the authors of *Developing a Residency Program: A Practical Guide for Librarians* point out, "A possible benefit to cohort groups is shared experience and sense of community, where residents learn, work, and grow professionally together."[21] As academic libraries transition into more integrative innovation and exert more influence in teaching, research, and community-based practice across the university, gaining capacity through co-constructive projects is a direction that can draw from the strength of ideas such as social constructivism.[22] Transitioning the internship to a cohort model will draw from the benefits of social constructivism and communities of practice with a group of individuals of similar experience and educational background in library science.[23] These peers, along with mentors and workplace colleagues, will form a community of collective inquiry when working together on a project. This was also a lesson learned from the last iteration of ASB involving the creation of metadata for the Black comic book collection.

Something else to consider is the variable of time. While summer (which is reflected in the name of the program) is a great time for the libraries to catch up on projects because fewer students are on campus, this time of year can also create a conundrum. Summer makes it challenging for ASB projects to intersect with areas of interest such as public services or in-class instruction. While it is easier for project managers to lead a project while not also caught in the throes of the fall and spring semesters, summertime does limit the opportunities available to interns with interests in these areas. Reconsidering when the internship can take place may help to achieve curriculum-related goals as well as bolster the experiential learning aspects of the internships.[24]

Conclusion

JMU's Alternative Summer Break Academic Library Internship began as an idea for connecting LIS graduate students with positive, productive work experiences

in an academic library where they would be treated as colleagues and develop professional relationships with their peers. Over time, ASB developed its model to more closely align project and professional development outcomes with the goals and career aspirations of prospective interns. Four interns have successfully completed ASB to date, and all of them continue to work in LIS fields, citing the internship as a foundational experience in their graduate studies and preparation for entering the job market. For example, one former intern says, "I've been able to bring the skills and the open mind I gained at JMU to my current position," while another exclaims, "Every experience from my internship has proved useful."[25] ASB has proved to be a positive experience for interns, librarians, and others involved in the program since its inception, and connections have continued beyond internships through continued scholarly collaboration, job references, and similar professional networking. Many areas of the program can and should be improved, and it is our hope that exploring these areas in the future will continue to frame ASB in an ethical perspective and ground our internships with meaning and purpose.

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CHAPTER 2

In Their Own Words

Scholars and Coordinators Reflect on the Oregon State University Libraries' Diversity Scholars Program

Marisol Moreno Ortiz, Bridgette Flamenco, Valeria Dávila, Natalia Fernández, and Beth Filar Williams

Designing successful graduate student experiences in academic libraries can take many approaches. Our Diversity Scholars Program (DSP) within the Oregon State University Libraries (OSUL), offers MLIS graduate students of color a nine-month part-time position, salaried with full benefits, that can be renewed for a second appointment.[1] The OSUL established a DSP Committee in 2015 to research and develop the program, hiring our first Scholar in 2018.[2] The DSP incorporates key themes that help ensure graduate student success, including mentorship, funded professional development, and opportunities to apply MLIS theory to praxis.[3] The DSP is structured so Diversity Scholars have meaningful work experiences because they have

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the agency to develop projects of their choice. They begin the program by rotating through every unit of the library in order to understand the full ecosystem of an academic library. To support career-preparedness for work in an academic environment, we make sure they have scholarship, service, and professional development opportunities. The DSP Committee helps Diversity Scholars navigate workplace dynamics, and the program offers a flexible work schedule to enable the balance of work responsibilities with coursework and life experiences.

The Diversity Scholars are expected to engage in the primary assignment duties of an academic librarian. As examples, the Scholars have worked with students in the library's undergraduate research and writing studio, taught library information sessions and workshops, tabled at campus and community events, worked the reference desk and online chat, compiled and analyzed library data, and participated in library-wide as well as relevant departmental meetings. As a part of developing their scholarship, the Scholars have attended and presented at local and national conferences and even one international conference. They have also served on a variety of library committees such as search committees, the Library Awards Committee, and the Library Employee Association. We make sure the Scholars know that their MLIS studies come first, and they are strongly encouraged to use their work experiences for class projects. Offering a flexible work schedule so they can best manage their time is a must. Scholars are given the opportunity to experience the full scope of an academic library, working in all of our departments and meeting with administrators. They are then able to determine their areas of focus. The flexibility in the schedule of their appointment timeline, as well as their weekly schedule, allows for support when and how they need it. Additionally, the DSP Committee mentors Scholars through the job search process.

Our chapter features the voices and perspectives of the program's first three Diversity Scholars, as well as the program managers, in order to provide a full story of the DSP. Each Scholar focuses on specific aspects of the program and how it impacts them: Marisol Moreno Ortiz discusses the overall structure of the program, including the pay, flexible schedule, and benefits; Bridgette Flamenco shares her thoughts on the professional development and mentorship opportunities offered, especially for her job search process; and Valeria Dávila reflects upon how the program is shaped to specifically cater to Scholars' career goals while also providing a well-rounded academic library experience. Beth Filar Williams and Natalia Fernández, DSP Committee members and program managers, share their recommendations on developing and managing a program like the DSP.

Marisol Moreno Ortiz

OSU Libraries Diversity Scholar

January 2018–June 2019

My name is Marisol Moreno Ortiz, and I like it when people call me Mari. I am the youngest of three daughters, and I was born in Mexico. I moved with my family to Oregon in 2000. As the first one in my family to go to college, I worked hard to earn my bachelor of arts in English from Oregon State University in 2014, my master of arts in English from Portland State University in 2016, and my master of library and information science from Louisiana State University in 2019. Throughout my time in academia, I learned that word of mouth is a powerful thing, something that the DSP utilized in spreading the news of the program being developed. This is how knowledge of the program reached my ears through a conversation on an early morning in 2017 with one of my past OSU advisors. I had returned to OSU to do a term of service through AmeriCorps, as I was finishing my master of arts in English degree, and I had decided to take a year off before starting my MLIS program the next fall. Learning about the DSP got me very excited, and I could not wait to contact them to express my interest in the program. The email that I sent to the program to learn about the application process began my journey into becoming the first OSUL Diversity Scholar.

When my appointment as the first Diversity Scholar began in January 2018, I was just beginning my second semester of my MLIS program. My knowledge about librarianship was limited, and I needed a program that supplemented my online coursework, which the DSP did. Within my MLIS program, I had the control of what courses I wanted to take each semester. The DSP was similar in that I had the flexibility to decide what I wanted to learn and what departments in which to work. The DSP Committee also helped me to structure a work schedule that fit with my courses and bus schedules as I would be commuting to the library since I don't drive. I decided to work in the mornings to midafternoon, as this would allow me to get home and do some coursework for the day. I also did some of my coursework reading during the commute to and from the library. Being a Diversity Scholar meant working in a part-time position for twenty hours a week, with the agency to choose what days of the week I wanted to work. This flexibility helped me structure a schedule where I had a three-day weekend to focus on coursework, which in turn helped me balance my responsibilities and have a manageable stress level. This established a strong foundation for my first year, and it made me feel that I had control of my learning.

The structure of the first term of the program included a lot of onboarding to establish that strong foundation, as well as giving me time to decide on which areas of OSUL I wanted to focus as part of my position. Along with

my MLIS coursework, I aligned my library experiential learning to include book mending, cataloging, literacy instruction, circulation, and reference. These areas of librarianship were the areas that matched my temperament and goals. I spent each term working on projects, as well as attending conferences, including presenting at an international conference, with the professional development funds provided by the program, opportunities similar to those of the full-time permanent librarians. Another important element of the program that was very valuable to me was the weekly meetings scheduled between me and the chair of the DSP Committee, my supervisor, as a check-in of how the previous week went. This was also a time where I had the opportunity to ask for any assistance that I might have needed. Having this weekly meeting really helped to incorporate the DSP Committee as part of my support team and not a separate entity.

During this time, I was fortunate to still live at home and received a graduate tuition award from my MLIS program that covered tuition and out-of-state fees. This and the stipend provided by DSP was enough for me to provide some rent and grocery money to my parents and successfully complete my DSP appointment. The stipend also helped me pay for the internet I needed to do my MLIS program, lunch money during DSP work, textbooks, and spending money when traveling for conferences. Other Diversity Scholars who do not receive extra assistance from their program or external scholarships may need to work another part-time job to supplement the DSP stipend. Even though the program didn't provide a big stipend, it did provide a health plan that matched the health plan given to other OSU graduate teaching assistants. The program covered medical, vision, and dental with only a small co-pay. For me, the health plan provided was extremely beneficial as it provided me with the opportunity to finally take sessions with a psychologist who specializes in anxiety disorders since, at the time I began my appointment in DSP, I was struggling with my obsessive-compulsive disorder. I also used some of my stipend money for transportation to attend my treatment appointments. The stipend is not much, but along with the other benefits of the program, like its professional development budget, I didn't mind it. My goal going into the Diversity Scholar Program was not to make money but to get the experience and increase my knowledge to be much more prepared to apply for library positions after finishing my MLIS, which the program indeed helped me accomplish through experiential learning and increasing my confidence by helping me develop my academic librarian identity.

Bridgette Flamenco

OSU Libraries Diversity Scholar

October 2018–March 2020

My name is Bridgette Flamenco, and I'm a first-generation Mexican American who grew up in Los Angeles, California. I am currently enrolled in San José State University's master of library and information science program; I started my first semester in August of 2018. I have always had an interest in serving diverse and underrepresented communities, and I applied to the Diversity Scholars Program because I wanted to work and learn in an environment that engaged in creating a diverse and inclusive library sciences field.

During my DSP appointment, I engaged in a multitude of professional development opportunities that allowed me to travel, network, and identify areas of interest within my professional career. As a master's degree student with limited funds, I never dreamed that I would have the opportunity to travel as much as I did during this program. During my eighteen-month appointment, I was able to attend conferences both regionally and nationally. These included presenting on the DSP at the 2019 Oregon Library Association-Washington Library Association conference in Vancouver, Washington; attending the 2019 American Library Association (ALA) annual conference in Washington, DC; presenting at the 2019 Association of College and Research Libraries (ACRL) WA/OR Joint Conference in Eatonville, Washington; and attending the 2020 ALA Midwinter Conference in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. Sprinkled in between these conferences were workshops and seminars, which all served to expand my understanding of how librarians can work to better the lives of their academic communities and also increased my knowledge and interest in instruction and outreach. I am particularly fond of the 2019 ACRL WA-OR Joint Fall Conference "Whiteness and Racism in Academic Libraries: Dismantling Structures of Oppression," wherein I was accepted to give a presentation. The conference was focused on openly acknowledging the ways that whiteness and racism are supported in libraries and strategies for practicing anti-racism across the breadth of our work. My presentation focused on the work I had been doing with OSU's underrepresented Latinx students and their diverse information needs and cultural perspectives. The presentation advocated the need for diverse academic librarians to create connections with diverse students and their families in order to increase the library's overall approachability. It also touched upon how diversity residencies such as the DSP can help make this possible. This presentation allowed me to integrate my MLIS coursework to better understand and reflect on the importance of the work I was doing at OSU while also networking with professionals who shared similar interests.

There was a real focus within the DSP to create opportunities for me to gain as much experience as possible within an academic library. I was encouraged to look at the type of work I wanted to do within academic librarianship, and once I decided that I wanted to focus my career on conducting library instruction and outreach services, I was offered opportunities to conduct that type of work throughout my appointment. Having worked entry-level jobs most of my life, it was a welcomed change to work at a more professional level within this program and have the duties and service responsibilities that would be expected of an academic librarian. The types of duties that came from the DSP consisted of leading data analysis presentations, serving on library hiring committees, conducting library and information literacy instruction, and tabling outreach events in order to promote library services. I had opportunities to join departmental meetings and administration briefings that allowed me to better understand the inner workings of such a large institutional organization regarding budget spending, strategic planning, and so forth. Throughout these experiences, I also learned how to communicate and collaborate with colleagues using various office software (Outlook, Slack, Google Docs), which I did not have experience using in a professional setting. These experiences allowed me to understand the work environment, culture, and etiquette within an academic institution and helped prepare me to work in an academic work environment in the future. Overall, the myriad of professional development opportunities that I was able to participate in helped to solidify my interest in becoming an academic librarian and in working with diverse and underrepresented communities, specifically in the realm of instruction and outreach.

Ultimately, the benefits of the opportunities afforded to me during the DSP came through when the DSP Committee asked me to create cover letters and résumés for actual outreach and instruction librarian positions within academic libraries. As I looked at the position descriptions of academic librarian positions, I found myself comfortable with meeting the requirements and qualifications for these positions. Additionally, I was able to attain letters of recommendation from colleagues with whom I worked with throughout my appointment. I then met with the DSP Committee to receive advice and feedback on my résumé and cover letter. While I found myself being able to meet the desired experiences for many of these positions, the insight gained from the DSP Committee allowed me to understand what employers are looking for in job applications and in interviews. Consequently, I feel confident in applying for such positions once I attain my MLIS, a confidence I don't think would exist without the help of the DSP.

While the DSP offered me exciting and interesting professional opportunities, I must say that at first, I felt inadequate in my ability to perform such responsibilities. My previous library experience was based mostly on circulation and shelving, and these new duties were out of the realm of the backroom work I had

normally done. In truth, I was somewhat inexperienced, but the whole point of the DSP was to afford me the types of opportunities that were out of my realm of experience and comfort so that I could grow into a well-rounded academic librarian. More so, as I tried out different aspects of academic librarianship, from cataloging to public services, I always found that my fellow colleagues were not only helpful but excited to advise me and offer me opportunities to grow. Whether they offered me the opportunity to teach a reference manager workshop or took the time to teach me how to use LibGuides, being mentored by such compassionate and experienced individuals made it easy to step out of my comfort zone throughout my DSP appointment. Even as my appointment came to an end, I found many of my colleagues wishing me the best, exchanging contact information with me, and offering to write letters of recommendation. Having such a supportive network of fantastic and caring individuals certainly made it hard to leave, but it also eased my mind as I know I can come to them with questions or ask for advice as I take the next step in my journey toward becoming an academic librarian.

Valeria Dávila

OSU Libraries Diversity Scholar

October 2019–June 2021

My name is Valeria Dávila, and I am from Argentina. My journey in LIS began at OSUL after moving to Oregon in mid-2016. Having no prior experience at libraries but a professional background in photography, film, and digital film restoration, and an interest in archives, I worked almost two years at the Special Collections and Archives Research Center (SCARC), a department within the OSUL, digitizing photographic and paper materials for access and digital preservation. After defending my thesis in 2018 and earning my bachelor of arts in film at Fundación Universidad del Cine, I decided to pursue an MLS-archives degree. Because I had limited financial means, being appointed as a Diversity Scholar at OSUL before starting my program in fall 2019 was instrumental to my decision.

Having recently completed my first nine months in the DSP, what I love most about the program is its focus on helping Scholars explore and develop their areas of interest, made possible by a DSP Committee that cares and is invested in providing all kinds of valuable opportunities. In my case, being not only the first foreign Scholar in the DSP, but also the first with a preexisting interest in archives—most particularly, audiovisual archives—I find this aspect incredibly supportive and beneficial to my professional development.

During my first nine months, I attended the 2019 Association of Moving Image Archivists (AMIA) Conference for the first time, where I connected with professionals in the field from the US and around the globe. This experience

was significant for me at a personal and professional level, as friendships and collaborations that I value started there. Besides attending AMIA, I was able to improve my audiovisual archiving skills by helping preserve audiovisual materials at SCARC. I had helped preserve a collection of films at SCARC prior to my DSP position, and having continuity in this sense was key. The opportunity for working with such materials came early in 2020, as the library moved collections originally housed at an external facility to a considerably smaller location. Urged by these circumstances, SCARC began to reevaluate the size of certain collections. I was then charged with reassessing a myriad of film elements from the OSU-produced documentary *Farmers of the Sea* (1984) from the Oregon Sea Grant Communications Moving Images Collection to determine which elements were to be kept and which deselected. Involving a kind of responsibility I had never had before, the challenge of this task attracted me because it provided an opportunity for personal and professional growth.

Besides my interests in audiovisual preservation and archiving, as a Latina, I intend to serve underrepresented and especially migrant and Spanish-speaking communities. In this aspect too, the DSP offered opportunities from the start. In October 2019, I tabled at the Noche de Alma Latinoamericana event to share information about the OSUL's Corvallis campus library with the Spanish-speaking community in Corvallis. Soon thereafter, the opportunity emerged to contribute to a collection development initiative at the Guin Library, an OSUL branch in Newport specializing in marine science. Guin's director, Mary Markland, sought to add books in languages other than English to the marine-themed children's book collection at Guin to better reflect and serve the local community, but Spanish books with such characteristics were scarce. I was traveling to the International Book Fair (FIL) in Guadalajara, México, at the time—the largest Spanish book fair in the Americas to date—with the REFORMA Oregon program Libros for Oregon, and I took advantage of the trip to acquire books for Guin at FIL that were hard to get in the US. This collaboration brought me endless joy and holds a special place in my heart.

Most recently, moving to remote work mid-March amid the COVID-19 outbreak, I had time to work on projects that expanded my options for serving Spanish-speaking communities that I would not normally do in the context of the DSP, projects such as translating video presentations of the fourth edition of the No Time to Wait Symposium to Spanish, in an attempt to help make their content on open access, standardization, and audiovisual preservation available to Spanish-speaking audiences around the world. Furthermore, this summer I will be collaborating in a bilingual Spanish-English oral histories project with OSUL Oregon Multicultural Archives (OMA), a project I am very excited about.

In addition to advancing my specific career interests in the DSP, I also gained a holistic understanding of academic librarianship. Teamwork and collaboration

are strong components in every workspace and especially in academic librarianship, and this program provided me with plenty of opportunities for both. I gained this understanding by not only serving on committees and participating in cross-departmental meetings, but also by having time to meet with colleagues to discuss their work and role within the library's larger environment, as well as by collaborating with them in projects such as a mass book deselection coordinated by the Resource Acquisition and Sharing Department. Participating in this project helped me explore this fascinating and controversial aspect of collection management I was eager to learn more about.

All these wonderful opportunities—some sought after, some circumstantial, some totally unexpected—emerged within these first nine months only, and I am looking forward to what other opportunities my remaining time with the DSP will bring!

Beth Filar Williams and Natalia Fernández

DSP Committee Members

From our experiences developing the DSP, we would like to share our lessons learned to help you in implementing a similar program at your institution:

Examine your library's and institution's commitment. Are you and your library investing in ongoing concrete actions that support equity, diversity, inclusion, and anti-racism? It is essential that this work is integrated into all departments so that the scholars are working in an environment that is truly committed to social justice. Be sure to review the ACRL Diversity Standards for cultural competencies for academic libraries.[4]

Work with human resources. Determine the best fit in terms of classification for the position to ensure that the scholars receive the benefits they deserve, including a salary that reflects the work of a scholar, health benefits, as well as professional development funding.

Consider all possible options. What type of program will work best for your library, especially if funding or buy-in is an issue? For example, consider the options of piloting a short-term version of the program, developing a one-year-only program for a second-year MLIS student, or perhaps creating a remote-only position.

Seek administrative support. Administrative support is critical, as is sustainable funding. Administrators need to commit both fiscally and systematically, prioritizing the program by dedicating their own time and energy as well as strongly encouraging staff to participate.

Find advocates within your library. Have conversations with faculty and staff at all levels of your library to ensure staff capacity and buy-in from all departments. Library staff will be working with the scholars daily. Make sure that your colleagues understand that their positions are not internships; a scholar is to be treated as a colleague.

Seek program partners beyond your library. Determine existing programs on campus, as well as in your community or local area, that could become partners or advocates for your program. Local MLIS programs, those on campus working with undergraduate students of color, and your current and former library student employees can help in this area.

Reflect on what success means for your program. Develop assessment strategies, including feedback from the scholars themselves, from library faculty and staff who work with the scholars, and your own self-reflection, in order to ensure that the program adapts, evolves, and improves.

Do your research. Seek out literature written by scholars of color who have published about developing and structuring effective programs for librarians of color. The 2019 book *Developing_a Residency Program: A Practical Guide for Librarians* is an in-depth guide filled with practical advice that covers the processes to successfully develop, build support for, and structure a program.[5] The book covers recruitment, hiring, onboarding, program assessment, and ideas for post-program support for individuals as they continue their library careers.

Build in an infrastructure. As part of the program, ensure the scholars continue to receive ongoing support even after they have graduated and have begun their careers.

Conclusion

As Anantachai and colleagues state, "Professionals are generally better equipped to grow and to succeed when they have such collegial group environments and networks at their disposal."[6] One of the key outcomes for the DSP is not only to provide Scholars with mentoring during their time in the program but to establish a supportive network as they move on to a professional position. Effective mentorship and a supportive network are keys to retention, for all librarians, but especially critical for librarians of color.[7] As we move forward with our program, we will continue to assess its effectiveness. Currently, we seek feedback to evolve and improve the program experience through methods such as the Scholars' reflective journaling and self-evaluation, feedback from library staff who have worked with them on projects, and the Scholars' presentations or written reports shared with the library at the end of their appointment. Additionally, in order to ensure the program's sustainability, we will not take our existing buy-in from colleagues for granted and will continue to advocate for the program. For now, we will continue to offer one to two positions per academic year. During the

2020–2021 academic year, we hired our fourth Diversity Scholar into a 100 percent remote position. Our long-term goal is to grow a solid cohort, building a strong network for the Diversity Scholars so that, as our Scholars end their time with us, the relationship does not end. We will continue to support them through ongoing mentorship after their DSP experiences and into their careers.

Notes

1. Oregon State University, "Diversity Scholars Program," last modified October 15, 2020, https://guides.library.oregonstate.edu/diversity-scholars-program.
2. For more specific information on the development and implementation of the Diversity Scholars Program, read the article by Natalia Fernández and Beth Filar Williams, "Creating a Library Wide Culture and Environment to Support MLIS Students of Color: The Diversity Scholars Program at Oregon State University Libraries," *In the Library with the Lead Pipe*, June 24, 2020, http://www.inthelibrarywiththeleadpipe.org/2020/diversity-scholars-program.
3. Diversity Scholars are paid a monthly stipend, $1,275 per month (for thirty weeks of work over a nine-month period, totaling 600 hours), which is about $18.80 per hour. (For comparison, minimum wage in Corvallis, Oregon, is $12 per hour as of July 1, 2020.) The position includes health care coverage as well as $2,500 in professional development funds per nine-month appointment. Our university librarian gave us a set amount of funds for the positions using soft money that could be spent at her discretion.
4. American Library Association, "Diversity Standards: Cultural Competency for Academic Libraries (2012)," last modified May 4, 2012, https://www.ala.org/acrl/standards/diversity.
5. Lorelei Rutledge et al., *Developing a Residency Program* Practical Guides for librarians, no. 63 (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2019).
6. Tarida Anantachai et al., "Establishing a Communal Network for Professional Advancement among Librarians of Color," in *Where Are All the Librarians of Color? The Experiences of People of Color in Academia*, ed. Rebecca Hankins and Miguel Juárez (Sacramento, CA: Litwin Books, 2015), 32.
7. Anantachai et al., "Establishing a Communal Network," 50.

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VOICES FROM THE FIELD

Training Future Librarians

Creating Online, Flexible, and Effective Internships and Practicum Experiences for LIS Graduate Students

Jenny Dale, Samantha Harlow, and Amy Harris Houk

What roles should academic libraries play in developing future professionals? As more graduate programs, including library and information science (LIS) programs, are moving online to accommodate nontraditional students and busy schedules, this question becomes even more complex. As of January 2020, forty-two of the sixty-two ALA-accredited LIS programs offer a 100 percent online option;[1] the LIS program at UNC Greensboro (UNCG) is one of these forty-two programs. In response to these changes, the Research, Outreach, and Instruction (ROI) department at UNCG University Libraries has expanded our in-person intern and practicum programs to include new online options. Reviewing literature on designing collaborative and effective intern and practicum programs is useful for librarians when developing a relationship with any LIS department at a university.[2]

The ROI department has a long history of working with UNCG LIS interns. The face-to-face intern program has evolved over time to take a holistic approach to training future library professionals, focusing not only on the skills and knowledge necessary to staff our reference desk but also on the development of broader communication, problem-solving, and teaching skills crucial for our field. More online components have been added to this internship program, including an asynchronous Canvas learning community to house presentations and training materials, as well as streaming and recording face-to-face training through Webex or Zoom when possible for online practicum students and interns with whose schedules conflict with training.

With employers expecting practical experience from recent library school graduates, academic libraries have the opportunity to play a critical role in preparing the next generation of library professionals, even when their graduate programs are fully online. LIS practicums are crucial for future librarians to begin their careers prepared. At UNC Greensboro, the majority of the students enrolled in the program are distance students, so they may not have ready access to a traditional practicum site. To support these stu-

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dents, the UNCG LIS department developed an Alternative Spring Break program where students can spend a week completing an intensive practicum experience. The head of ROI worked with a student interested in working in academic libraries in spring 2019. This practicum enabled the student to meet with librarians from various departments and create an online library tutorial. The student and the head of ROI also presented on the experience at a state conference.

In spring 2020, the UNCG online learning librarian, housed in ROI, created a completely online practicum experience for one LIS distance student. The online learning librarian met with the UNCG information literacy coordinator to discuss how in-person practicums and internships with LIS students geared toward information literacy and academic librarianship are organized in order to explore how they could adapt the practicum to an entirely online format. Based on this feedback and the reading of literature on best practices of working with LIS students, internships, and practicums, a practicum structure was developed that was flexible enough for the online student's schedule, but also met the requirements for course credit for a practicum.

In order to create a successful and individualized practicum focused on online learning and academic libraries with one UNCG LIS student in spring 2020, various synchronous virtual meetings between the student and the online learning librarian were scheduled at the beginning of the semester. Each of these meetings had an agenda on a Google Doc, where the student was a coeditor to access permalinks to readings on academic libraries, as well as various online learning resource hyperlinks. The student also tracked hours on a Google Doc and wrote reflection blog posts in WordPress on the readings and work assigned. This student was working in a public library at the time of the practicum, and they wanted to gain experience creating online learning objects on curriculum design, inclusive online pedagogy, open educational resources (OER), podcasts and makerspaces, and scholarly communication. Based on these initial meetings at the beginning of the semester, one-on-one virtual meetings with a variety of academic librarians across the state were also scheduled with this student: the student success librarian at UNCG, a community college online learning librarian, the English liaison at UNCG, a UNCG LIS professor who specializes in inclusion in makerspaces, and a librarian working at an academic UNCG makerspace. After the student read various academic literature on these specific library topics, the final products of this practicum were agreed upon in partnership: a webinar to UNCG students about getting started with podcasting at home co-led by a librarian in the Digital Media Commons at UNCG, an openly designed syllabus on Victorian literature that was added to the OER Commons repository, and an infographic for students on getting started with OER.

Our experiences adapting traditional face-to-face practicum programs to short-term and online formats have been successful. Being aware of best practices is important, but flexibility and customizability are critical for creating effective programs for students learning online and at a distance.

Notes

1. American Library Association, "Searchable Database of ALA-Accredited Programs," Education and Careers, 2020, http://www.ala.org/educationcareers/accreditedprograms/directory/search.
2. Kayo Denda and Jennifer Hunter, "Building 21st Century Skills and Creating Communities: A Team-Based Engagement Framework for Student Employment in Academic Libraries," *Journal of Library Administration* 56, no. 3 (2016): 251–65, https://doi.org/10.1080/01930826.2015.1121662; Jennifer A. Dixon, "Experience Required," *Library Journal* 143, no. 13 (May 10, 2018): 32–34, https://www.libraryjournal.com/story/experience-required; Tanner D. Lewey and Hannah Moody-Goo, "Management: Designing a Meaningful Reference and Instruction Internship: The MLIS Student Perspective," *Reference and User Services Quarterly* 57, no. 4 (2018): 238–41, https://doi.org/10.5860/rusq.57.4.6699; Jennifer E. Nutefall, "Structuring a Successful Instruction Internship," *College and Undergraduate Libraries* 19, no. 1 (2012): 80–94, https://doi.org/10.1080/10691316.2012.652550; Geraldine Purpur and Jon Levi Morris, "The Learning Outcomes of Mentoring Library Science Students in Virtual World Reference: A Case Study," *Journal of Library and Information Services in Distance Learning* 9, no. 3 (2015): 192–203, https://doi.org/10.1080/1533290X.2015.1044690; Max Eckard, Ashley Rosener, and Lindy Scripps-Hoekstra, "Factors That Increase the Probability of a Successful Academic Library Job Search," *Journal of Academic Librarianship* 40, no. 2 (March 2014): 107–15, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.acalib.2014.02.001.

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CHAPTER 3

Virtual Spaces

Developing Experiential Learning Opportunities for Online Students

Allison Bailund and Christina Miskey

Introduction

There are currently over thirty completely online American Library Association (ALA)– accredited master's degree programs throughout the United States. The makeup of these programs is diverse and often includes students across the country, many looking to change careers and begin working in libraries after jobs in customer service, academia, teaching, and so on. However, their potential lack of physical proximity to an academic library makes it difficult for online students to gain the necessary experience for academic librarian positions. Figure 3.1 shows a map of the United States and the geographic distribution of current ALA-accredited library school programs. As much of the research on the topic shows, "a graduate degree in library or information science is required, but not sufficient, to enter the profession."[1] Many LIS programs and academic libraries have worked to meet this critical need by building experiential learning opportunities into their curriculum, but they are not a requirement of every program.[2] Despite the fact that not every program requires experiential learning, throughout our time in school we heard about the importance of internships, directed fieldwork, and volunteering to gain valuable experience; yet as online students, we have faced difficulties finding suitable opportunities.

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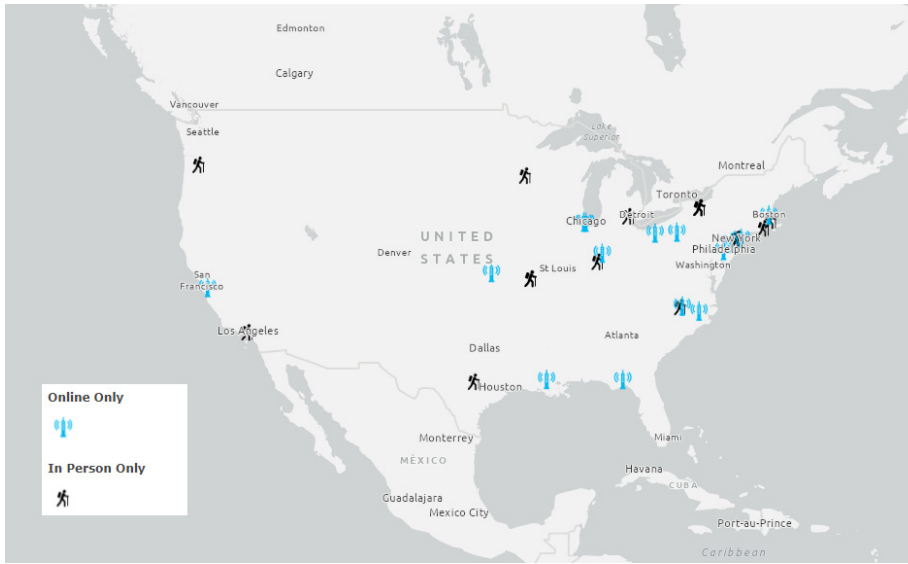


Figure 3.1
ALA-accredited library school programs in the US.

These opportunities can go by many names, including "practicum, internship, work-study, co-op, field experience, and service learning," which reflect "different lengths, formats, and components of practical experiences,"[3] and we may use these terms interchangeably. Experiential learning opportunities for online students provides a mutually beneficial outcome for both the students and the academic libraries that host them. Hands-on experience gives the students an opportunity to grow and experience working in their chosen profession and gives employers a chance to mentor and train the next generation of academic librarians. Institutions without an iSchool or MLIS program can still create these opportunities for local library school students and benefit from their work, insights, and fresh perspectives.

In this chapter, we will highlight some of the current offerings for distance students and include insights from former students, administrators, academic advisors, and librarians on how to make successful programs. We will explore the benefits of experiential learning for distance and online students, along with methods for cost-effective implementation of programs. We will also offer a brief reflection of our own experiences as online students working full-time in nonlibrary environments and the role our experiential learning opportunities played in shaping our career trajectories. Finally, we will examine some of the missteps that institutions have made and offer suggestions for avoiding those same mistakes when developing an experiential learning program at your institution.

Current Opportunities for Online MLIS Students

Opportunities for internships vary across MLIS programs. While some institutions have in-person internships embedded into their curricular programs, such as TALint from the University of Toronto, giving students a way to explore the field, others have developed partnerships with local libraries.[4] The University of Denver and Emporia State University, for example, have both sent students to Auraria Library, an academic library that services three university campuses in Colorado, allowing them to gain experience in reference and instruction.[5] In Southern California, students were able to participate in FILL (From Interns to Library Leaders), helping out in various SCLC (Southern California Library Cooperative) public libraries.[6] Positions are also often posted on library school websites,[7] such as SJSU's (San José State University's) internship page, though many schools, including the University of Washington and the University of Texas at Austin, limit access to their postings to current students. Browsing through the positions posted on the SJSU site in June 2020 shows us that, of the available opportunities, approximately 15 percent are virtual with only a third of those in academic libraries (see figure 3.2).[8] The numbers in October 2020 during the first full academic semester of the COVID-19 pandemic, weren't much better. While virtual opportunities increased, they did so by only 5 percent, with positions in academic libraries growing slightly, from approximately 33 percent to 40 percent. The internships themselves focus on a variety of aspects of librarianship: marketing, teaching, metadata/cataloging, reference work, grant writing, and so on, but with virtual opportunities being less than 20 percent for a completely online MLIS degree, only a scant few positions are available within each focus.[9]

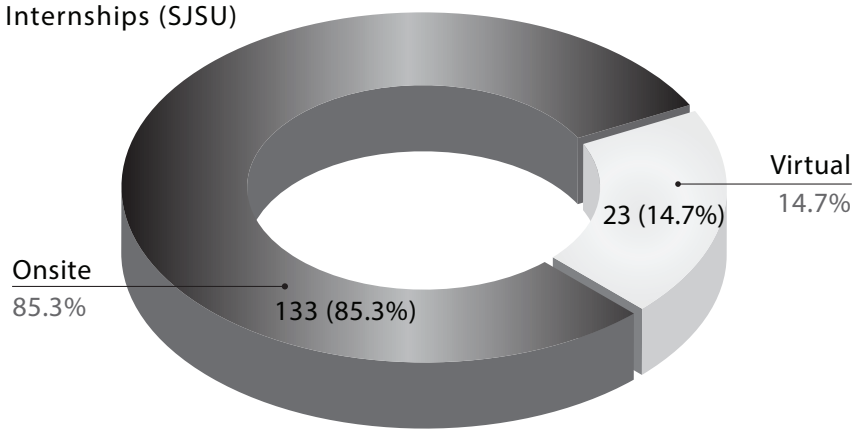


Figure 3.2
Positions posted on the SJSU internship page at the beginning of June 2020.

Makeup of Online Students

The lack of online internship opportunities makes it difficult for distance and online students, many of whom have trouble adjusting their schedules to fit within normal operating hours, to take advantage of onsite offerings. Students in online programs are often nontraditional, may be employed full-time, may have familial obligations, or may be library paraprofessionals seeking to advance within the field.[10] Overall, online instruction has expanded opportunities in library science and information studies, allowing greater diversity among students from traditionally underserved groups. It also creates additional opportunities for students who cannot afford to relocate to attend school.[11] For a field that is predominantly white,[12] there should be more opportunities available for online students, including virtual internships.

While we will discuss the benefits of internships later, it should be noted that internships provide students with valuable experience to demonstrate their capabilities and ingenuity, as well as help to reduce or remove barriers to entry for students from underserved populations. This is especially important for online students since "online degrees seem to have a stigma with employers,"[13] and much of the curriculum in library school focuses on theory. Internships allow students to have practical, hands-on experience and marry the theory they learn in school with concrete examples and real-life work. Unfortunately, even when internships are available, students may face other hurdles, the biggest of which is working without pay.

Financial Barriers

> Practicums are problematic in a similar way in that students work for a library for free while paying their school to do so. Only some students can afford to do that financially, and the students who can afford it gain experience, representing what is essentially a pay-to-play system.[14]

Both authors completed internships while attending the University of Washington; Christina also officially enrolled in the Directed Fieldwork course over the summer to earn additional credit hours, which ultimately cost more than $2,535 in tuition.[15] Looking again at the positions listed in San José's internship database from June 2020, only 35 percent of the virtual internships are paid; however, six of those paid internships offer only a $500 stipend.[16] For ten hours of work per week over a fifteen-week semester, that translates to making less than half of the federal minimum wage. The reality is that for many online students with full-time positions, an unpaid internship isn't feasible or practical.

Christina and Allison both had the privilege of being able to afford unpaid internships and the flexibility to adjust their full-time work schedules as needed. Why did both authors undertake this burden? Simply put, we both felt we needed more library experience, especially because neither of us were working in a library during school. The job market is incredibly competitive and seems to require an abundance of experience even for paraprofessional positions, making it imperative for students to take on the additional burden of internships and practicums along with their schoolwork.[17]

Benefits of Offering Experiential Learning for Libraries

Often, the benefits of experiential learning for students are clearly and thoroughly outlined, but what about for the libraries and institutions that offer these opportunities? While these benefits may not be immediately clear, they do exist and can have a large impact on both libraries and librarians. In many programs, librarians, either alone or in collaboration with others, supervise and mentor students during their internship. Supervision can come in many forms, depending on the program and library organization. The TALint program has a team that determines internship placement depending on the annual needs of the library, so multiple librarians are able to participate as supervisors.[18] San José State University incorporates interns into its library subject teams for tasks such as one-shot instruction.[19] Other examples include an assigned supervisor with various other librarians working together as part of the program or one-on-one supervision and mentoring.[20]

Virtual internships, in particular, can offer a unique opportunity for librarians and library staff to supervise from a distance, utilize new technologies that support working in a virtual environment, and save on limited physical staffing spaces. Additionally, the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic has changed working conditions, where library workers have been encouraged to be flexible and work remotely more frequently. Library administrators, librarians, and staff have been able to accomplish many services virtually, and the lessons learned during this period can provide opportunities for future internship programs that will accommodate online MLIS students.

Skills and Benefits

In either of these formats, librarians are able to build two critical skills for their careers: supervision and mentoring.[21] Supervisory experience is often required for librarians who desire to move into leadership roles, and working with a variety of MLIS students provides an excellent opportunity to gain such experience.

Mentoring is a critical skill set that not only allows librarians to share their knowledge and experience with future librarians, but also provides the opportunity to learn from the new perspectives of students.[22] One method of mentoring, which is discussed in an article by Berg, Hoffman, and Dawson, is incorporating interns into the academic librarian research process.[23] Librarians can gain much from this, such as the ability to keep on track with deadlines and help with large or time-intensive research projects to meet research or scholarship goals. Librarians also have the ability to work closely with the next generation of librarians to share their valuable knowledge of the research and publication process.

There are other substantive benefits that may not be as tangible. For more experienced librarians, burnout is a real possibility. Working closely with library school students provides an injection of excitement, allows for a fresh perspective, and grants librarians a refreshing reboot to their professional careers.[24] Students can also help provide information about new practices and new technologies and evaluate current policies and procedures for outdated, exclusive, or inefficient practices.[25]

Bolstering Diversity

Librarians from diverse backgrounds and identities can also experience some hidden benefits, such as the ability to work with the next generation of librarians from underserved populations and support their growth as they prepare to enter the profession. In the right environment, one that promotes equitable, open, and active engagement for diverse librarians and interns, some have noted that internships that both accept and promote their cultural identities can lead to a feeling of empowerment.[26] The internship program at CSU Bakersfield utilizes funding from the Department of Education for Hispanic-serving institutions and focuses on encouraging and supporting ethnic minority and low-income students who would like to become librarians in order to help remove barriers to entry as well as diversify the profession.[27] The University of Alberta has a program dedicated to supporting Indigenous MLIS students from Canada so they are prepared to enter the profession.[28] Ultimately, however, libraries need to find a balance between promoting and encouraging MLIS students from diverse backgrounds and ensuring they are not utilized to provide free labor surrounding diversity initiatives.

By investing in the professional development of current librarians and creating a reliable pipeline for interns to become hired as permanent librarians, libraries and institutions can gain something from each of the benefits described above. Experiential learning programs allow libraries to provide practical and valuable experiences for library school students so they are prepared to enter the profession after graduation. These experiences can many times lead to interns being hired by their host institutions in part due to their hands-on training, networking with future colleagues, and institutional knowledge.[29] Additionally, and perhaps

most critically, libraries can be instrumental in supporting, training, and aiding future librarians from racial and ethnic minorities by developing programs that help them gain skills, experience, and a network of current professionals.[30] While there are costs (tangible and intangible) associated with creating a robust, efficient, and productive program, depending on the institution and library staff, the benefits of hosting experiential learning programs can far outweigh the cost, time, and resources that are involved in creating such an endeavor.

Benefits of Experiential Learning for MLIS Students

Internships provide students an entry into the profession and allow them to begin the journey into more specialized work, be it cataloging, reference, or scholarly communications.[31] The "point of an internship is to gain experience, not proficiency, to build a foundation" where students can ask questions and begin to develop the skills needed to build a career in librarianship, information science, or a related field.[32] A good internship will allow students to learn about the field, including the ever-present library jargon, and gain experience in library systems.[33] They also provide students an opportunity to ask, "Is this the kind of place where I want to work?" and "Is this the type of job I want?"[34] These questions are especially important for nontraditional students who might be changing careers or need further guidance or mentoring to find the best path. Additionally, online education can often be isolating, but experiential learning opportunities can provide a chance for students to create a network outside of school and socialize with future colleagues or fellow interns.[35]

The Internships Themselves

A good internship or practicum should not only enable students to ask questions but also give them an opportunity to develop their professional network. Working closely with either fellow interns or library staff in a variety of roles allows students to build new relationships and foster new connections with various members of the field.[36] Of course, in order for this to happen, the internship must be reflective of what it means to be either a librarian or an information professional. For students to receive the full benefits of a program, they need to be able to get hands-on, meaningful experience.

> At their best, practicums or internships [should] be established in a way that supports students taking ownership of their work product and contributing to their hosts' ongoing objectives, not just filing, shelving, or "doing things the staff don't have time to do"[37]

Internships should give students an opportunity to work on projects and engage in what Galvan calls "process assignments."[38] There should also be ongoing conversations between interns and their mentors, advisors, and host institutions to ensure that their work is both engaging and purposeful.[39] This is one of the strengths of experiential learning programs specifically, which call for self-reflection and give students an opportunity to consider how their hands-on experiences fit within the broader context of library and information science.

Concrete Benefits

We touched upon the competitiveness of the librarian job market earlier in the chapter while discussing the current opportunities for MLIS/MLS students and alluded to the benefits of experiential learning. Here, we will articulate the benefits for students in more concrete terms. "Obtaining hands-on skills offers more than knowledge building; it provides practice that allows students to become adept at various skills, which evolve into professionalism."[40] Fieldwork can help students connect theory to practice and provide synergy with their coursework.[41] It can also provide great examples for their portfolios and talking points in future interviews. An internship that enables students to generate something tangible, such as a LibGuide or report, can help when they interview for library positions and possibly even lead to conference presentations or poster sessions.[42] Both of the authors of this chapter were able to capitalize on their relationship with the Law Library of Congress to write an *In Custodia Legis* blog post on the "Pioneering Women in Congress" after their internships concluded.[43]

Self-Reflection and Students' Views

As virtual metadata interns at the Law Library of Congress, Christina and Allison applied subject terms to cases from the Supreme Court of the United States in anticipation of the launch of a searchable database. Allison found the work challenging but rewarding and was able to talk about her experience during an interview for a paraprofessional staff position at San Diego State University in cataloging and acquisitions. Though she had trouble understanding many of the intricacies of law, overall she enjoyed metadata work and is happy working in a cataloging position. Her internship taught her the importance of strong communication, particularly in a virtual environment. While interns had a forum to talk and ask questions, it was hard to develop strong relationships, and there was a lack of engagement between library students and law students. Thankfully, she had Christina and two other iSchool students to chat, commiserate, and collaborate with. Christina enjoyed applying metadata to individual cases, and the online internship environment allowed for flexibility while working full-time and going to graduate school. The skills gained during the internship led to a part-time

position in the library at the University of Nevada, Las Vegas, where Christina was eventually able to have an in-person internship, and later a full-time tenure-track librarian position. She also developed a professional relationship with the intern supervisor, a librarian in the Law Library of Congress, who served as a reference for future interviews and a resource for advice while job searching.

The *Hack Library School* blog also features a post from a number of students whose internships led to further opportunities. One student notes that they "developed some great relationships with their co-workers and supervisors,"[44] while another was able to "work closely with librarians on their specific projects, including a consumer health module for public librarians, and social media/marketing."[45] Indigenous students at the University of Alberta were able to blend their "professional, scholarly and personal cultural interests" during their internships.[46] Of the studies we reviewed in writing this chapter, the vast majority of students stated their internships were worthwhile and most were able to parlay their experiences into positions.[47] In fact, according to Mandi Goodsett, LIS graduates think "that their hands-on experiences were the most important part of their degree programs and the part of their degree program that was lacking the most."[48] In our next part, we will provide some steps for you to implement a successful program at your institution.

Ways to Implement an Experiential Learning Program

Throughout this chapter, we've discussed different types of experiential learning programs and some of the ways that these programs can benefit both students and libraries. Our Types of Experiential Learning Opportunities table (see appendix) defines the various types of experiential learning opportunities that currently exist. Depending on a library's needs, budget, and staffing, implementing a program may not be easy. However, libraries can utilize the work that has been done before, including learning from mistakes made by other institutions, to create a robust and impactful program.

Missteps and Recommendations

We have compiled a list of specific recommendations for the implementation of an experiential learning program at your institution. With insight from current and former interns, librarians, library schools, and administrators, and based on surveys and programmatic reviews conducted during and after active programs, this comprehensive list will aid any academic library that wants to build a successful internship experience. These recommendations are organized into a chart (table 3.1), with the most critical ones discussed separately below.

Begin building your internship program by thinking in advance about how it should be structured. Developing a well-thought-out system will help to alleviate stress and strain on librarians and library staff and serve to better prepare students for their future careers.[49] Things to consider are what areas of the library will be included, who will be the supervisors, will there be a coordinator dedicated to organizing the program, how will the library recruit interns, and how long will the internships be? Additionally, libraries will want to identify key learning objectives and goals for interns to accomplish when they enter the program. These can be crafted for each new group of interns or at another regular interval and will help to create a valuable learning experience for each student.

A critical part of any successful internship program is ensuring that interns and their labor are valued and respected. Libraries should create an environment that emphasizes learning and recognizes the student as a colleague. The work that interns are asked to perform should be professional level; clerical work, while a valuable part of the library as a whole, will not benefit students who are training to become successful academic librarians.[50] Students should also be paid a reasonable amount for their labor, as unpaid internships create a barrier of entry for racial and ethnic minorities, low-income students, and those with other diverse identities.[51]

Library administration in charge of building a program also needs to consider the workloads of the librarians and library staff involved. While these types of programs have many benefits for students, libraries, and librarians (outlined in the previous sections), they should not become an undue burden on staff. There are a few ways to avoid this, including distributing workloads related to the internships among multiple people.[52] Other suggestions include designing programs so interns can assist librarians with their professional work (such as instruction, research, reference, etc.) after undergoing training and working with librarians' regular workloads to ensure that they are manageable when additional duties are incorporated.

Finally, as we have discussed earlier in this chapter, virtual internship opportunities are only a small portion of the whole and came up infrequently during our research. Even during a global pandemic, which necessitates virtual work, there are very few online internship opportunities available. This ultimately reduces access for online MLIS students who are not in close physical proximity to an academic institution. Libraries and institutions considering implementing an experiential learning program should explore virtual or hybrid (partially online, partially in-person) internship programs. Some examples of virtual internship opportunities include providing virtual reference services through a chat or web service, higher level cataloging or metadata work, outreach services, creating web resources (e.g., virtual displays, LibGuides, tutorials, etc.), and virtual or asynchronous instruction.

Table 3.1
Tips for implementing an experiential learning program for online MLIS students.

Misstep to Avoid	Recommend Instead
Having no clear goals or objectives for interns to accomplish.	Identify specific learning objectives and goals for interns.
Focusing on only one area (e.g., reference) or task during the entire internship.	Aim to give interns a variety of experiences (e.g., time in reference, time in instruction, time in cataloging)m and include time for building foundational skills in professional-level tasks.
Relying on a single supervisor to manage interns and provide training.	Develop cross-organizational support, with staff at multiple levels working together who share supervisory, mentoring, and training responsibilities.
Keeping internship structure and formatting the same for multiple years or terms without seeking reflective input from participants.	Provide the opportunity for regular and honest feedback from everyone involved with the program (e.g., interns, library staff, administrators, etc.).
Assuming students all have the same background and know-how to function in meetings, write professional emails, etc.	Spend some time on basic workplace behaviors (e.g., oral and written communication, staff meetings, etc.).
Limiting the internship applicant pool to only those that can afford to work in person during a standard workweek.	Explore virtual internships for work that can be done remotely.
Assuming interns will learn about how to research, write, and publish a scholarly article in their MLIS program.	Include interns in the research and scholarly publishing process.
Asking interns to do clerical level work or using “free labor” to replace full-time paid staff members.	Respect the value and labor of interns by utilizing their time well and paying an equitable and fair wage.

Conclusion

As we’ve demonstrated, having a well-designed and meaningful experiential learning program can benefit students, librarians, and institutions. Implementing a new program will be challenging, but following the suggestions outlined above will help to guide libraries in creating a program that truly benefits all of the participants and stakeholders.

> As the profession has evolved and become more technologically sophisticated and the organisations in which professionals work have become more complex, maintaining this bond between academia and the profession is crucial to ensuring that education and practical work remain connected.[53]

Library schools across the country can also utilize their knowledge of students' needs to reach out and establish relationships with other local or regional libraries to assist with the process of developing a program that works to supplement library degree curricula in a way that prepares students for the profession.[54]

Additionally, new challenges are arising with the emergence of COVID-19 and the dramatic increase in virtual working and learning, which we recognize will significantly impact opportunities moving forward. The guidelines and recommendations we have provided hold true for virtual opportunities and are informed by our own experiences as graduates of an online MLIS program. Lastly, and perhaps most importantly, we want to once again emphasize that "in order to be truly successful, students must be given a practical experience that is a true reflection of the professional environment."[55] Whether an opportunity is virtual, in person, or a hybrid of these models, libraries that host MLIS students as interns have the ultimate responsibility of providing a well-rounded experience that will enable students to become successful librarians. Regardless of the challenges ahead, institutions that look to support future librarians through developing robust, equitable, and diverse programs will help to impact the profession for the betterment of library folks and the populations we serve.

APPENDIX 3A

Types of Experiential Learning Opportunities

Type	Definition	Time Frame	Example
Internship	Structured experience where a trainee (usually a student) learns about the day-to-day of a profession or specialty	• Long-term, generally 1–2 years, though can be short-term	• San José State University: Subject Teams (unpaid) • University of Alberta: Indigenous Internship for First Nations, Métis, or Inuit (paid) • CSU Bakersfield (unpaid)
Practicum	A combination of training and on-the-job experience designed to give students supervised practical application of theory	• Short-term, generally 3 months or less	• Auraria Library (100 hours, unpaid) • University of the Punjab (8 weeks)
Service Learning	Hands-on learning experience that combines educational and community needs to create progressive societal change	• Project- or community organization–based, generally short-term	• University of South Carolina (Archiving South Carolina Women project)
Graduate Assistantship	Paid positions often in support of classes (such as grading or instruction) or research	• Semester, quarter, or academic year, sometimes fiscal year	• Work as a reader or grader (teaching assistant) • Placement in an on-campus library

Type	Definition	Time Frame	Example
Co-op (Cooperative Education)	Integration of academic studies and work experience, where the host institution works closely with degree program and instructors	• Long-term, generally at least one-half or whole academic year	• University of Toronto: MI Co-op (paid)
Field Experience/ Directed Fieldwork	Structured opportunity based on specific learning outcomes to gain hands-on experience, often coordinated between host institution and degree program	• Generally based on credit hours, usually a semester, term, or quarter	• University of Pittsburgh: Information Culture and Data Stewardship (130 hours at host institution, 20 hours class meetings)
Workplace Integrated Learning	Experiences in both educational and practice settings, often with a critical pedagogical lens	• Based on the academic year	• University of Toronto: Toronto Academic Libraries Internship program (TALint, paid)

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Voices from the Field

Dream Big, Intern Small

The Value of Internships at Small GLAM Institutions

Hannah King

A local history museum, municipal archives, art gallery, or other small GLAM (gallery, library, archives, museum) institution might not be the first place an LIS student with academic library ambitions would think to look for that all-important internship or practicum experience. It might be easy to think, as I did, that interning at an academic library is the only and best way to prepare oneself for a career in academic libraries. As I was lucky to discover, this is NOT true.

I stumbled into my internship at a historic house museum. I intended to stay only for the short length of time necessary to fulfill the internship requirement of my graduate degree, but a few months quickly turned into a fulfilling year and a half. The variety and amount of professional-level work I was entrusted with at the museum were unexpectedly large, and I felt that my work was making a tangible impact on my local community. I was able to leverage my library and information skills to create exhibits that brought new visitors to the museum, catalog and make available archival collections that had sat unorganized and inaccessible for years, and overhaul the museum's artifact collection database. I am proud that my contributions as an intern will continue to benefit the museum for years after my time there. I hope that by sharing about my experience as an intern at this small, local history museum, I might encourage other LIS students wanting to gain a well-rounded skill set to consider internships at small, nonacademic (even nonlibrary) institutions. I also recommend that staff working in GLAM institutions consider developing internship programs and opening up existing programs to LIS students.

In my experience, one of the greatest benefits of an internship at a smaller institution is the abundance of opportunities to do professional-level work in multiple areas. This work could include archival arrangement and description, exhibit curation, event and program design, artifact cataloging, and preservation, as it did for me, or any number of other relevant and interesting tasks and skills. At small archives, libraries, and museums, each staff member is typically involved with all levels and all aspects of the institution's work. At the museum where I worked, the curator was the only other museum-focused

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employee besides myself and was often stretched thin attending to administrative tasks. From the perspective of an intern, the small number of permanent staff members means that projects normally taken up by a more senior employee at a larger institution are more likely to fall within an intern's responsibilities at a smaller place. Student internship and practicum programs also benefit the institution and its permanent employees. An increased workforce means that long-put-off projects or creative new initiatives can be undertaken without scaling down other aspects of the institution's services or making workloads unsustainable for full-time employees.

Eager and ambitious interns at small GLAM institutions could likely involve themselves with any aspect of their institution's work that interested them, setting themselves up for the workforce with a wide variety of skills and abilities and tailoring their internship experience to fit their desired career path. This remains true even if the internship is not at the specific type of institution in which an intern hopes to work in the future. I feel confident that the skills and abilities I gained during my internship at a historic house museum are a great complement to the theoretical and technical knowledge I acquired during my graduate degree and that this diverse set of experiences will have prepared me well to begin a career in academic libraries.

I encourage LIS students weighing internship and practicum options to give some consideration to working at a smaller GLAM institution outside of academia. While the positive aspects of broad access and varied professional responsibilities must certainly be weighed against the potential challenges of having fewer resources and decreased opportunities for networking as compared to larger institutions, LIS students hoping to set themselves up for entry-level academic and special collections librarian roles should consider pursuing internships at small, nonacademic, nonlibrary institutions. These small GLAM organizations, too, would benefit from the presence of LIS interns and should work to develop internship and practicum opportunities where they do not exist. Not only will these positions provide opportunities for professional development to the students who hold them, but they will also bring the valuable skills and perspectives of LIS students to new settings.

Part II

Developing, Running, and Evolving Programs for LIS Students

Introduction

The chapters in this part are connected in their efforts to explore what elements are needed to make a successful internship or practicum program for LIS students. Though the authors of these chapters are examining these elements from different angles, they all demonstrate the need for careful planning, reflection, flexibility, and consideration of students' learning.

We have paired up the first two chapters and last two chapters of this part in order to be in conversation with each other. The first two chapters serve as case studies of two programs. Both chapter 4 (Daly and Chapman) and chapter 5 (DeMarco) have several things in common, including that the authors use some of the same methods and strategies from their professional work to approach their support of students as well. Daly and Chapman work in the Assessment and User Experience department in their library, and they use assessment techniques to continually refine their program. DeMarco leads her Digital Strategies and Innovation department, where they deploy Scrum and Agile practices both in their own projects in how they work with students. A highlight of the Daly and Chapman chapter is how they reworked their recruiting approach to increase the diversity of their candidate pool. A strength of the DeMarco chapter is the emphasis on how students benefit from becoming involved in teams.

The last two chapters of this part function as two sides of the same coin. While Graham, Scott, and Rocca (chapter 6) survey both librarians and students who have participated in the internship program at the university, Archer-Capuzzo and Bird (chapter 7) provide results of a survey of students in an LIS program who have taken part in an experiential learning opportunity. Reading both these chapters will provide insight into what makes these kinds of programs most effective. The perspective of librarians who have worked with interns is an especially valuable part of Graham, Scott, and Rocca's chapter, and Archer-Capuzzo and Bird do a great job of including the voices of the students who responded to the survey.

This part includes profiles with three student perspectives and a manager's perspective that provide even more viewpoints on what makes an experiential

learning program valuable for both students and librarians. Finally, the profile "Internship: What's in a Name?" by Graham, Scott, and Rocca is a potentially helpful tool for teasing out how and why different institutions use different names for these graduate work experiences. "Read these chapters and profiles if you want to establish some best practices for yourself in how to create, sustain, and continually improve an internship or practicum program for LIS students.

Voices from the Field

Breaking Down Barriers

Preparing Graduate Students for the Unspoken Rules of Academic Libraries

Jenny Hoops

I began working for Indiana University Libraries as a graduate student within the Scholarly Communication department as I completed my library science degree. After a year and a half in my student position, I was hired full-time as the department's open access publishing manager. Soon after my hiring, I was asked to manage two new graduate students, as well as revamping our new employee onboarding process. This granted me a unique opportunity to apply my very recent experiences to the development of materials that would both increase the quality of student work and provide educational opportunities for students to succeed as I did. The first task I set for myself was to interrogate my experiences as a student and identify how my training within the department had contributed to my hireability and comfort working in a professional environment.

When I had first begun my initial position as a graduate student, I soon found that my time checking in books at the circulation desk during my undergraduate years did not prepare me for the true intricacies of working in an academic library. Many graduate students, regardless of previous experience, can become overwhelmed by the various barriers established library workers take for granted: the consistent use of niche library terminologies and acronyms (including technical and cataloging lingo), software/programs not available in previous institutions, and most importantly, an abrupt introduction to the intricate bureaucracy of academic libraries. To truly be prepared for a professional environment, particularly one in academia, graduate students need to develop an understanding of the daily administration and unspoken politics of their workplaces.

One of the most profoundly helpful pieces of training I received from my supervisors was the chance to shadow meetings, both external and internal. These included consultations with patrons to develop practical technical experience, as well as the chance to attend internal departmental or institutional meetings when possible. Through these meetings I was able to not only develop the skills required to complete day-to-day tasks, but also gain greater comprehension of how and why decisions are made at the department level,

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how institutional directives are disseminated and put into practice, and how conflicts can be professionally and productively resolved. A common joke I've heard from current LIS students and coworkers alike is that they wish library school included a course on how to conduct or properly attend a meeting; until such a class exists, allowing students to take work time to shadow such meetings can help them learn how to coordinate with coworkers and patrons effectively, as well as introducing them to academic hierarchies, best communication practices, and the basics of budgetary management.

It's also never too early to start providing students with resources to navigate the wider world of library science. As a new manager, I created a glossary of terms and acronyms that were used frequently in department work and meetings, as well as terms generally seen in our field. I would also recommend suggesting various email discussion lists for the students to join, which will hopefully prepare them for the inevitable future of being constantly barraged by emails. If you are able to regularly meet or check in with your students, assigning initial readings such as recent blog posts or published articles to discuss together can also help them develop a scholarly mindset toward their work and prepare them for any research and writing requirements further down the road. These tips can all be quickly introduced during training but can make a noticeable difference in helping students acclimate to the professional workplace.

For many libraries, graduate students are a key factor in the success of various departments. Part of the compensation they deserve for such invaluable contribution should include opportunities to truly engage with the academic library as a place of work and research, especially if the positions prove to be underpaid or unpaid. I know that I personally benefited from such careful and meaningful mentorship, and I hope to continue this practice as I step into a role as manager. Ensuring that students leave their jobs with a clear sense of what it means to work in an academic library empowers them to bring engaging and dynamic changes to our institutions in the future, investing in the future of our profession.

CHAPTER 4

Improving in Action

An Iterative Approach to Developing a Successful Practicum Program

Joyce Chapman and Emily Daly

Introduction

Like many innovations, the Assessment and User Experience (AUX) practicum at Duke University Libraries was born of necessity. The AUX department was less than a year old and included just two full-time staff members with an ambitious charge: to improve users' experiences with all aspects of the library, including services, resources, physical spaces, and web interfaces. A colleague put us in touch with a graduate student interested in user experience (UX) research and usability testing. We met for coffee and took a leap of faith on a student practicum, scheduled to begin just three weeks later. That graduate student is now an accomplished information architect/user experience designer, and we would like to think we have been just as successful, with nearly thirty graduate students completing a semester-long practicum since the program's chance start in 2014.

AUX staff have approached our practicum program in the same way we address all our work: with an eye toward continuous improvement and a keen

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interest in learning from our users. In this case, the users are library and information science graduate students completing a semester-long practicum in exchange for MLIS course credit. We strive for a robust, mutually beneficial learning experience that enables students to gain valuable practical skills and knowledge in an increasingly important field while also dramatically expanding the capacity and productivity of the AUX department.

Just as we do when working with library users and researchers, we learn alongside our practicum students. This ongoing assessment has helped us make significant improvements to the AUX practicum program and to students' learning opportunities. This chapter will describe the incremental improvements we have made in response to student input, as well as ways we gather student feedback. We will share strategies for supporting multiple students from a range of educational and experiential backgrounds as they learn new skills and complete high-impact projects. We will also discuss how we restructured the recruitment process to be more equitable and inclusive. Our goal is for this chapter to be practical and instructive, and we hope readers will be able to adapt what has worked for Duke Libraries' AUX practicum program to their institutional circumstances.

A Culture of Continuous Improvement

Since 2014, we have made numerous iterative improvements to the AUX practicum program. These iterative improvements have come fairly quickly. Working with new students every semester means we receive input multiple times a year and have opportunities to make changes on a continuous basis. If we see something that could work better after onboarding a new student in the fall, we can make a change when we onboard our practicum student the following semester.

For instance, we immediately learned the value of developing learning objectives before students begin working with us. This is required by some MLIS programs, particularly when students receive course credit for their practicum. Even when it is not required, we began asking practicum students to develop three to five learning objectives that refer to skills or projects they intend to gain or complete during their time at Duke Libraries. When a student decides to work with us, we provide sample learning objectives that previous practicum students created, and we encourage students to keep their objectives fairly broad, knowing that students' interests and our departmental needs will likely shift as the semester progresses. These initial learning objectives give us a starting point and also demonstrate to students that their learning is paramount and equally as important as the work they complete during their time with us.

As we gained familiarity working with students and developing mutually beneficial projects, we realized it was helpful to host students continuously, without gaps during the summer. Recruiting and onboarding students to complete a summer practicum (roughly May through August) allows us to maintain

momentum on projects and conduct year-round usability testing, a core departmental function we rely heavily on students to do. At the same time, it makes the practicum accessible to students who do not live nearby during the school year and to students who work full-time and can complete an unpaid practicum only when school is not in session. After the first year hosting summer practicum students, we learned that the nature of summer student work is different from work during the semester, often taking the form of sustained, in-depth projects well suited to practicum students who are typically not taking courses and so have more time and energy to devote to a summer-long project.

Another change we made was to the number of students we host simultaneously. As our department grew in size to five full-time staff, and as we gained confidence hosting students year-round, we realized there is value in having two or more students work together in a single semester. In some cases, students have the same learning objectives, but quite often, they come in with different learning goals and end up working on some projects together and others independently. Having pairs of students provides numerous benefits to the students and to the department. While we first worried that we would not have the capacity to adequately support more than one student, we soon learned that practicum students provide a good deal of support to each other. Students recognized that it would be helpful to coordinate their schedules so that they spend at least half of their weekly hours together. We onboard students together, meaning they often complete their first tasks as a team and then work to divvy up projects and tasks for the remainder of the semester, drawing on each other's strengths and learning new skills from one another. This setup means that students typically go to each other with questions before approaching a full-time staff member, thereby building their confidence to work independently. When we hire two or more students to work together, we consider carefully each student's background, including their coursework and experience working in libraries. While the primary goal of our practicum is to give students an opportunity to gain experience in academic libraries, it is often the case that at least one student each semester has worked in libraries or completed relevant coursework. By pairing students with relatively little experience with more experienced students, or by ensuring that students' strengths complement rather than duplicate each other's skills, we are able to be more productive and support students more effectively. Moreover, this practice has enabled us to build a more diverse cohort of practicum students in terms of skills, background, and expertise.

While pairs of practicum students work closely on projects and rely on each other to brainstorm possible solutions and answer basic questions, we repeatedly hear from practicum students that they highly value time with full-time staff. Students appreciate how accessible AUX staff are and report that regular check-in meetings are critical. These regular check-in meetings typically take

place weekly for thirty to sixty minutes. Meetings include the AUX department head (the primary supervisor for students), all practicum students if schedules permit, and any other full-time staff the practicum students need to talk with about their projects. In addition to the regular check-in meetings, students participate in monthly department meetings and are invited to take part in as many library staff and team or project meetings as they like. Over the years, we have learned that attending these types of library-wide meetings not only helps students learn more about working in academic libraries and higher education, but also provides context for particular projects and nuance for UX problems they are trying to solve.

Relatedly, we have improved the way that we assign tasks and communicate with students between weekly check-in meetings. We heard from students early on that they wished they knew more about previous practicum students' work, especially because many student projects continue from one semester to the next. We also learned that students wanted a way to effectively manage their time and tasks since they often juggle coursework and paid jobs in addition to the practicum. To help respond to these needs, we began using Basecamp, a web-based project management and team communication tool, to document students' work. Now, rather than storing all communication in staff members' email, documentation and files are housed in Basecamp. Basecamp helps students organize their time and projects during a given semester and allows them to post questions for staff who might not be immediately available. The tool also ensures that future students have easy access to key project details since we routinely add new students to the relevant Basecamp team each semester.

Finally, we have refined the logistics of students' work schedules. We strive to be as accommodating as possible to our unpaid practicum students, but we find that it works best when students can be on campus for two half-days per week. In some cases, we have had students with very long commutes opt to work one full day instead of two half-days per week. While this arrangement is certainly more practical for a student who lives over an hour away, we find that most students are able to learn and work more efficiently when they are on campus more than once per week—after all, weekly visits mean students are in the library just thirteen to fourteen times in a typical semester.

Making Recruitment More Equitable and Inclusive

As the fields of assessment and UX in libraries have grown in popularity, so too has interest in our AUX practicum. In the first years of our program, the practicum opportunity was advertised only passively on the Duke Libraries website and by word of mouth, and typically only one or two students would

express interest in our practicum each semester. The AUX department head would conduct informal meetings with the first students who contacted us, and we were nearly always able to accommodate everyone who expressed interest. As more students began to apply, we would accept as many as three students per semester and fill practicum positions for the following semester or two with anyone else who applied. This left us at times with no free practicum spaces for a year in advance and created an unfair situation for other potential applicants. The process of backfilling positions was not formally documented or communicated, providing an advantage to the applicants who heard about the program first.

Prior to fall 2019, 75 percent of our practicum students were enrolled in a single MLIS program. While Duke University does not have an MLIS program of its own, we are fortunate to have four schools with ALA-accredited library science programs within a ninety-minute drive. One is a competitive, top-ranked program. This well-funded program has hundreds of students each year, provides its students with many paid part-time work opportunities within its library system, and offers courses in UX and assessment. Instructors for UX and assessment courses tell students about our practicum and encourage them to apply. Additionally, the Duke Libraries have a well-established relationship with the school and a large number of graduates on staff. At the same time, less than four miles from Duke is another library science program at an HBCU (historically Black colleges and universities). The program has no courses in assessment and UX, has few in-house part-time job opportunities for students, and offers many online and evening courses so that students can easily work full-time while completing their degree.

These issues demonstrate how discrimination in job opportunities and access is often perpetuated by informal networks of opportunity. Patterns of social and economic segregation in social networks—such as those forged at the prestigious MLIS program and extended to Duke Libraries—are shown to regularly disadvantage members of historically marginalized groups.[1] This creates a network of access to the AUX practicum with high returns for the students in one particular MLIS program. In seven years and thirty students, we never had a practicum applicant, let alone a student, from the local HBCU until late 2020, nearly two years after implementing changes to address critical problems with AUX's application and recruitment process.

In early 2019, AUX staff discussed what had become a clear inequity and aimed to develop solutions. Our discussions were guided by the libraries' 2016–2021 strategic plan. A number of guiding principles, including "diversity strengthens us," inform the strategic plan's priorities and goals, and "define who we are and who we strive to be."[2] As a department dedicated to continuous improvement, we understood that we needed to address the growing disparities of our own processes. We developed more equitable and inclusive recruitment practices in

an effort to attract students from more institutions and backgrounds. We had no formal recruitment or interview processes in our program's early years, which meant that the AUX practicum hiring process was not structured in a way that was inclusive. We realized that the playing field was not level for applicants across the four local schools or from online programs. Those students at the most prestigious local institution—who already had a leg up with acquiring work experience and relevant UX and assessment coursework while in school—were the most likely to complete the AUX practicum each semester if we did not structure our recruitment and interview process to be more equitable. We committed to ending our overreliance on professors at the prestigious program to funnel students to us and took the following steps:

1. *Active recruitment.* We developed staff contacts at every MLIS program in the state and now send a recruitment email to every student electronic discussion list each semester. We additionally post the recruitment message to the email discussion list for the North Carolina Library Association's Roundtable for Ethnic and Minority Concerns, and we began reaching out to faculty advisors at the local HBCU, asking them to encourage students to apply, rather than relying solely on a post to the student email discussion list.
2. *Financial and distance considerations.* While there are certain major economic inequalities that we are unable to overcome (for example, students who must work full-time to support their families may not be able to complete unpaid practicums and often do not have availability during the hours when our departmental staff work), we make accommodations where possible. For instance, we have long offered paid parking passes to all practicum students, but we did not share this information before candidates applied. We added information about the paid parking passes to the online ad and recruitment emails so that paying for parking would not be a barrier to applying. We began encouraging video and phone interviews instead of requiring applicants to travel to campus in the middle of the workday to interview, and we began permitting some students to work a few hours a week from home when necessary.
3. *Defined application process.* We developed formal recruitment and hiring processes, including deadlines for advertising the position and accepting applications for each semester. We created a policy by which no practicum positions would be filled in advance of the current advertised semester and encouraged those who did not receive a position in one semester to reapply in subsequent semesters. In this way, those who heard about the opportunity first—often students told about the opportunity by professors in class—were not given an advantage in hiring.

4. *Structured interviews.* AUX staff now meet to review applicants after the application deadline and agree on which students to invite for an interview. Interviews are forty-five minutes, including time to provide background on the department and type of work the student would be doing and for the student to ask questions. A minimum of two AUX department members attend each interview to reduce the influence of any one staff person's bias. We send applicants the list of questions we intend to ask ahead of time, allowing those who are less experienced with interviewing an opportunity to prepare.
5. *Criteria for hiring.* We developed our first formal criteria for hiring. These criteria do not prioritize experience with UX and assessment ahead of attributes such as the ability to work well independently and as part of a team. While it had never been our goal to recruit only students with experience in web design, UX research, data analysis, or assessment, there was no shared understanding around our selection criteria. If we prioritized experience with UX and assessment, students from large programs that include UX and assessment courses would always have an advantage over others.
6. *More inclusive language.* We changed the name of our program from *field experience* to the more universally recognized term, *practicum*. The term *field experience* is used by the aforementioned prestigious MLIS program. By using the terminology that only this MLIS program uses, we inadvertently signaled to potential practicum students that the AUX practicum gave preference to—or worse, was open only to—students enrolled at the one institution. We changed the name of our student program to *practicum* on all web pages, advertisements, and recruitment materials and encouraged our Duke Libraries colleagues to do the same for their unpaid student experiences. We more recently clarified and moved the text emphasizing that there is no requirement for prior experience in UX work to the top of the job ad.

In the two years since we implemented these changes, the percent of practicum students from the single MLIS program has dropped from 75 percent of total students to 37.5 percent of total students, and we will host our first practicum student from the local HBCU in spring 2021.

Ways We Gather Feedback

How have we determined what to change in AUX's student experiences? How have we identified the factors that contribute to a strong student program? We gather feedback from students much the way we do in our departmental work with library users. We ask for input continuously, and we apply structure to

the ways we gather feedback whenever possible. We foster strong relationships with students and instill a sense of confidence and independence so they feel comfortable suggesting improvements beginning on day one.

Building relationships with students starts as early as the interview phase, when we share an informative and detailed departmental web page that describes example AUX projects, including activities completed by former AUX students.[3] Even before students interview with AUX staff, we demonstrate our commitment to their success and learning. We share interview questions in advance, knowing that students will likely feel more comfortable and answer questions more fully if they are able to prepare. We communicate during the interview that students are highly valued and respected members of the department. Our goal in sharing these details early on is to demonstrate to students that we value their observations and perspectives.

Relationship building with students continues once they accept a practicum, as their first assigned task is to walk through library spaces and use library web interfaces, making note of what works well and what does not work for them. These activities accomplish a number of things. First, they give students the opportunity to explore the library buildings and websites they will be working with all semester. Second, we often learn something that needs to be reviewed or changed, sometimes resulting in a new task or project. Finally, we demonstrate that students' fresh eyes and unique perspectives matter deeply and that we are serious about seeking ways to improve. Of course, this stance does not end after the initial task. We encourage students to continue sharing their experiences and suggestions for improving library spaces, services, and web interfaces—it is, in fact, their job.

We have learned over the years that students prefer to share their feedback and suggestions for improvement in different ways. While students come to us from a variety of backgrounds and with different communication styles and preferences, we have developed a practice that seems to work well for all students—the weekly check-in meeting. As noted earlier, the purpose of this meeting is to stay in regular, synchronous contact. While we regularly check in at each other's desks and by email and Basecamp, it is critical to the success of the practicum that we set aside time on a weekly basis for students to talk with the department head. These weekly meetings allow us to build relationships with our students, develop and carry out meaningful projects, and establish a way for students to provide ongoing feedback about their learning experience. It is in these meetings that we learn about everything from logistical concerns to aspects of students' overall experience that need to be addressed (e.g., they are not able to accomplish everything they would like in only eight hours per week, or they need more support learning how to use a tool or platform than we originally realized).

We also gather midpoint practicum evaluations and end-of-practicum reflections that provide additional insight into the overall effectiveness of a particular student's experience as well as the program as a whole. During the midpoint evaluation, the AUX department head and students review students' goals for the practicum and make adjustments where needed. By the middle of their experience, students often have far more information about Duke Libraries' needs and about their personal interests than they had when they wrote their learning objectives. By meeting with students on a weekly basis and then holding a structured midpoint review, we are able to revise goals and thereby optimize students' learning and their contributions to the AUX department and library as a whole. Ideally, students' MLIS faculty mentors are also part of this midpoint review by phone or videoconference, but in our experience, this does not happen as often as we would like. We aspire to strengthen relationships with practicum students' faculty mentors so that we can make deeper connections between students' work at Duke and their coursework and career goals.

We seek input about all aspects of students' learning experiences and the AUX department at the end of students' time working with us. Just as we do in the interview phase, we share questions in advance of an end-of-term, one-on-one meeting between each student and the AUX department head, this time at least two weeks beforehand so that students have sufficient time to reflect on their experiences. Our questions are simple but surprisingly effective:

1. As you think back on your experience working with AUX, what are you most proud of?
2. What might you do differently if you were to do the practicum again?
3. What has worked particularly well about the AUX practicum?
4. What about the AUX practicum would you recommend improving or changing in future semesters?
5. What other thoughts, observations, or questions would you like to share or ask?

This final meeting is typically scheduled during students' last week with AUX. It is celebratory in nature, a time to reflect on students' growth and learning. Students often comment on the breadth and depth of their experiences with AUX and nearly always raise something they would do differently if they were to complete another practicum. For some, the suggested changes are logistical in nature. Other students reflect on changes they would make to their output—for example, they would explore a particular assessment method earlier in their term, or they would spend more time researching a problem before diving into

a solution. In all cases, the goal of these final meetings is for students to consider their own learning as well as suggest ways AUX staff can continue to improve our student program. For instance, students have requested more opportunities to interact with staff outside our department. In response, we began hosting informal coffee hours where practicum students could meet library staff they might work with during their semester with AUX. Another student noted during their wrap-up meeting that it would be helpful to have a departmental laptop for usability testing so that students would not have to rely on personal devices. We were able to act on this suggestion immediately, and students the following semester noted that it was indeed helpful to have a designated laptop for user testing. The end-of-term meetings also reveal aspects of the practicum we should continue. Positive feedback we hear most frequently from students includes the following:

1. *Availability of AUX staff.* Students report being surprised that all AUX staff, and especially the department head, are so available to mentor students and guide their work. Students share that the regular synchronous and asynchronous communication provides structure for their work and helps them feel productive and supported.
2. *Involvement in departmental work and communication.* We hear that students value being included in library meetings and email discussion lists, staff meetings, and professional development opportunities. Practicum students are often interested in learning what it is like to work in a large research library, and exposure to staff communication and internal and external programs helps them achieve this goal.
3. *Practical, relevant, marketable projects.* In addition to learning about library organizational culture, students are interested in gaining practical skills and completing meaningful, high-impact work. We hear from practicum students that they find their projects interesting, relevant, purposeful, and helpful for landing future internships or professional positions.

The Future of AUX's Student Program

As higher education continues to shift in response to health, social, and economic concerns, there are undoubtedly changes that will be out of our control. Our commitment to continual assessment and improvement will continue to serve us well. For instance, we were pleasantly surprised by how smoothly our practicum program shifted to a virtual environment when all AUX staff began working remotely in response to the COVID-19 pandemic. Weekly check-in meetings moved to Zoom, projects related to the libraries' physical spaces took a backseat while we focused on the libraries' web presence, and in-person usability testing

switched to an online format. AUX staff successfully recruited and onboarded new practicum students while working remotely. Our years of experience working with students, our well-tested virtual platforms, and the iterative improvements we have made over the last seven years have positioned us well to continue to provide meaningful learning opportunities for MLIS students, which may well be more important than ever.

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VOICES FROM THE FIELD

A Chinese Student's Perspective on American Library School and Work

Shu Wan

An increasing number of international students are coming to the United States with a passion for taking high-quality training in library schools across the country. Among those international students pursuing better advanced education, I began my graduate study in the School of Library and Information Science at the University of Iowa in the summer of 2019. Reviewing my experience of studying as a library school student from a unique background, I will reflect on my study and work in the library school from an international student's perspective.

I've been enrolled as an MLIS student for over one and a half years. I have also already served as an ArchivesSpace assistant in the Department of Special Collections of the UI Libraries for over two years. The combination of my coursework in the library school and work experience in the library makes me confident that I can become a qualified librarian after my graduation. In particular, Dr. Lindsay Mattock's instruction and encouragement in the library school and the supervision of my work by two librarians, Lindsay Moen and Jenna Silver, in Special Collections are significant for my studies and work.

The first course I took in the library school was Dr. Lindsay Mattock's inspiring class Computing Foundations. As an introductory course on the computational and technical foundation of library science, Dr. Mattock's course provides basic knowledge of computer programming. The course covers composing command lines in the Linux system, completing tasks in Raspberry, and basic coding in Python. This course aims to provide intense training in computational skills and knowledge for students like me, whose academic backgrounds are predominantly from the humanities and social sciences. Before beginning library school, I trained as a historian for almost ten years, and this first course in computer programming was not an easy task!

Thanks to Dr. Mattock's inspiring teaching, I did not feel frustrated when taking my first step into the world of coding. I acquired the basic skills of coding in Python, HTML, CSS, and other popular programming languages, which paved the way for me to lead a project to implement AI technology at the traditional reference desk. With a seed grant provided by the University

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of Iowa and the National Science Foundation, I am leading a team consisting of graduate students from interdisciplinary backgrounds in library science, computer science, and computer engineering in developing a reference desk–oriented chatbot. The product of this project is tentatively called "Referbot." Developed on Microsoft's chatbot platform Azure, Referbot is designed to assist reference librarians in dealing with their overloaded workflow, including answering patrons' simple questions and assisting patrons looking for books.

In addition to Dr. Mattock's support, my journey in the library school has also benefited from my two supervisors for my graduate student position in Special Collections, Lindsay Moen and Jenna Silver. Having come to Iowa to pursue an advanced degree in US history, I had no conception of what a library job was like before getting my assistant job. As the only foreigner among students and staff working in the department, I sometimes felt alone and anxious. Thanks to my patient and merciful supervisors, I am thriving in my first library job. In a post for the American Library Association's (ALA) diversity blog, I have shared useful lessons about how to efficiently communicate with two American bosses as a way to help other international LIS students.[1]

As part of my work, I was assigned by my two supervisors to take advantage of my native proficiency in Chinese to process the collection of Manuscripts of Chinese Writers (http://aspace.lib.uiowa.edu/repositories/2/resources/685). It contains the manuscripts of Chinese writers who participated in the International Writing Program in the past thirty years. The opportunity to process the collection gave me the chance to read the manuscripts of some well-known Chinese writers and poets including Wang Meng, Can Xue, and Ding Ling. During my processing of this collection, I received my two supervisors' support for my attempts to implement linked open data technology in processing and cataloging the collection. As the by-product of my work on this rare collection, my presentation proposal "Linking Bilingual Bibliographic Data: A Wikidata-Based Project of Chinese Writers' Archival Collections" was accepted for the 2020 LD4 Conference on Linked Data in Libraries.

In reflecting on my coursework and library work, I tentatively offer some suggestions to the library school faculty and library professionals supervising student workers and assistants from international backgrounds. First, be respectful of cultural differences and diversity when communicating with those strangers in the land. Second, you may need to show additional patience for those international students and workers who may encounter extra frustration in their everyday workflow. Finally, it can be better to use email instead of face-to-face talk as the first choice for communication because some students, like me, may feel nervous and (socially) anxious when talking with supervisors. International students offer diverse perspectives and life experiences, and I encourage library school staff and librarians to strongly consider bringing

them into your work and projects. Finally, I sincerely hope my American colleagues and peers may integrate foreign student workers into their account of cultural and racial diversity in the library space.

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CHAPTER 5

Building an Innovative Internship Program

The Recipe for Greatness

Claire DeMarco

There is an aspect of serendipity in building an internship program—a delicate balance between the administrative framework and individual personalities at play. The hope is that the personalities align and the framework gives rise to learning opportunities, but it is difficult to identify all of the necessary ingredients and combine them to create a great internship program. Interns are change makers, learners, catalysts, innovators. They bring dynamism into an organization in a way that cannot be preplanned. Planning also takes time—the ingredient most often in short supply. In many ways, the planning is the roadblock. Instead of starting from scratch, this chapter will identify three key ingredients that can be measured and mixed to create a great, innovative internship program using the Digital Strategies and Innovation (DSI) Internship program at Harvard Library as a case study.

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When designing the DSI Internship program, we saw an opportunity to not only recognize the innovative spirit of interns, but to grow it, among the interns and across our institution. Curiosity and exploration are at the heart of Harvard Library's mission, and to further our mission, we have embraced Agile principles, originally intended for the software development industry, and brought them into library practices. Key among those principles is the commitment to "build projects around motivated individuals. Give them the environment and support they need, and trust them to get the job done."[1] We have also adopted a Scrum framework for organizing many of our projects and teams. Agile and Scrum dovetail in ways that align directly with the mission of Harvard Library and foster a team-focused commitment to transparency, inspection, and adaptation. These methods create the conditions upon which this recipe works.

The DSI Internship has welcomed three cohorts of interns thus far, and the program has continued to evolve through each iteration. Like any good chef, we have tinkered and tweaked, but this recipe has three key ingredients: a bias toward action, an openness to innovation, and a team-based approach. By sharing the DSI Internship story, this chapter lays out a recipe for greatness and identifies the ingredients that give rise to an innovative internship program.

Ingredient 1: Bias toward Action

Despite the seemingly endless amount of work on our to-do lists and the perpetual need for additional hands, saying yes to a new internship program is not without risk. There are budget constraints. There are considerations around the time associated with managing additional people. An innovative internship program, however, must start from a guiding principle of "yes, and." Starting from "yes, and" as a form of applied improvisation has gained traction in higher education and organizational development in recent years.[2] In the library context, "yes, and" has become a mantra of collaboration.[3] Building a successful internship program starts with saying yes to the opportunity. There is never enough time, enough space to add something new to the list of responsibilities, but making space for interns builds the capacity for learning in our organizations. Saying yes builds the capacity to keep saying yes.

Saying yes to opportunity requires a tolerance for risk, and tolerance for risk has an inverse relationship to the fear of failure. In an innovation context, failure is not cast in the negative—it presents an opportunity. Although a failure may be associated with negative outcomes, it is first and foremost an attempt, and the attempt creates the learning opportunity for the team and individual team members. "Signaling it is acceptable to take risks, experiment and voice their ideas and concerns to team members, a psychologically safe work environment will foster team and individual learning."[4] If we feel psychologically safe—if we are free to fail—risk-taking becomes easier—for us and for the interns we are

bringing into the organization. As change makers, interns have endless opportunities for failure, and we can model the risk tolerance and learning associated with individual and collective attempts in order to amplify their experiences.

> It is okay to not know the answer to everything and figure it out as you go. The freedom to take risks with creative solutions was a difficult mentality to get used to. The stereotypical intern role commonly portrayed in the media that interns should follow the rules made it difficult at first to take advantage of this creative opportunity. But the experience of demoing our work, failing, and then implementing a more creative solution allowed us to take more risks and made us better prepared for the work ahead. —Former DSI intern

In order to model risk-taking from the beginning, prioritize those qualities associated with experimentation and learning in the first engagement with potential interns: the job interview. An open-ended, innovative internship program requires deciding the qualifications of a successful applicant without relying on specific expectations of productivity and experience. Instead of questions about prior related work, ask about how they handle self-direction, what they need in order to get started, and whether they are willing to take action without explicit guidance, to embrace the try. Ask what role they traditionally play in a team; ask them to identify the hardest part about working with others, where they see opportunities for growth. Ask how they like to manage tasks, whether they know about Agile and Scrum, or whether they are interested in learning. In short, interview questions should model curiosity, not qualification. By modeling the importance of curiosity, the organization's employees can be teachers and learners. Interns call on us to explain why things are the way they are, and they ask the question: Do they have to stay that way? Establishing this practice from the early stage of a job interview sets the stage for a great and innovative internship experience.

The traditional intern is expected to perform menial, even personal, tasks at the whim of a supervisor, under the guise of observing that supervisor at work. The intern performs these assigned tasks in order to build out a résumé and fulfill the need for work experience. By contrast, a program that values curiosity, experimentation, and learning creates a deeper and more meaningful opportunity for work experience. There is, however, a parallel track for task-based work in the innovation context. On their very first day, interns have tasks to accomplish—interns need ID cards, access to buildings and systems. There are computers to set up, passwords to create. This work serves as a good juxtaposition for the big-picture questions and creative structure of the job interview—relationship building and fostering curiosity, followed by boxes checked off the to-do list.

Administrative tasks are not merely prerequisites, they are accomplishments on day one, springboards to self-efficacy.

Self-efficacy, or the personal confidence in completing a goal, supports innovation by motivating individuals to push through the uncertainty and accompanying fear of action.[5] Even the smallest tasks can help to build self-efficacy, creating a bias toward action. When we are biased toward action, we are gifted with the opportunity to reflect on our actions, and learning can take place only as a result of that reflection. Even if we design a program focused on learning rather than outcomes, that learning arises as a result of investigating the outcomes—the successes or the failures. The fear of failure remains a factor, even in the most psychologically safe environments, but is not simply the fear at play—it is the inaction as a result of the fear. Inaction, not failure, is the biggest barrier to success, and the key to overcoming that barrier is creating self-efficacy, modeling a bias toward action.

Ingredient 2: Openness to Innovation

Innovation is often portrayed as a bolt out of the blue—an aha moment that changes everything—but those moments are not random. They are the result of circumstances that leave the innovator open, vulnerable, receptive, free to ask questions and think divergently. The extent to which individuals will produce innovative ideas during their everyday work depends not only on their unique characteristics, but also on the work environment around them.[6] The same characteristics that underpin a bias toward action foster an openness to innovation, and that openness is baked into the experience of interns as learners. An internship program is the perfect preheated oven for innovation.

A clear example of placing value on openness from the DSI Internship experience is a form from human resources intended to make sure that intern opportunities are distinct from those of existing employees. It makes sense—unions do not want to see employees replaced with interns who work for less and do not get benefits. That form, however, sets a tone. This is not about productivity. It is about the learning opportunity. Learning is more important than discrete results. The learning is the outcome. An internship is an opportunity formed around people. Interns do not fill existing roles. They are not entry-level employees. Interns are learners—they bring with them the value of their inexperience. Their perspectives are not only free of the inertia that naturally develops within an organization, but they are also stripped of the assumptions that form over years of work experiences. They have an openness to curiosity, learning, and a natural inclination toward innovation.

One method of creating openness from the beginning is to set aside an early, time-boxed period within the program for the interns to observe and participate in as many meetings and events as possible. Anything that any member of the

team hears about or knows about, bring the interns along. They are sponges. They are learning this institution by osmosis. They are taking note of their big questions. With every acronym, every conclusive statement they hear, they have the authority to add "Why?" to the end and to make us explain, show, question, refine. They are teaching us to question our own assumptions through their own attempts to learn. Their learning is reflected in us, and we welcome it. By providing interns with access to every member of the team, every part of the organization, we welcome their questions, their feedback, and their participation. We show them that they are valuable by virtue of their presence, not their productivity.

> As summer interns, we arrived on the team with little system-design experience and institutional knowledge, which meant that the ability to ask questions of and learn from other members of the team was especially important for us. Being expected to communicate on a daily basis with more experienced members of the team made it easier for us to approach them other times when we needed their help with one of our own tasks. —Former DSI intern

After a time-boxed period for absorbing as much information as possible, interns can transform all they have observed and experienced into action through a facilitated brainstorming session. One facilitation technique is to have the interns place every question, every interesting idea, everything they want to try on a series of individual sticky notes. The interns break each idea down into its smallest possible components. Sticky notes for "learn more about user research" or "design-driven development" or "digital collections migration" become "observe and take notes for a moderated UX session" or "design a research agenda for understanding student use of the library website" or "prototype a Zotero-based solution for bibliography migration." These individual tasks then map to broader themes or projects. By focusing on the actions the interns can take to move these projects forward, they can start right away—again, modeling a bias toward action. The sticky notes can become cards on a board for tracking progress. The board can include three simple statuses: backlog, in progress, done. Just like that, the interns are sprinting.

Sprinting is a method defined by the Scrum framework to move in two-week intervals—or sprints. Looking over every sticky note they have created in their initial brainstorming, the interns can identify what they want to accomplish within their first sprint. They get to decide, from all the work available to them, where they want to get started. Setting a two-week time-box presents this as an attempt, not a guarantee. Scrum includes four key ceremonies over the course of a short, time-boxed sprint: Planning, Daily Stand-Ups, Demonstration, and Retrospective. The demonstration takes place at the end of each two weeks, and

while the demo serves as a deadline, it is not artificial. Demo is a benchmark designed to provide an opportunity for inspecting the work. Demo is immediately followed by a retrospective to consider what worked, what did not, and what we want to do differently. A demo/retro framework gives the interns the ability to make their best attempt, inspect, and adapt for the next sprint. This series of benchmarks or ceremonies throughout a time-boxed period or sprint provide the lightweight scaffolding that allows teams to employ an iterative, incremental approach.[7]

That first big brainstorming session is an example of convergent thinking, where interns are bringing a variety of ideas together and organizing them into potential work streams. Convergent thinking alone, however, even when structured with a creative, action-biased framework, reinforces many of the traditional modes of project planning and limits the opportunity for innovation. In order to reinforce openness to innovation, there is a need to augment the Scrum framework with an additional ceremony—in the DSI Internship program, this is known as "Thursdays at 3." Weekly, dedicated divergent-thinking time. An opportunity to bring any and all ideas to the team for discussion. Go outside if possible. Avoid agendas—think instead about discussion prompts.

One such discussion prompt is the headline game. Adapted for the DSI Internship program, it goes like this: "Imagine yourself one year from now. You've graduated from the School of Information. You're applying for jobs. Someone from your student newspaper wants to do a profile of you—of your time during the internship. What's the headline?" At the beginning of the program, there is no way for the interns to answer that question correctly—to predict what they'll be able to accomplish or what they can say about their time. But their attempt to answer that question at such an early stage lets us know how we can make this opportunity meaningful for them. What we can set out to help them achieve.

We cannot expect innovative ideas to push through the day-to-day of traditional office culture. We need to make space for them, to invite innovation in by considering what circumstances bring about innovative thinking. To truly be open to innovation, we must make space for it to grow—that means dedicated time for divergent thinking without a particular end point in mind.

> Feeling respected and working in a jovial environment allowed us to become creative in our work. When you are not respected, you feel like you are walking on eggshells, always being watched, and never want to do anything wrong. This might cause you to take fewer risks, be less productive, or limit yourself to typical solutions. Our working environment allowed us to be creative thinkers and not be afraid to fail. If we did fail, we were agile enough to pivot and try something new. —Former DSI intern

Ingredient 3: Team-Based Approach

Building a great internship program requires a team-based approach. Even when a single intern is paired with a single supervisor, those two people can create a shared goal. Their individual efforts toward the accomplishment of that shared goal are what makes them a team. Their efforts involve actions—tasks that they do—that "leave an impact on them in terms of influencing their personal and collective psychological states."[8] Framing an internship as a team experience increases capacity for collaboration and creativity. When individuals discuss their questions, challenges, and ideas with one another, "they are more likely to generate, build on, and combine a greater variety of information."[9]

Creating a new team around a shared purpose introduces fear and uncertainty into even the most confident among us. Rather than pushing through fears and uncertainty individually, an innovative approach requires that we demonstrate the value of curiosity for the team by asking questions about the interns. Who are they? What are they excited about? What are they scared about? Harvard Library staff have done a lot of work in this space—describing and naming fears—allowing that discussion to inform next steps. We call it fearstorming.[10] Interns have made major adjustments to incorporate this new environment. Thinking back to our own major adjustments can allow us to relate to their experience. We let them ask questions. We share our own fears. We do not focus on the work directly, but it is there—we focus on their questions. They get a chance to show their curiosity. Already we are learning together. Instead of seeing fears as barriers to productivity, consider fears as opportunities to share transparent, honest communication. Fears are universal—and because we all have them, we can build relationships through sharing them. Shared fears encourage collaboration.

> As interns and students, we were constantly questioning whether we belonged and suffered from "imposter syndrome," but the work we produced, the meetings we participated in, and the team we were surrounded by gave us the confidence that we were learning things in the classroom and could successfully apply them in the workplace. —Former DSI intern

Interns create new teams, they do not simply augment existing ones. Through the curiosity, the acknowledgement of fear, there is a new team. Together, the new team must create shared norms and protocols. One simple protocol is to check in every day. Each person starts every day with an expression of how they are feeling: glad, mad, sad, afraid, or any required combination. These universal terms allow us to communicate our feelings without the pressure of finding our own descriptive words. We tap into what are common, basic emotional states

and allow ourselves to express them simply in a way that fosters team trust, happiness, and productivity.[11]

Once we have established what we are feeling and how we are approaching work with the team each day, we can supplement with the standard "daily scrum" information—sharing recent accomplishments and updating the team about next steps. There is an explicit interplay between emotional states and the tasks at hand that allows this transition to occur smoothly. We can respond to the temporary feelings that team members may be experiencing and the impact those feelings may have on work the way we check a weather forecast. If it is cloudy with a chance of rain, I might grab an umbrella—if I am checking in feeling mad, this might not be the best day for me to engage in a difficult conversation with a stakeholder; perhaps I should reschedule. At the same time, we can distinguish that weather from the larger climate patterns that influence our emotional states over long periods of time.

The interns should observe and participate in these weather reports from their very first day—again, the observation and participation create opportunity for learning; the learning is the task. The check-in ceremony is part of a series of high-performance team protocols rooted in promoting psychological safety. Great teams are made up of great people, but in order to bring their individual greatness to the team, they need to be aware of what they think, what they want, and what they feel.[12] Self-awareness gives us the ability to connect with others. That connection then enhances our productivity. Accessing and building on others' unique perspectives and expertise contributes to the "combination of unique information, which leads to developing new solutions."[13] This approach works well when building an internship program as part of an existing high-performing team, but it can also be a chance to turn individual contributors into a team.

The Showstopper

Innovative intern teams share a bias toward action rooted in Agile principles with an openness that builds on and enhances the Scrum framework. In addition to the regular demonstrations at the end of each sprint, DSI interns are asked to prepare a final demonstration for the entire library. There are no requirements for this presentation—no deliverables they must share. Like the internship itself, the final demonstration is self-directed. Over the three years of the DSI internship, the final presentations have highlighted the ways in which the cohorts have mixed and measured the key ingredients of a great internship program.

In the first year, the interns focused on their team-based approach. They showcased their own strengths, what they did to complement one another, and of course they showed the work—an incredible migration of thousands of bibliography entries regarding the library's medieval manuscripts from outdated,

inaccessible Word documents to a Zotero collection of transformable data. This accomplishment is one that the retiring curator never thought he would see during his tenure. Despite this accomplishment—the interns cited the framework of the internship using Agile and Scrum as the defining characteristic of the program, one that they go on to share at national conferences and opportunities for publication.

In the second year, the interns demonstrated work that placed more emphasis on a bias toward action—they created an incredible diagram of all their touch points with the library throughout the summer. They yearned to demonstrate all of their work in one presentation, but settled on selecting the work they were each most proud of—and in so doing, they focused on the three major phases of work: user research, design, and development. They showed how each of those phases fed into one another—an elegant articulation of the team's methods—and they concluded by thanking us for the learning opportunity. With the newly minted university librarian in the audience, it was near perfection to watch her stand up at the end of their presentation and in turn thank the interns for the learning opportunity they have provided to us. By providing the interns with a platform to share their work at the broadest possible level, we are again demonstrating their value to the team and the broader organization.

In the third year, the interns embodied an openness to innovation that transcended all expectations. Openness to innovation can feel tied to the physical working environment, but in the spring of 2020, we transitioned to fully remote work as a result of efforts to slow the spread of COVID-19. We were able to replicate ceremonies remotely—using virtual sticky notes and whiteboards—and we experimented with mindfulness exercises as part of our divergent sessions. In a sense, the importance of our connection as a team was even more acute because we could not physically be together. We also had the opportunity to recognize the value of our unique work locations and circumstances. The transition to remote work has been a tremendous challenge for many to be transparent about both what "work from home" means and how we trust one another to continue our work together in the face of a global pandemic. Trust is an extension of positive bias—another building block of psychological safety. I trust that the interns are bringing their whole selves to the team, that they are making their best effort, not in spite of, but in light of the circumstances. They trust that I am doing my best to create learning opportunities and experiences in line with their goals—that I will offer constructive feedback at regular intervals and showcase their impact in our organization.

It feels like luck, but in retrospect, the job interview, the big brainstorming session, and the Agile approach intentionally contributed to an amazing inaugural class. We were able to jot down the ingredients, to inspect the process of building that initial cohort, but we did not feel confident that we could replicate the

recipe a second time. Then it happened again. The public demonstration of the interns' work, along with their own evangelizing to classmates and recognition at a national conference led to twice as many applicants in the second cohort. The changes in the way we ran the program, the introduction of dedicated divergent thinking and more individualized projects, developed organically as the interns took risks and made adaptations. In the third year we realized that this success was not random. These were not just library students interested in "digital stuff." They were engaged and excited applicants for a competitive and well-respected internship program—a great one.

It will not always feel like greatness. Remember that each cohort creates a new team, and that creative process requires time. In the first few sprints it may feel as if the interns do not understand how to create space for openness, how to be biased toward action. There are slow times, misalignments, communication gaps, and the constant fear that it will not work, but that is when you put faith back in the people. The team is made up of people—people who enjoy the work—working to get great things done—together.

We have used these ingredients to build a successful internship program, but we have also seen the program influence the way we manage employee teams. We employ shared boards for tracking self-directed work. We engage in regular demonstrations for large groups of library staff and retrospectives for individual teams. We have adopted regular divergent-thinking sessions into our shared calendar. These practices can foster curiosity, collaboration, and innovation within departments and across organizational silos. Our intern alumni have committed to bringing the methods and principles of this program to their own workplaces as employees and, as always, we should take the opportunity to learn from them.

> We have been able to take the principles and lessons we learned and apply them to work in disparate settings: a public university, a corporate library, and a government library.... Every library can find its own unique mix of these elements, as we did, that provides real, lasting benefits for the work and the people doing it. —Former DSI intern

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CHAPTER 6

Interns in Action

Exploring an LIS Internship Program at a Canadian University Library

Rumi Graham, Emma Scott, and Marissa Rocca

Introduction

The status and priority of library-related work experience in Canadian and American library school curricula have been much discussed and at times vigorously debated since the emergence of librarianship as a profession. In a paper first published in 1968, Rothstein traced a historical pattern of "shifting factors and weights" in the curricular ratio between library-based and classroom-based learning.[1] Despite a strong initial weighting toward apprentice-style practical learning in libraries in the last quarter of the nineteenth century, by the late 1960s a decided lean in the direction of theory-guided classroom instruction was evident.

Over fifty years after Rothstein's review, it remains the case that most North American master's degree programs in library and information studies (LIS)

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accredited by the American Library Association (ALA) do not require completion of an experiential learning component, although many offer the option to do so.[2] Such components, often referred to as internships, can vary widely along many dimensions such as when they are offered, their duration, if they are credit-bearing, whether interns are paid, the type and quality of assigned work, if they take place alongside or after traditional coursework, if they involve full- or part-time work, whether a virtual format is permitted, and the extent to which stakeholders at LIS schools and host libraries are active participants.

In this chapter we use *internship* inclusively to mean on-site work appropriate for professional librarians that is performed by LIS graduate students during co-op or practicum placements occurring prior to completion of their master's degree studies. As one way of examining the current relevance of acquiring library work experience while pursuing an LIS education, we set out to explore features and experiences of an internship program for LIS students that evolved at a Canadian university library over a ten-year period.

Since the early 1990s, the University of Lethbridge Library has hosted internships for students pursuing master's degrees in librarianship. At first the internships occurred irregularly, usually in response to inquiries from LIS schools in search of work placements for students interested in academic librarianship. From about 2009, however, the library began to take a more proactive approach by annually seeking to fill at least one librarian intern position with a student completing an LIS master's degree at a Canadian library school.

We were interested in studying the goals, benefits, and outcomes of LIS graduate student internships and work placements hosted at our library from 2009 to 2019, as ten years in, the time seemed ripe for a closer look at what had become a more or less regularized placement offering. The internships introduced LIS students to many aspects of librarianship in practical ways and assisted the library in carrying out core services and special projects. In several instances, interns were later awarded tenure-track professional librarian positions in our library, but we wondered what more could be learned from a wider sample of past interns.

University of Lethbridge Internships: The Lay of the Land

The setting of our investigation is the University of Lethbridge Library over a continuous ten-year period ending in 2019. The library provides instructional programs, research and information services, collections access and management, and quality study space to advance the scholarly and creative endeavours of the university's students, faculty, and researchers. Established in 1967 on traditional Blackfoot land, the University of Lethbridge is a public university located

in Southern Alberta, Canada. Remaining guided by foundational liberal education principles, the university is a research-intensive institution that is home to about 8,800 students who pursue undergraduate, master's, and doctoral degree programs in a variety of academic and professional fields.

The library is staffed by a team of approximately fifty, including five administration staff, ten professional librarians, three operations managers, fifteen operations and systems staff, and about fifteen undergraduate student assistants. Among the responsibilities held by professional librarians are information literacy instruction, including the teaching of credit-bearing information literacy courses; subject librarian liaison work; collection management; research consultation and research support services; leadership and management in specialized areas such as archives and copyright; and research.

While LIS graduate students have completed paid internships hosted by the library since at least the early 1990s, in the beginning these offerings occurred irregularly and usually took place in the summer when the normal volume and variety of academic activities on campus were much reduced. In about 2009, however, the library initiated what became an annual process of recruiting an LIS graduate student from the MLIS co-op program at the Faculty of Information and Media Studies (FIMS), Western University, for a paid one- or two-term internship position.[3] Student participation in the FIMS co-op program is optional and does not reduce the number of courses needed to graduate, although a pass/fail grade is assigned.

Besides annually offering one or more MLIS co-op internships for LIS graduate students between 2009 and 2019, in the same period the library also hosted one MLIS practicum placement for a student at the School of Library and Information Studies (SLIS), University of Alberta.[4] Although we use the term *internship* inclusively throughout this chapter, it is important to note that some structural differences exist between the FIMS co-op program and the SLIS practicum placement. The University of Lethbridge internships for FIMS and SLIS graduate students thus necessarily differed in some respects.

The SLIS practicum placement is a three-credit (credit/no credit) elective course involving 100 hours of workplace experience, which SLIS describes as full-time work for a three-week period. The school's practicum guidelines prohibit remuneration for the work performed by students enrolled in this course. We included the student who completed an SLIS practicum placement at our library in the pool of individuals invited to complete the intern survey, as we were interested in exploring experiential comparisons between the co-op and practicum internships.

In addition to duration and eligibility for remuneration, another difference between the internships for our co-op and practicum placement students was their supervisory structure. The practicum placement was completed under the

supervision of one subject liaison librarian, whereas co-op interns were supervised by the associate university librarian and worked collaboratively with a variety of librarians and other library staff. Supervision by one librarian created a concentration of work in a narrower range of areas that were primarily associated with the supervising librarian's particular responsibilities.

The library's main reasons for hiring LIS interns were initially to provide assistance in staffing the reference desk and to advance priority projects such as the development of LibGuides. About three years later when supervisory responsibility for the interns changed hands, library administration sought input from librarians regarding the kinds of professional work that could be suitable for interns. This consultation resulted in intern job postings that were less prescriptive and more accommodating of students' own areas of interest, although reference service remained a core element of assigned duties. The new postings were intended to expose interns to a variety of areas within the library and to allow internships to take on aspects of a mentorship program.

Another outcome of the change in supervisory responsibility for our librarian internship program occurred in 2013 in the form of a mentorship initiative. In this initiative, the librarian intern spent two to three weeks with each librarian to learn about their areas of responsibility and particular research interests. This particular form of mentorship occurred only once, but the mentorship idea was maintained, albeit more informally, in subsequent years. After 2013, it was common for individual librarians to reach out to the intern to arrange meetings, suggest collaborative projects, and offer support and mentorship throughout the intern's work term.

A review of the library's LIS intern postings from 2012 to 2019 revealed that each posting listed a common range of responsibilities: providing reference service, creating and maintaining LibGuides, assisting with general library instruction, participating in outreach events, and developing online tutorials. Posted librarian intern positions have never been confined to one department or area of service. This has allowed successful applicants to explore multiple areas within the library and to work with a wide range of librarians and other library staff. The postings also indicated other duties would be assigned as needed. In addition, from 2014 onward, the postings mentioned opportunities to work in areas such as collections and assessment, with the possibility of working on special projects that aligned with interns' personal interests.

A Tale of Two Surveys

Our study probes the experiences of both librarian interns and library staff during LIS internships hosted by the University of Lethbridge Library from 2009 to 2019. The following two research questions guided our study. In what ways have the library's internships benefited LIS graduate students as they prepared for professional roles, and reciprocally, in what ways has the library benefited

from intern contributions? How can we better understand ways in which library internships might be further enhanced or refined in the future?

We conducted two online surveys to help us explore our research questions. We invited fourteen individuals who had completed an LIS student internship at our library in the period 2009 to 2019 to participate in an intern survey (appendix A). In addition, we sent an invitation to complete a staff survey (appendix B) to thirty-eight individuals holding library staff positions as of December 2019, which included librarians, operations staff, and administrative staff. Staff invitations excluded student assistants but did include librarians who had retired between 2009 and 2019, as librarian interns work most closely with librarians.

No individual received more than one invitation to complete a survey relating to this study. One member of our research team received an invitation to complete the intern survey, as they had completed an LIS internship in the library in the period 2009 to 2019. Another team member received an invitation to complete the staff survey. The third member of our research team held an LIS internship during our study, but was ineligible to participate in either survey as their internship did not draw to a close until the end of the spring 2020 term.

Study protocols were approved by the University of Lethbridge Office of Research Ethics. Both surveys were conducted on the Qualtrics survey platform and remained open for three weeks over March–April 2020.[5] All survey responses were collected anonymously. Although the survey coincided with the early phase of the COVID-19 global pandemic during which academic activities and learning and workplace environments on Canadian university campuses were suddenly and drastically disrupted, the response rate for both surveys was robust: 50 percent for the intern survey and 45 percent for the staff survey.

Our data analysis methods were largely qualitative in nature. For each survey, the team member who took principal responsibility for analyzing the results was not a participant in that survey. The textual responses were first reviewed for meaning and then reviewed again repeatedly to identify common themes as well as unique perspectives and ideas among the survey participants' comments. We have anonymized quoted survey responses to protect the identity of participants.

Sifting the Responses

Intern Experiences

For all seven participants in the intern survey, gaining experience in libraries was a contributing factor in their decision to seek an internship. Only two respondents reported having little or no library experience prior to their internship. Four participants pursued an internship to gain experience in any kind of library, while two said they specifically sought placements in academic libraries. The five interns with previous library experience had worked in different types of

libraries while performing a variety of duties that ranged from shelving books to teaching classes and running programs.

All intern respondents expressed satisfied with the length of their internship. A clear preference was shown for the two-term internship, as all participants mentioned that the longer placement allowed them to pursue larger projects. Two participants noted that having their internships fall within the academic year was beneficial, one of whom commented that this enabled them to "fully experience the 'busy-ness' of an academic library." In contrast, interns who had placements over the summer months spoke of fewer opportunities to teach and fewer projects to complete. Table 6.1 presents duration and timing aspects of the internships.

Table 6.1
Temporal aspects of internships.

Temporal Aspect	**Number of Intern Respondents**
Duration	
8 months	5
Longer than 8 months	2
Time period	
Complete school year (September–April)	4
Other than a complete school year	3

As for work activities, in addition to the common duties outlined in the library's LIS internship postings, interns are typically involved in a selection of work teams or working groups. In some cases, interns are assigned to work teams, and in other cases, work teams are chosen by interns based on personal interest or a desire to gain particular experience or knowledge. Table 6.2 summarizes the work teams that were assigned to or chosen by interns.

Table 6.2
Intern respondents' assigned and chosen work teams.

Work Team	**Assigned to Interns (Number of Respondents)**	**Chosen by Interns (Number of Respondents)**
Assessment	2	1
Collections	2	3
Community engagement	3	2
Digitization	2	1
Information literacy instruction within a writing course	1	0

Work Team	Assigned to Interns (Number of Respondents)	Chosen by Interns (Number of Respondents)
Reference service	1	0
Research services	1	3

Of the various skills, listed in figure 6.1, that interns developed or honed over their internships, teaching was the only skill mentioned by every respondent. Overall, intern respondents said the practical application of course material helped them grow their understanding of librarianship. Five participants mentioned that courses completed prior to their internship provided a good foundation for their understanding of LIS concepts. In addition, five respondents reported they were able to use skills acquired during their LIS degree program in other contexts.

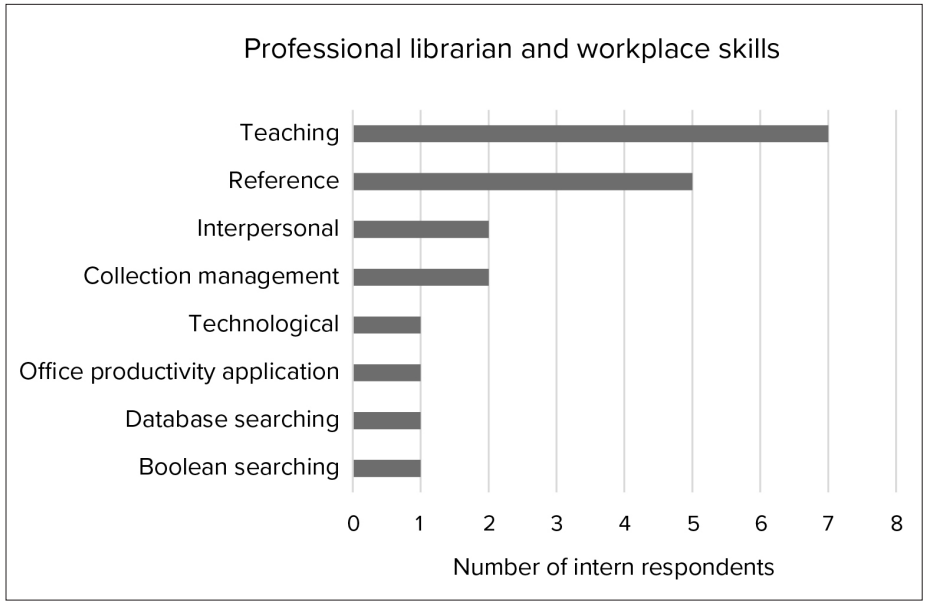


Figure 6.1
Professional skills developed by interns during their internships.

Respondents highlighted a variety of areas within the library and aspects of librarianship they would have liked to learn more about during their internships. These included public services, library management, professional librarians' discussion groups, librarian support of academic research, faculty liaison work,

collection development, electronic resource management, in-class instruction, and archives and special collections.

All intern respondents said they were currently employed as librarians or information specialists. Furthermore, some respondents noted they have taken on a mentorship role with LIS interns since becoming a professional librarian. Of five participants who answered the question about how their own LIS internship influenced their mentorship roles, two said they make a very conscious effort to reach out and aid new interns. The other three described ways in which the internship enhanced their understanding of the role of librarians as well as confidence in their own abilities, which in turn influenced the way they mentor interns or new librarians.

Staff Experiences

For the seventeen individuals who responded to the library staff survey, their reported interactions with interns ranged from indirect interactions in various activities to close working relationships. The identified activities included digitization work, event promotion and planning, technology outreach, collections projects, and subject-specific work. Table 6.3 outlines areas of staff-intern interactions.

Table 6.3
Library staff interactions with interns.

Context of Interaction	Number of Staff Respondents
Project work	7
Reference work	6
Work groups	4
Teaching	3
Mentorship	3
Librarian research	1
Indirect interaction	1

Staff respondents were asked to suggest activities in which they felt future interns could usefully participate, broken down by the library's work units. While many responses mentioned duties typically assigned to interns such as reference desk shifts, LibGuides development, general library instruction, online tutorials and outreach events, unique answers were also received, which are presented in table 6.4.

Table 6.4
Staff-suggested intern activities within particular library units.

Library Unit	Suggested Intern Activity	Number of Staff Respondents
Liaison Librarians	Teaching assistance	7
	Librarian project assistance	4
	Shadowing librarians	3
	Collection development	3
	Participation in librarian research	1
	Scholarly communication	1
Information Systems	Technological literacy instruction	2
	Information systems projects	2
	Digitization projects	1
	Other	1
Technical Services	Cataloguing	3
	Collections review	2
Access Services	Assessment projects	1
	Interlibrary loan service	1
	Other	1
Archives	Archives work	3
Administration	Event planning	1
	Mentorship/shadowing	1
	Administration projects	1
	Other	1

The importance of intern interest in the suggested activities was highlighted most often in reference to Archives work. A related concern was raised by a staff respondent who noted that, while interns could participate in Information Systems–related activities, opportunities are limited, and interns may not have the required skills. One notable comment suggested that interns could participate in Access Services work by "reviewing best practices for the delivery of front-line services." In another comment relating to the Administration unit, a respondent wrote that interns could gain "an understanding of the role of Librarians in collegial governance."

Evaluating the Internship Program: Mutual Reflections

In different ways, the surveys asked both interns and library staff to assess the value of the library's internship program. Instruction, working on LibGuides, and opportunities to shadow more experienced librarians are among the various experiences intern respondents said were the most useful in their internships. Regarding how interns have benefitted the library, eight staff respondents noted that interns have increased the library's staffing capacity in the areas of reference service and general operations as well as engagement in projects. Six staff noted interns' beneficial contributions to the library's information literacy instruction, and five staff highlighted interns' assistance with work team activities.

Reflecting on intern participation in library instruction, a staff respondent highlighted the value "for students in the classroom to see a fellow student and support them." Another staff member said, "It seems many interns have gravitated towards instruction but I'm not sure if that is based on their interests or whether there are more available opportunities in this area." Of four staff who remarked on interns' refreshing and positive perspectives, one commented that new viewpoints were helpful "whether it is the implementation of a new technology, a development in the field they studied, or their enthusiasm to be joining the profession." Another staff respondent recognized the value of new skills introduced to the library by interns.

In response to a question about aspects of the library's internship program that are particularly well organized, four staff noted the effectiveness of how interns are integrated into the workflow of library activities. Other staff members spoke positively about the detailed orientation process that introduces interns to staff across all library units, having interns shadow staff on the reference desk, inviting interns to library meetings, offering interns flexibility in their choice of projects, and involving interns in all aspects of the library.

In terms of aspects of their internships that interns considered to be the least useful, two said they thought the amount of time spent on the reference desk was too high. One participant mentioned that the lack of payment during their internship was a hindrance, and another participant believed they did not have enough duties to keep them busy during a portion of their placement. Other less useful aspects mentioned by intern respondents included being asked to participate in a work group that did not correspond to their particular skill set and having fewer opportunities to assist with in-class information literacy instruction than were desired.

Both staff and intern respondents were invited to suggest ways in which the library's internship program could be improved. Staff recommendations included allowing interns to be more involved in library committee work and university activities outside of the library. Two staff respondents also suggested that more

information could be shared with staff about interns before their arrival to facilitate project planning based on interns' interests.

A common area in which staff and interns offered suggestions for improvement was supervision, which was the purview of library administration in the ten-year period of our study. Five staff recommended changes to the supervisory model that included increasing the amount of structure and providing more direct supervision to support students who may struggle with self-direction or feel "unguided." The main areas of potential improvement touched on by intern respondents were the "openness" of the internship and the style of supervision, which may not be suitable for all interns. Weekly meetings with a supervisor were appreciated by one participant as an important time to check in, and four participants noted more supervisor input might be beneficial.

Themes and Variations

The rapid onset of COVID-19 closures that began to ripple across the globe in mid-March 2020 preceded the launch of our survey by less than two weeks. And as we analyzed our survey results in a mandated work-at-home environment, we gained a new appreciation for the extent to which education, scholarship, and academic librarianship can in fact take place virtually. These unusual circumstances have coloured our analytical lenses in ways we could not have predicted at the outset.

Our examination of the responses to both surveys yielded five themes. One theme reflects the role played by proactive self-direction in the success of the library's internship program. Another theme highlights the value of allowing interns the flexibility to choose projects and work teams. A theme that surfaced in responses to both surveys is contrasting views of reference work. Additionally, themes of mentorship and employability are also evident in both intern and staff responses. In this section we consider how these themes help shed light on our two research questions.

Proactivity

A central research question for this study is how internships mutually benefit LIS graduate students and the library as host. Both interns' and staff responses reflected on the interplay between success and assertive self-direction.

From the staff perspective, several respondents identified motivation, initiative, and assertiveness as key ingredients for intern success. For example, one staff member said, "LIS internships have been beneficial to greater or lesser degrees depending on the students themselves (mostly related to their level of personal motivation and initiative)." Others expressed concern that insufficient initiative could lead interns to "drift into the gravitational pull of persons who first involve

them in their own activities" or leave them feeling "adrift and unguided, and unsure what they should be working on—depending on how assertive they are about seeking out relationships and projects with librarians, and how good they are at working independently." Similarly, another staff member observed that less self-directed interns at times seemed to be "lost" and perhaps bored.

From the intern perspective, at times there was insufficient work. One respondent said, "I had very little to do [for the first four months] which I found frustrating and made me feel undervalued. Any work is better than no work. I was frustrated by hierarchies (i.e. this meeting is only open to professional librarians) which denied me some learning experiences." Another intern noted that their internship felt very self-driven:

> If I had an area I wanted to learn more about I had to pursue those projects myself quite often. Having a clearer program of what skills I needed to touch on would have been helpful. Previous interns gave me the advice to be self-driven and that was valuable to know going into the internship.

Additionally, one intern said their supervisor had a very "hands-off approach, which I found worked well, but it may work less well for others." They also suggested "it could be helpful for the intern supervisor to have a list of different kinds of activities to offer to incoming interns for them to read, and then have a conversation early on about which activities they'd most like to become involved in." Although McGurr and Damasco suggest it is ultimately up to the student to ensure that their internship runs smoothly, this may disadvantage students who are inexperienced in self-promotion.[6] To offset such potential disadvantages, Dixon notes a "student centred" approach can help students feel empowered to find effective ways of meeting their professional and learning goals during the internship.[7]

Flexibility

On the other hand, intern responses showed an appreciation for the openness and flexibility of the library's internships. Four participants said they enjoyed the "self-driven" nature of the placement, as it allowed them to pursue their interests and gain experience in areas they wished to explore. One intern who stepped away from less compelling archival work in order to pursue a LibGuides project said, "The great thing about this placement was that I was able to learn about whatever I was interested in."

To increase the likelihood of an enriching learning experience, McGurr and Damasco advise students to pursue their interests by asking questions of everyone involved, including themselves, throughout the process of selecting and

completing an internship.[8] A respondent to our intern survey who appeared to embrace the spirit of this approach wrote, "The openness of the internship really allowed me to pursue what I felt was relevant to my interests, yet there was still accountability ensured through weekly meetings with a supervisor." Ferrer-Vinent and Sobel suggest that a balance between structure and flexibility is preferred by interns, "with perhaps more structure in the beginning progressing into more freedom."[9]

A number of staff members commented that a flexible and self-guided approach supported interns' learning processes. One respondent observed that allowing interns to interact with different groups in the library contributed to students' professional growth:

> The opportunity to be mentored by multiple individuals is something that benefits the intern immensely. Even if [library staff] have similar titles, we all have very different roles, backgrounds, perspectives, and approaches to our practice. It is important for the intern to see that there isn't just one way in librarianship—and, in fact, that they should seize the opportunity to find their own path in their practice.

Reference Service

A core element of the library's largely self-directed LIS internships is reference service. As interns are typically assigned a significantly greater share of scheduled reference service than other library staff, it was unsurprising to find that all staff comments about intern participation in reference desk work were positive. One staff member stated the "Co-op Intern helps tremendously," and another said intern assistance with reference service is "absolutely necessary." Furthermore, one comment pointed out the role played by interns in backup coverage: "Our LIS interns are the ones who most often are willing to take extra shifts in the event of illness etc., which gives the library a lot of flexibility we wouldn't have otherwise." This coverage allowed staff to attend to other work priorities.

While the contributions made by interns to the reference desk team are undoubtedly very valuable, it is important to consider what interns may be required to forego if they are asked to shoulder a disproportionately large share of hours at the reference desk. Reflecting on a personal LIS internship, Warren notes having had less time to train and pursue other projects as a result of scheduled hours on the reference desk.[10] Based on those experiences, Warren encourages host libraries to include reference work in LIS internships, but cautions against using interns "to plug holes in scheduling or hiring."[11]

Some intern respondents appreciated the chance to gain reference experience, especially those who did not have previous work experience in academic

libraries. Two interns noted that their time at the reference desk was useful. The majority of interns mentioned reference consultation as a skill they were able to develop during their internship. One intern observed that "other things like reference interviews are developed the more you do them, so being able to learn about the principles first and then put them into action is key."

Other intern respondents expressed variant views. While acknowledging the importance of reference experience, one intern felt "the amount of time spent on the desk was excessive." A different intern noted, "There is a lot of desk time required, which is normal in most practicums, but I do think that ensuring that the individual overseeing the practicum is checking in often and in a compassionate way is very important." Since reference is a key service in which most of the library's professional librarians participate, it is appropriate to involve LIS interns in this work. At the same time, Lewey and Moody-Goo note the desirability of involving interns in a rich variety of professional librarian work to maximize the likelihood of a "meaningful, beneficial, and transformative" internship.[12]

Mentorship

Regarding how to improve the internship program, one intern suggested a peer mentor could be assigned to interns to field their questions. Another wrote that one of the most useful aspects of their internship was "watching and learning from very experienced colleagues… I was fortunate to be mentored by individuals who have 20+ [years of] professional experience." Ferrer-Vinent and Sobel observe that respondents to their survey of former LIS practicum students said one way to improve the academic library's practicum program might be to provide several mentors.[13]

Other interns said their internship led them to assume mentorship roles when they began work as a librarian. One such respondent observed that having previous experience helped them understand what would be valuable to an LIS intern. Reflecting on their experiences after landing an academic librarian position, another intern respondent noted that interns came to them with questions they were not comfortable asking other staff members. In an informal mentor role, the latter respondent said they were able to suggest "projects or work that would complement the theoretical work" the LIS interns had already completed.

McGurr and Damasco recommend open communication as a way of promoting successful internship outcomes.[14] An intern respondent who was subsequently hired as a librarian at the University of Lethbridge wrote that their internship experience strongly influenced their mentorship role:

> Since I started in my current position as a librarian… I've made it a point to have coffee with the intern two or three times during their

> internship. We typically talk about what they've been involved in, what they'd like to be involved in, and gaps in their experience.

Additionally, this staff member said they strive to "ensure that [interns] are able to make the most of their experience." Lacy and Copeland refer to this sort of mentorship as a repayment of "debt" to the profession.[15]

Ketcham advises libraries that are considering hosting an internship to first assess whether capable and interested staff are ready to act as mentors.[16] A staff respondent to our survey suggested a more explicit mentorship model would improve the internship program. Other staff observed that mentorship tends to happen organically when interns approach librarians to discuss their area of expertise or to seek advice or assistance in working through issues related to library politics, professionalism, or managing difficult situations. Dixon notes this type of problem-solving can be difficult to learn in the classroom.[17] Moreover, Holland experienced "professional surprise" upon discovering the theoretical knowledge gained through LIS graduate education was insufficient preparation for the practical challenges they faced as a new librarian.[18]

Echoing findings of an LIS mentorship study by Lacy and Copeland, a staff respondent observed mentorship to be beneficial for librarians as well.[19] They commented that mentorship is "mostly informal, as 'supervision' of the intern seems to be under the umbrella of Library Administration." Another staff member described mentoring interns as "a very rewarding aspect of professional work." Lewey and Moody-Goo suggest the incorporation of supportive mentorship into an LIS internship can provide an enriching experience for interns and librarians alike.[20] They recommend that mentor-intern pairs regularly check in with each other to gauge progress on projects, allow for constructive feedback, and ensure the internship progresses in a way that is instructive for the intern and beneficial to the library as a whole.

Along with supportive mentorship, Lewey and Moody-Goo identify purposeful planning and training, reflection and assessment, and authentic professional librarian work as four key ingredients of a successful LIS internship.[21] They view authenticity to be achievable by treating interns as integral members of the library staff and assigning responsibilities to interns that are commensurate with those of professional librarians. This approach allows for more variety in work assignments and avoids situations in which interns find themselves "completing mounds of busy work while doing nothing to better themselves as future librarians."[22]

Employability

Interestingly, when asked about highlights of the library's internship program, several staff mentioned the hiring of previous interns. Since 2016, four previous

interns have been hired as professional librarians at the University of Lethbridge. This turn of events arose from a unique set of circumstances: several librarians retired within a few years of each other and the resulting posted vacancies were all successfully filled by applicants who had completed LIS internships at our library. These circumstances allowed library staff to observe firsthand the benefits of strong relationships and institutional knowledge acquired through the internships as the new librarians began their work. One staff member wrote:

> What an incredible opportunity for both intern and library to "test each other out." This is an incredible source of future, experienced employees—and they've all done so well. I look at our current tenure-track librarians/former interns and reflect on how well-developed they are at this point in their careers and what they're bringing to this library, the university, and the professions in terms of their practice, service, and research contributions.

Some staff described internships as "effective trial runs of a sort" and "an eight-month trial period for determining if an intern might make a good 'fit' for future employment." A case report by Raszewski and Peterson corroborates the importance of LIS work experience, as some students felt their practicum projects helped them secure a librarian position.[23] Eckard, Rosener, and Scripps-Hoekstra note that academic library internships improve the chances of a successful academic library job search.[24] But as Rathbun-Grubb observes, "While much has been discussed about their potential benefits… little is known about measurable associations between LIS EPA [end of program assessments such as internships] and subsequent career success across the field."[25] Additionally, while the relationship between LIS internships and employability is well discussed in the literature, research on long-term benefits of library investment in recruiting former interns into professional librarian positions is scarce.

Acquiring library experience was important for interns. One intern said having no experience when applying for jobs could be seen as a deterrent. Another wrote that gaining experience was "100% the reason I chose to do an unpaid practicum." When asked to identify the most useful part of their internship, one respondent said,

> Frankly, it was that I could put 'academic library experience' on my cv. The academic librarian culture is such that, even with an MLIS, commensurate experience, such as teaching & designing full term university courses, is not considered enough to qualify you for work as an academic librarian.

Discussions with LIS faculty and librarians led Dixon to a similar conclusion that experiential education is key to student learning and to "what employers expect from new librarians."[26]

Lessons Learned

In the end, what did we learn from staff and former LIS interns about the overall value of the library's internship program and ways in which it might be improved? For interns, the program has evidently fostered a flexible and largely diverse learning environment in which they gained practical professional skills and learned about other aspects of an academic library's workplace culture that tend to be less accessible in a classroom setting. Flexibility is valuable only to the extent that it is effectively leveraged by a student, however.

A student-centred approach aiming to help students make the most of their internship could include a more deliberate mentorship pairing. Mentorship could perhaps be expanded through the creation of an informal mentorship club involving interns and interested librarians that meets periodically to share interesting stories and experiences from the frontlines of intern and professional librarian practice. Additionally, while intern proactivity is highly encouraged, providing more structure in the early stages of an internship may assist students in meeting their personal and professional goals more effectively.

For the library, there is widespread recognition of the important boost that interns provide to the library's staffing capacity in reference service and instruction-related areas. Staff also appreciate interns for their generally positive, fresh perspectives and for new skills, approaches, and knowledge they bring to their host community. Furthermore, mentoring interns is rewarding work for professional librarians, as it provides an opportunity to perpetuate a virtuous circle of reciprocal learning and sharing experiences and information relevant to professional practice. Looking to the future, the quality of new internships could be enhanced by regularly inviting librarians to assist with planning, particularly those who have completed LIS internships.

Conducting our surveys during the COVID-19 pandemic prompted us to reflect more carefully on the changing and adaptable nature of academic librarian work. While our library has traditionally hosted in-person LIS internships, one member of our research team finished her internship remotely due to the sudden closure of our library during the pandemic. This global health emergency occurred against a local backdrop of sustained deep cuts to post-secondary funding by the provincial government and plunging oil prices affecting the province's coffers, all of which combine to place the future of our internship program in jeopardy for the time being.

For the first time in over ten years, our library began the 2020 school year without a new MLIS graduate student intern in place. In the event that this

internship program is reinstated in the not-too-distant future, we believe it would be fruitful at that time to review our survey respondents' ideas on how the program might be further enhanced and to make adjustments accordingly. Intern and staff respondents identified several ways in which internships could be better structured with more openness and inclusivity and a customized approach to intern supervision.

At the same time, the enriching benefits that our internship program has yielded to date for LIS students and the library (and the university) are clear and compelling. Is it time for our library to pursue other modes and options for hosting future LIS internships? Are there ways we can still mentor new students while giving them practical experience to complement their learning? Should virtual LIS internships become more common? Do internships delivered online require key ingredients beyond the four—mentorship, planning, authenticity, and assessment—that guide quality in-person experiences? Our study appears to have generated more questions than it has answered, which points to fertile ground for future investigation.

APPENDIX 6A

Survey Questions for Interns

1. To what extent was gaining experience in an academic library a factor in your decision to pursue an internship or work placement?
2. Did you have any experience working or volunteering in a library prior to the completion of your LIS internship or work placement at the University of Lethbridge Library?
    - If yes, what type of library work did you do? For how long?
3. How long was your internship or work placement?
    - Were you satisfied with the length of your internship or work placement? (Why or why not?)
4. Over which months did your internship or work placement occur?
    - Were you satisfied with the timing of your internship or work placement? (Why or why not?)
5. What did you find to be the most useful experiences in your internship or work placement?
6. What did you find to be the least useful experiences in your internship or work placement?
7. What are some ways that future LIS internships or work placements at the University of Lethbridge Library could be improved?
8. What professional skills were you able to develop or hone during your internship or work placement?
    - How did the practical application of your course material grow your understanding of librarianship?
9. Which Library committees or work groups (if any) were you assigned to during your internship or work placement?
10. Which Library committees or work groups (if any) did you choose to join during your internship or work placement and why?
11. Which areas of the Library (if any) would you have liked to learn more about?
12. Are you currently employed as a library or information specialist?
    - If no, have you been able to use skills acquired during your LIS degree program in other contexts?
13. Have you had the opportunity to mentor other graduate LIS students?
    - If yes, how do you feel your LIS internship or work placement experiences influenced your mentorship role?

APPENDIX 6B

Survey Questions for Staff

1. During the period January 2009 to December 2019, did you have opportunities to work with one or more LIS (library and information studies) graduate student interns or work placement students as they completed work-integrated learning at the University of Lethbridge Library?
    - If yes, briefly describe those opportunities.
    - If no, do you wish you had more opportunities to work with LIS graduate students?
2. How have LIS internships or work placements at the Library benefited Library programs, services, or operations?
    - Which Library programs, services, or operations do you believe have particularly benefited?
3. What has worked particularly well in how LIS internships and work placements have been organized?
4. For the following units within the Library, please briefly describe activities that you believe LIS interns and work placement students could usefully participate in. (liaison librarians, information systems, tech services, access services, university archives, administration)
5. What are some ways in which future LIS internships and work placements at the University of Lethbridge Library could be enhanced?
6. In your view, what are the highlights of LIS internships and work placements that have been hosted by the Library in the period 2009 to 2019?

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Voices from the Field

Internship

What's in a Name?

Rumi Graham, Emma Scott, and Marissa Rocca

At the outset of our study discussed in Chapter 6, we regarded *internship* to be a work opportunity for an LIS graduate student at the University of Lethbridge Library and *intern* to be a student participant in such an opportunity, as these are terms our library has been accustomed to using for some time. In perusing the professional literature, however, we quickly encountered a need to clarify the meaning and scope of *internship*, as there appears to be wide variance in how it is defined.

We find it useful to consider the concept of *internship* within the broader landscape of hands-on workplace-situated education that has been variously labeled *experiential learning*, *field experience*, *structured workplace learning*, and *practice-based learning*.[1] While terminology in common usage within the field has shifted over time, in general, an enduring idea is that LIS graduate students' workplace-situated learning is structured and supervised.

Rothstein understood practice work to encompass classroom demonstrations, laboratory work, projects, and field work to involve learning in locations "where the student is detached from the class to do actual work in a library."[2] He identified field work as the focus of his 1968 paper, as do we in this chapter. Viewing it as a complementary component to theory, Rothstein suggested practice work in LIS is roughly comparable to clinical experience in the education and training programs of medical and other health professions.[3]

Among LIS schools, internship is sometimes conceived as a form of fieldwork called *practicum*, although this term, too, is variously defined. Witucke understood practicum broadly as "library experience sponsored by the library as part of its instruction,"[4] whereas Monroe defined it more precisely: "relatively short-term work experience (two to six weeks of full-time employment in a library situation, or a semester or two of approximately 10 to 12 hours weekly)."[5] Finding that "a bewildering array of titles exist for the practicum," Coleman used the term to cover all practical experiences such as field experience, fieldwork, and internship.[6] Among others who have adopted a similar approach are Ball, McGurr and Damasco, Ferrer-Vinent and Sobel, and Bird and Crumpton.[7]

Differing views on LIS internship characteristics also abound. Grotzinger considered internship to be a form of practicum that is longer than four

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months.[8] Witucke defined internship as "supervised library experience at a professional level following completion of library school course work; comparable to a medical internship, with a systematic plan for library experience. Stipend."[9] Similarly, Dotson saw internship as library-situated learning that is additional to LIS coursework and takes place under the direction of a qualified librarian for a set number of hours.[10] Monroe distinguished between "post-degree internships that follow professional study" and "pre-masters internships" involving full-time work typically timed to occur after all coursework is completed and lasting several months to a year.[11]

Other considerations are relevant beyond timing, duration, and whether remuneration is offered. Bird and Crumpton contrasted credit-bearing internships and practicums with extracurricular part-time work, observing that the degree to which all stakeholders are actively involved in an internship can vary.[12] A study by McGurr and Damasco noted the scope and meaningfulness of work assigned to LIS interns may not always be optimal.[13] A survey of international LIS education programs by Bird, Chu, and Oguz showed that, unlike ALA-accredited schools, the majority of master's level programs in respondents' countries required an internship.[14] Their study also found that, globally, virtual LIS internships are rarely permitted.

Additional terms in the LIS literature denoting concepts similar or related to internship include "trainee programs and work-study programs" described by Monroe as "usually involv[ing] paid employment at a sub-professional level and requir[ing] activities selected to serve the needs of the library rather than serving the learning needs of the students."[15] *Co-operative education program* (*co-op*) is another term for library-situated learning preferred by some institutions.[16]

Internship is now often discussed as an example of *work-integrated learning* (WIL), with key aspects mirroring those of earlier conceptions of fieldwork and practicum. WIL is generally understood to be an educational program component comprising workplace-situated experiential learning that complements or is integrated with in-class study.[17] Observing that WIL is both "nothing new" and "a uniquely 21st century phenomenon and public policy response to the transformative power of ICTs [information and communications technologies]," Stevenson and Hannaford described a new WIL program offering opportunities for LIS students to intern for two years in one of the University of Toronto's libraries.[18]

To summarize, internships are infrequently a required element of Canadian and American LIS graduate programs today. Internships vary widely along many dimensions, such as when they are offered, their duration, if they are credit-bearing, whether interns are paid, the type and quality of assigned work, if they take place alongside or after traditional coursework, if they involve full-

or part-time work, whether a virtual format is permitted, and the extent to which stakeholders at LIS schools and host libraries are active participants.

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VOICES FROM THE FIELD

Theory + Practice = Student Success

Allison Kittinger

Introduction

I had never worked in a library before my position as a research and instruction assistant at Robert B. House Undergraduate Library in the first year of my master of science in library science program at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. Over the first year of my program, the specific combination of courses and work responsibilities I had was ultimately crucial to my developing confidence in working in a library setting and a sense of preparedness for postgraduation academic library jobs. Although this positive outcome was due to serendipity more than intentional planning on my part, I strongly believe that it can be strategically engineered and applied to a wide variety of graduate student work experiences.

The Position

My duties at the Undergraduate Library during my first year included providing reference services and research consultations, managing the library's research blog, coordinating library programming and outreach events, participating in collection development, and teaching first-year English instruction sessions and library workshops. As I gained a better understanding of academic librarianship, I got the sense that I was building a foundational set of skills that is applicable to a wide range of academic library positions. This feeling was reinforced when I saw the skills I acquired reflected in academic librarian job descriptions.

In addition to my duties at the Undergraduate Library, the hands-on training I received was immensely helpful in increasing my confidence and independence in my position. Because we often receive questions about scanning and printing in the library, our training required us to directly scan and print various documents and learn how to troubleshoot common issues. We also shadowed both professional staff and second-year graduate assistants during instruction sessions and on the reference desk in the beginning, which gave me the opportunity to get advice from the people I was shadowing and practice skills such as reference interviews and teaching with immediate feed-

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back. My favorite part of the training was completing a sheet of item search exercises where we had to search for an item and detail how we found it. Going over this with my trainer was eye-opening in that I realized there often is more than one right way to complete a reference task.

The autonomy I was given, the training, and my duties at the Undergraduate Library all reflect the collaborative, open learning environment there. Even though my position is temporary as a student worker, student assistants are explicitly invited to library staff events and meetings. I had frequent check-ins with my supervisor, and I received practical and professional advice, such as conference and course recommendations, from both second-year graduate assistants and library staff. In fact, I even received some advice during my interview about courses that complement the position, which I took to my great benefit.

The Courses

The recommendation I got during the interview was to take two required courses, Reference and Collection Development, in my first semester because these classes would complement my hands-on work at the Undergraduate Library with a more theoretical framework. My graduate student handbook also suggested that I take these classes in the first year of study, so I decided to follow my future colleagues' recommendation.

What ended up happening was that I learned about strategies and considerations around reference interviews and collections policies in the classroom that I directly applied to my position at the Undergraduate Library. I also was able to contribute valuable anecdotes about my work experience to class conversations and assignments, which reinforced concepts for myself as well as for my classmates. Being able to learn and contribute positively to my academic community through both professional and classroom channels increased my confidence in both my choice to go to graduate school for library science and my certainty that a career in librarianship is right for me.

Recommendations for Managers

- Show students how the skills they learn will translate to their ideal positions.
- Provide hands-on training.
- Schedule regular check-ins.
- Treat students as a part of the library staff, and invite them to meetings and library events.

Recommendations for Students

- Ask senior graduate students in your program for their recommendations or advice.
- Look for synergies between the LIS courses you take and your practicum or work experiences.
- Compare student position descriptions to descriptions of librarian positions you would like to have in the future.

CHAPTER 7

Practice Made (More) Perfect

Sonia Archer-Capuzzo and Nora J. Bird, with Kyle Burkett, Aspen Chang, Sarah Fetzer, Rebekah Hilton, Sujeit Llanes, Alyssa Nance, Soni Philip, and Morgan Pruitt

Educating the next generation of librarians requires a combined effort involving practicing librarians, library educators and the programs that they represent, and the profession represented through its many allied organizations. This chapter will examine the practicum program at the library and information science (LIS) program of the University of North Carolina at Greensboro (UNCG). First accredited by the American Library Association in 1982, the program focuses primarily on libraries, archives, and similar information organizations as the place where people and information connect through services provided by professional librarians. About one-third of the students specialize in service to higher education institutions at the community college, four-year liberal arts, and university levels. The program recently instituted a requirement for students to complete hours in a workplace setting as part of a capstone course, but this chapter is based on reports from students who completed a 120-hour practicum elective (also sometimes called an internship, field experience, or other names, depending on the institution).[1] Through the use of a survey and gathered testimonials, the students reported on their experiences with learning while doing in the field.

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Background

The education of library professionals began as training programs or apprenticeships that were located within and managed by individual libraries and their librarian staff. The content of these programs was unique to each institution, as most shared few processes and procedures. As library standards were established and the demand for library workers increased, it became obvious that centralized education would be more efficient. In the early 1880s, Melvil Dewey established the first School of Library Economy at Columbia University. Although the curriculum was set, there was also a strong emphasis on apprenticeships, and other early library programs, including one at the Los Angeles Public Library, combined courses with frequent work in libraries.[2]

The move to the master's degree as the preparation for professional roles deemphasized the apprenticeship and focused on academic preparation. Indeed, library school programs remain mixed on whether to require a practicum. A recent unpublished review of program requirements showed that only 26 percent of the sixty-six ALA-accredited programs demand this type of experiential learning, but the numbers change frequently. Over the years, practicing librarians have criticized the strength of practical preparation among recent graduates and called on LIS programs to institute experiential learning requisites.[3]

Experiential learning can be transformative for all parties involved in the work if that goal is intentionally embedded into the design of the practicum, as shown in a multiyear project entitled Real Learning Connections.[4] In that study, the supervising practitioner, the library student, and the library program all learned something from the boundary-spanning that is required when students encounter work for the first time and supervisors reengage with the academy. In fact, the entire organization may evolve in these situations because the student or the library professor overseeing the experience may question current practice.[5] Rethinking, redesigning, or updating can emerge when naivete, knowledge, and experience converge. The curriculum can also change in response to the evaluations by the supervising librarian and the students, leading to modifications in existing courses and the development of new offerings.

Library education is now almost exclusively presented in various online formats. Although there are still in-person classes in some programs, 85 percent of UNCG LIS students, for instance, are registered as distance/online. This has created challenges and opportunities for arranging practicums. Academic libraries in institutions with LIS graduate programs sometimes offer a paid opportunity to practice reference skills,[6] but as LIS programs have switched to a primarily online mode of delivery, there has been a change in their ability to recruit. Some have started to use virtual student help, especially to do chat reference and create tutorials.[7] Many library activities can be done virtually, including social media creation and distribution; digital collection enhancement, including adding

metadata and creating new records; and embedded librarianship. One of our longest running virtual practicums has been hosted by a community college where library students are embedded in a class and produce tutorials, answer questions, and provide instruction for the students in that class.[8]

Additionally, students may not be confined by the location of a library school. Therefore, students may be looking for opportunities well beyond college towns and cities, allowing more rural libraries to enjoy the benefits of a student intern. The opportunity to work with multiple library schools also presents challenges, as each school may have unique requirements to be negotiated. Open lines of communication throughout the practicum with the LIS program can overcome many of these challenges. For example, at UNCG

1. A practicum liaison acts as the point person for questions and works directly with the students and sites to set up goals, expectations, and rules.
2. The practicum liaison keeps a database of potential practicums that may be available during any semester. Job ads can be shared with students via a departmental jobs board or the departmental electronic discussion list. While this does not guarantee that each site will find a student worker each semester, as our students are distributed around the country, it increases students' awareness of sites that will welcome their interest.
3. A faculty member supervises the practicum class, gives grades, administers evaluations, and handles problems that occur during the semester of the experience. The professor assigns learning activities such as reflective journaling and other short exercises that encourage students to connect theory with practice.

Gathering Stories

To gain a deeper understanding of what students see as a successful practicum, we invited eighty-five current and former students in the UNCG MLIS program to take a survey (see appendix); all had completed the practicum in the past three years. Of those, twenty-two (approximately 26 percent) provided usable responses. All respondents were anonymous. We also asked eight current and former students to provide longer testimonials about their practicum experiences. All eight responded. Several central themes that led to practicum success emerged in the surveys and testimonials: preparation (on the student's part and on the part of the host institution and supervisor), communication, and respect.

Preparation

In her testimonial, Alyssa Nance wrote,

> One thing I heard from others in my cohort was that their placements weren't really prepared to help them meet their goals in some way, so I appreciated the preparation and thoughtfulness that my site supervisors put into crafting my experience.

Preparation for the practicum is the responsibility of the student and the site.

Preparation for the student begins with their coursework in the MLIS program. Aspen Chang wrote,

> The biggest thing that helped—and I am not exaggerating—was all the LIS class[es] I had taken up to that point.... There isn't a particular aspect of the class that helped, but [it] did help me to map out what objectives I needed to accomplish with the materials and time I had on hand.

However, coursework alone cannot prepare every student to step into a practicum without guidance. Soni Philip wrote that "the practical purpose of some… coursework… was unclear," so for those students who have never worked in a library or similar organization, a practicum is an important way to gain experience and tie what they learned in class to what they will do as professionals. Joint preparation on the part of the site and the student can help students feel ready for this new and vital experience.

Sites can begin planning for student volunteers by carefully crafting job descriptions for practicums. This provides a starting point from which they and the student can work to set goals and design projects. Goal setting is central to a successful practicum. Fifteen of the twenty-two survey respondents indicated that they worked with their site supervisor to set goals unique to the student. Rebekah Hilton wrote, "My supervisor… worked with me to create **specific and measurable goals**, which were weekly in my case… this helped give me perspective, so I could see progress even in as little as a week" (emphasis in original). Hilton is not alone in these thoughts. Other students also cited goals "driven by [their] learning and career interests" as being highly beneficial, and many also emphasized the importance of having smaller weekly goals that helped them see progress throughout the semester.[9]

Sites must also plan for the onboarding procedures that will be necessary to have the student accomplish the planned goals. This might include specific training, information technology (IT) access and passwords, parking, and transportation. Training may include only what is necessary for the library work, but for one practicum in a medical library attached to a large medical center, the student was required to take a daylong safety course in order to be in the building. IT access may mean having an institutional email address, and that may require the student to be considered staff. It is important to consider practicum

participants' status. Are they more like work-study students or like staff? How will they be referred to during the experience? These issues should be clear as the practicum job description is being written.

If students are going to be considered more like staff, sites should consider requiring an interview before the experience. This will give students a chance to practice professionalism and communication skills as they research the institution that they are applying to and get ready to answer questions about their knowledge, skills, and abilities. An interview takes time but can avoid problems later.

Students were overwhelmingly positive about sites that specifically tied the tasks and projects students would work on to their goals. Kyle Burkett wrote, "I think the most important thing was having a specific project to work on. While I was working on the… project, the library and I had clear goals and expectations, so that part of [the practicum] ran very smoothly." A specific project or set of projects that a student is assigned for the semester is an excellent way for them not only to learn, but also to produce a final product that the practicum site can benefit from and that the student can point to as they enter the job market.

We cannot overemphasize the importance of tying projects to goals set by the student and site supervisor. This communicates clear expectations to the student, an important element of a successful practicum.[10] As Philip wrote,

> The structure of my practicum experience, and the LIS [practicum] course, combined to make my practicum experience a success. The practicum… was structured to provide me with the skills and knowledge [I needed] to collaborate with [my] team to develop, present, and promote programs and professional services.

This clarity helps the student do better work (which benefits the student *and* the practicum site), but it has an added benefit. Feeling that the practicum is an experience designed by and for them encourages students to do their best work. It also helps the host institution utilize the strengths and interests of each student in the best way for that person and the library. Nance echoed these sentiments, writing,

> I think the two main things that made my practicum a success were that I was well prepared and that my placements were able to be flexible and creative in creating tasks that would allow me to meet my learning goals.

In response to the emphasis students and site supervisors placed on setting goals, the UNCG LIS department has integrated goal setting into the preparation process students engage in for their capstone course field experience. All

students completing a field experience as part of their capstone course will now turn in a set of goals and associated projects before the beginning of their field experience semester. Students and supervisors are guided through the process with an open-ended list of questions and may call upon the practicum liaison as needed for feedback. If the program is successful, it will be expanded to include all students completing a practicum or capstone field experience.

Communication

In their 2011 article, Ferrer-Vinent and Sobel wrote that "one of the best aspects [of a practicum] for students is the insight, attitudes, and knowledge gained from interaction with site librarians."[11] McGurr and Damasco also emphasize the importance of communication, further pointing out that students need to communicate effectively with supervisors.[12] As stated above, communication should start with a conversation between the student and site that leads to goal setting and a planned project. After this, the communication must continue.

It can be tempting to design a single practicum experience and reuse it for every student. This, after all, can save the supervisor valuable time, and, truth be told, this strategy can work for many students. However, not all students want to have the same practicum experience or come to the practicum with the same level of skills or knowledge. It is important that the supervisor communicate clearly in the first meeting with the student what the site is looking for and then stick with the plan they make with the student. When this does not happen, students often feel dissatisfied with the experience. For example, Burkett found the ever-changing nature of his practicum and a recurrent lack of communication from his supervisor to be especially frustrating:

> There were some miscommunications between the university and the library about who could oversee a practicum. Our original point of contact, who put together the cataloging project, had taken a position with another library soon after I started, but that wasn't really much of a problem. The leader of practica [at the library] did not have a clear vision of my previous experience, so she wrongfully assumed that I had never worked in access services before and felt that it was important for me to get that experience. She had the unstated goal of letting me see all of the ways that librarians and libraries do not live up to their promise, which I found unnecessary and even a little insulting. (To be clear, when pressed, she did admit to that goal, but only when I pulled her aside to talk about what was not working in the practicum.)... Most of the tasks I performed with access services were only practicing activities I had done as regular work duties in other libraries, and because of the lack of good

> communication, it was highly unfocused—none of the clear goals and expectations that I had in the tech services department. It's not that they had expectations and weren't communicating them—they really had no idea what to do with me.... In the spirit of "making it up as we go along," at the later end of the practicum we cut hours from access services so I could work on more cataloging, which again created confusion based on mixed expectation.

Feeling that a supervisor is available, involved, and receptive allows students to build confidence in the workplace. Sujeit Llanes wrote that one of the biggest strengths in her practicum was that

> I had great guidance from my supervisors and support from everyone.... They were always very willing to [let] me shadow them and [be] part of meetings. They were very happy [to help] me gain as much experience and see as much of how the library works while I was there [as possible].

This feeling of connection with a supervisor is doubly important for those students completing practicums online. Hilton wrote that doing a virtual practicum was perfect for her schedule and allowed her to work somewhere she otherwise could not have. However, sometimes that distance left her "feeling somewhat isolated.… It would have been more difficult had the line of communication not been so open." Similarly, one survey respondent praised the availability of the supervisor for their online practicum, writing, "We had routine web meetings and consistent email correspondence."

A student's feeling that a supervisor was available was driven in large part by the supervisor. Two of the most important things supervisors can do to make students feel they are available are to schedule frequent check-ins and provide timely feedback. Hilton reported that she and her supervisor

> corresponded several times per week for the first few weeks to make sure I understood what was being asked of me. My supervisor was quick to respond, gave plenty of detail and examples, and worked well with me to determine the timeline of my assignments. She also gave timely and constructive feedback as I submitted assignments.

For many students, their practicum is their first job in a library or similar setting. They come to this job with at least a semester of MLIS courses under their belts, but they are well aware of the fact that they do not know everything. Checking in frequently acclimates them to the new environment, while regular,

timely, constructive feedback helps them stay on track, learn new skills, and build confidence.

Checking in frequently also allows the site and student to adjust to changes. For example, one survey respondent wrote,

> My supervisor asked in the beginning if I wanted to add goals, and I didn't have much to add, but when she asked again mid-practicum, I did. I think the midpoint checkup in the practicum is really very important and shouldn't be brushed over.

Frequent check-ins with students also encourage them to ask questions and ask for feedback when they need it. Nance put it well when she wrote:

> I felt empowered to ask questions and to ask for what I needed to achieve my goals. I tend to, perhaps unabashedly, ask quite a lot of questions when I am learning new things, and the team of people I was working with didn't deter any of them. A few times during the practicum, I felt that I could get off course if I didn't remind someone on my team or ask for confirmation of the short- and long-term plans and expectations. Everyone at my sites was receptive to my questions, and I think together my focus on my goals with their support and flexibility helped make the practicum experience a success.

Effective communication is one of the many soft skills that are generally easier to teach students in a practicum than in a classroom, especially in the increasing number of online classrooms. Teaching soft skills begins with the example of how the supervisor and other employees work with the student and continues as the student tries out those skills on their own. Sarah Fetzer wrote about the many specific skills she gained during her practicum, from creating webinars about research methods to working one-on-one with students, but she pointed out:

> The soft skills that I learned have proven to be far more important in my career. Working directly with students from a wide variety of skill levels provided an opportunity to practice tailoring my communication style for different needs.... The opportunity to work with many librarians in a fairly large community college grew my network of professional connections significantly.

As a result of this study and the changing needs of our students and site supervisors due to the COVID-19 pandemic, UNCG LIS has placed new emphasis on our communication with sites and students. We created two websites designed to communicate about field experiences with supervisors specifically (https://

sites.google.com/uncg.edu/lis-practicum/home) and with students preparing to take the capstone (https://sites.google.com/uncg.edu/lis-capstone/home). The practicum liaison has also stepped up efforts to recruit sites from a broad range of locations and disciplines (expanding beyond typical libraries, archives, and special collections) and to encourage flexible experiences that can be completed on-site, remotely, or both.

Respect

Feeling respected makes students feel more confident and empowered in their practicums. Showing respect for a student worker can begin with giving them "meaningful work to do" early in the experience.[13] One survey respondent suggested,

> Sites should have a very clear idea of what daily work will look like for students and be willing and expect to sacrifice some degree of productivity for the student's benefit. Some students in my cohort seemed to be working only for their placement's benefit, possibly without concrete goals or an ability to advocate for themselves.

Hosting a practicum student is a time-consuming endeavor, which can drain individuals and the library. One way to offset this challenge, while providing students with needed guidance, is to share responsibilities. Philip was especially pleased that her supervisor did just that, writing:

> My practicum supervisor created an inclusive environment at the library. I was able to observe and assist with all aspects of program development and delivery. The librarians took the time to explain their quartiles and programs of service and always included me in program delivery. This hands-on experience… gave me the confidence and the means to interview successfully.

Another way to marry respect for the student and time saving for the library is to allow the student some degree of autonomy. This is much easier later in the practicum but can be incorporated into the student's work early in the experience. For example, one survey respondent reported,

> My mentor did initial tutorials on various online systems, then had me assist her with the tasks associated with those systems. After I assisted her for a couple of weeks, she gave me my own tasks that I was to complete on my own. She had a good balance between instruction and allowing me to perform self-led tasks.

This terraced movement from more guidance to more autonomy over the course of the practicum provides students with an excellent balance that meets their changing needs. However, it is important to continue to provide guidance throughout the practicum. Chang cited the independence she enjoyed during her practicum as a positive and a negative, writing that "having a good bit of trust and autonomy from the library staff" helped her feel valuable, but also pointing out that "having no experience and no 'assigned' librarian to help me often led to me mentally questioning if what I was doing was right and of benefit to the library."

Another way to help students feel respected and empowered is to encourage them to think critically about their practicum and share those thoughts with others. This can take the form of meetings with the supervisor or other employees. It can also be more formal. One survey respondent wrote, "My supervisor had me do a mini presentation at the end [of the practicum]. It was to show all my coworkers what I had learned, but it really helped me show myself all that I had learned." This sort of self-reflection helps students as they zero in on the career they wish to pursue and keeps them excited about the field (not always easy at the end of two or more years of graduate study). It also helps them to see their strengths and weaknesses in a more objective light, often realizing that the uncomfortable moments during their practicum usually accompanied the moments of greatest learning. For example, Morgan Pruitt wrote that the practicum "helped me to figure out what I like to do best… [and] helped me to articulate some of my strengths and interests more effectively."

Best Practices

Several best practices can help sites work more effectively with practicum students. First, *setting goals* is essential for designing a meaningful experience. Goal setting should be a joint effort of the student and site supervisor but can be aided by a job description. Designing one or more meaningful, professional-level projects or tasks tailored specifically to the goals provides a tangible product that benefits the site and the student.

Clear communication helps students understand expectations and responsibilities. Scheduling regular check-ins can help keep the lines of communication open throughout the practicum. Further, providing timely, constructive feedback on student work facilitates the learning process. At the beginning of the practicum, many students need more guidance and oversight; however, as the practicum progresses, they can generally be given more autonomy. This balance between oversight and independence demonstrates a *respectful work environment* for students, making them feel valued and helping them gain confidence.

Field experience is a valuable part of LIS studies. While coursework can provide students with the theoretical backdrop necessary for a long, successful

career in this vibrant, ever-changing field, hands-on experience fills many gaps inherent in purely theoretical study. Making the field experience as meaningful as possible for students has benefits for not only the students, but also their practicum sites and supervisors, the universities at which they study, their future employers, and the library community as a whole. One survey respondent put it perfectly when they wrote, "Prioritizing practical experience really changed the way I saw myself as a professional, especially as someone coming from a non-library background. It helped me to build confidence in [a] way that my courses did not."

APPENDIX

Survey Questions

How did you find/arrange your practicum?

- ☐ Department practicum liaison
- ☐ Department list
- ☐ Listserv announcement
- ☐ Recommendation from faculty
- ☐ Recommendation from employer
- ☐ Own initiative
- ☐ Other _____

Was the practicum site prepared for you to work there?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Other _____

Was the practicum supervisor prepared for you to work at the site?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Other _____

Were you prepared for the work that you were expected to do?

- ☐ Definitely yes
- ☐ Probably yes
- ☐ Might or might not
- ☐ Probably not
- ☐ Definitely not

How did you set goals for the experience? Check all that apply

- ☐ The practicum was designed with particular goals that were advertised.
- ☐ The supervisor worked with me to set particular goals that were unique to me.
- ☐ I proposed my own goals.

Can you describe the balance between mentoring from the supervisor and their trust in you to do the work assigned?

What made your practicum a success?

What did not work?

Would you like to add anything else that would help supervisors and sites design better practicums?

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Voices from the Field

Learning Through Variety

Interning in Different Institutional Contexts

Teddy Stocking

I am grateful for my internships because I think they exposed me to the complexity and diversity within the academic library and provided a context for the things I learned in the classroom. I was able to learn at an LIS program at an R1 university, work in a special library, and participate in a practicum at a liberal arts college. Internships balanced my coursework with opportunities in circulation, technical services, and scholarly communications/digital initiatives. When applying and interviewing for professional positions, my internships created the framework for approaching job opportunities.

I gained tremendous perspective from UNC's School of Information and Library Science, specifically because of the opportunity to learn from highly accomplished academic librarians and professors. Most importantly, library school taught me how to anticipate patron needs in my actions, how individuals approach and process information, and how information literacy empowers patrons. However, I found a few gaps in my career preparation that could not be filled by my program. For example, I had only one course specifically on academic libraries and a single reference class. As I continued to work in special libraries and liberal arts contexts, I noticed some of the key topics we covered in class were not applicable or less relevant in the work environments I wanted to work in; similarly, an MLS curriculum prepares students for a host of careers, which sometimes makes learning objectives and conversations overly general. I think many students have similar experiences, especially considering half of MLS students study at R1 institutions.[1]

One large concern in academia and academic libraries is siloing. As a young student with relatively little work experience, my internships were my first opportunities to see how leaders create positive work environments and adapt to challenges faced within their institutions. In libraries, perceptions of status and titles often demarcate silos.[2] My internships were in different contexts: I worked in a vertical structure with tenured librarians, hourly staff, and student workers; a flat environment with a team of tenured librarians; and a team of full-time staff under a single librarian. In all cases, the departments succeeded in transcending the siloing that might exist in organizations. In my experience, the greatest places to learn as an intern are workplaces that are

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organizationally flat, practical, and well connected to their patrons. By interacting interdepartmentally, I discovered my interest in special librarianship, reinforced my desire to work with undergrads, and learned to stay away from cataloging (for the sake of our field). More important than these personal revelations were the nuances about organizational culture I learned by working in diverse working environments.

Milliken and Lam advocate facilitating employee voices as a means of achieving "organizational learning and adaptation,"[3] which Langley, Gray, and Vaughan also connect to meeting shared goals and cross-boundary needs.[4] I consider these claims a good dovetail with my discussions with library workers, who expressed the importance for leaders at academic institutions to resist getting swept into strategies that overemphasize reproducing prestige projects or initiatives. This style of decision-making can often lack an accurate assessment of an institution's capabilities or current strengths, and therefore, these projects can exist in a vacuum, which isolates staff members or teams. As an intern, I learned a culture of interdependence fosters respect in the workplace but also solves problems.

While my studies elevated the patron-centered approach to librarianship, my diverse work experience showed me the importance of inclusive practices toward library workers, specifically how a worker's status affects their approach to a library's mission. A sense of vocation often inspires library professionals, but achieving institutional goals requires far more than a strong sense of purpose. Poorly connected cultures lead to interdepartmental skepticism, as well as hostility toward leadership. These tensions can be deeply layered, such as tension between library faculty and teaching faculty, as well as library faculty and library staff. Being an intern gave me an opportunity to work between many of the silos that exist within library organizations. The most successful workplaces have cultures that foster interdepartmental cooperation, empower workers at every level, and motivate workers who understand their role within an organization. This is important in libraries, because departments may not directly collaborate, but they are interconnected in the systems they contribute to and rely on. For example, as an intern, many of my tasks were improved by cooperating with staff of other departments, and crossing those divides often met goals in each department. At Duke, this went so far as to train circulation student workers on a number of my job requirements, allowing me to fill in for an intern in technical services. I was not afraid that training students would replace my position. Teaching circulation workers how their workflow connected to other staff members enabled them to establish connections to those individuals. Similarly, when breakdowns occurred, we could communicate our needs to department heads. While transitioning to a new department can require adapting to a new environment, I already

worked on projects with every member of my new team. Leadership's tone for flexibility and mutual respect allowed staff and student workers to work interdependently. This approach also respects the real conditions of a library organization and affords workers at every level to contribute to project planning.

Overall, the opportunity to intern within a number of well-functioning libraries greatly improved my ability to understand how my passions translated to a career. It guided me to become a special librarian in an institution size I never imagined when I started my program. It also gave me a much greater appreciation for the contributions library staff and student workers make to the overall success of library services. It gave me a context to assess the opportunities before me upon graduation. Finally, it continues to encourage me to build a spirit of cooperation and respect the realities of my location and needs of my patrons.

Notes

1. Of the fifty-eight US programs mentioned in the ALA directory, thirty-three are at R1s. Based on ALA 2019 Trended Data, of 10901.48 FTE master's students, 5607.87 are at R1s. R1s are also well represented in rankings. Brady D. Lund, Ting Wang, and Danica E. White, "University Program Rankings in the United States: Failures in Assessing Important Factors for Library and Information Science Students," *Education for Information* 35, no. 4 (2019): 427, https://doi.org/10.3233/EFI-190248.
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Part III

Working with Graduate Students without an LIS Background:

Mutual Opportunities for Growth

Introduction

When your university is affiliated with a library school, there is an obvious source when looking to recruit individuals who are interested in the work of libraries. When there isn't a graduate program in library or information science, designing meaningful work experiences can be a challenge. The following part highlights institutions and individuals who speak to that challenge, framing the opportunity that lies within it.

The underlying tension in all three chapters is how to create a learning opportunity within the library for a graduate student studying and working in a different field, while also meeting critical needs of the library. Erin Rinto and Chelsea Heinbach at the University of Nevada, Las Vegas, write about one of those critical needs: giving early-career librarians the opportunity to develop supervisory experience without reclassifying their jobs (chapter 8). UNLV's Information Literacy Fellows Program, where the library employs graduate students from other disciplines based on proposals made by librarians, offers that experience to librarians while also giving graduate students a real-world context to apply their disciplinary knowledge. Fellows emerge from the program with teaching and other kinds of practical experience, and crucially, librarians are able to grow as managers.

These chapters show how a well-designed program centers the student but also enriches the library's position and offerings. North Carolina State University's Peer Scholars Program pays graduate students from other disciplines to come teach skills-based workshops in the library (chapter 9). The library develops a structure and guides the student through planning, implementation, and assessment, and ultimately these workshops allow the library to offer trainings that would otherwise exceed its capacity—a win-win situation, raising the visibility and connectedness of the library on campus. Louise L. Lowe's chapter (chapter 10) explains how the University of Arkansas at Little Rock, facing pressures from the 2008 financial crisis and preparations for accreditation, rethought how its library was integrated into the curriculum. She writes about cocurricular engagement as a strategy for relevance, and explains that employing graduate

students from other fields and giving them a voice in the library's plans and activities is one way of making sure that the library is aligned with the larger goals of the campus.

Look to these chapters and profiles if you're interested in how to leverage the connection your library has to a larger campus, how to translate library work into other disciplines, and how to meanwhile build opportunities for your own staff.

CHAPTER 8

Information Literacy Fellows at the University of Nevada, Las Vegas

Erin Rinto and Chelsea Heinbach

This chapter describes the conceptualization and managerial philosophy behind a graduate student fellowship at the University of Nevada, Las Vegas Libraries. Developed in order to provide both graduate students and academic librarians opportunities to collaboratively hone research and project management skills, the Information Literacy Fellows Program at UNLV has grown into an experiential learning opportunity that embraces graduate students as partners in research, teaching, and scholarship.

Background of the Program

The University of Nevada, Las Vegas (UNLV) Libraries supports a large urban, public MSI (Minority Serving Institution), HSI (Hispanic Serving Institution),

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and AANAPISI (Asian-American and Native-American, Pacific Islander Serving Institution) university in Las Vegas, Nevada, that recently earned Carnegie Foundation R1 ranking. According to data from fall 2019, the graduate student population at UNLV is around 4,300 students, with 62 percent seeking master's degrees. The largest percentage of graduate students are enrolled in the College of Education (33 percent), with significant portions also in the colleges of Urban Affairs (12 percent), Business (10 percent) and Liberal Arts (7 percent).[1] There is no graduate program in library and information sciences at UNLV.

Librarians at UNLV have long recognized that these graduate students are important contributors to the academy. Graduate students are not just future colleagues in teaching and research; they are *current* colleagues in teaching and research. A report from the American Association of University Professors (AAUP) found that "students at US colleges and universities are more likely to be taught by non-tenure track faculty members working in full- or part-time contingent positions than by tenure-stream faculty."[2] At many large research universities, graduate students fill these contingent teaching positions; this is also the case at UNLV, where many high-enrollment undergraduate courses are taught by graduate student instructors. However, that same AAUP report acknowledges that graduate student instructors often receive "little or no training for the teaching profession."[3] As a result, many informal partnerships and mentoring relationships have developed over the years as librarians work alongside these graduate student instructors to teach research and inquiry in undergraduate courses. In due course, it became clear to librarians that graduate students were eager for professional development opportunities, had a wealth of disciplinary knowledge, and, particularly for master's degree students, had difficulty securing funding, especially in the summer months when their academic departments had limited opportunities for teaching and research assistantships.

Alongside this growing awareness of the need to provide more professional development for graduate students on our campus was a period of expansion for our library, in terms of both new tenure-track librarian positions and new teaching and learning initiatives. The UNLV Libraries has long fostered a commitment to student success and lifelong learning, with particular attention to meeting the unique needs of our community through innovation and collaboration.[4] As any librarian engaged in liaison, teaching, and outreach work can attest, the day-to-day reality of supporting a robust commitment to student learning means that dedicating time during the fall and spring semesters to research and innovative projects can be very difficult. Many projects are set aside for the summer, when we have, in theory, more time to explore new avenues for creativity and scholarship. Even so, there is a limit on how much we can accomplish, and we don't always have the capacity or expertise to tackle these projects. In addition, many of the newly hired librarians at UNLV were eager to gain more experience as

project managers and supervisors. It can be difficult for librarians new to the profession to gain the managerial experience that is necessary to move on to positions as department heads and administrators. An important part of our own professional development was the opportunity to learn and grow in this capacity:

> To overcome the dearth of academic librarians with the needed training in management, the seeming inability of library school management courses to completely prepare librarians to take on actual management duties, and the increasing importance of management skills in the discipline of academic librarianship, many professionals and scholars have called for academic libraries themselves to participate more in encouraging and facilitating the preparation of academic librarians for management roles.[5]

In response to these interrelated issues, in 2014 the UNLV Libraries initiated a new program designed to further the teaching and learning mission of the library. Called the Information Literacy Fellows Program, this student fellowship was intended to meet two goals: to provide a supervisory experience for librarians interested in tackling substantive research or teaching-related projects, and to enable students to gain valuable experience while supported by funding. The program is open to students at the undergraduate and graduate levels, with supervisors selecting the candidate with the most relevant expertise; the majority of these fellowships have gone to graduate students. The IL Fellows Program is primarily intended to run over the summer, when librarians have more time to dedicate to project management and research endeavors, and when graduate students are less likely to have funding from their academic programs. To date, there have been eleven fellowships awarded to students from myriad academic disciplines.

Administration of the IL Fellows Program

The IL Fellows Program is housed in the UNLV Libraries Educational Initiatives department. The Head of Educational Initiatives has been instrumental in the development and longevity of the program, but as the program has grown, we, the authors, have assumed responsibilities for many facets of the program's administration. We have each served in the capacity of IL Fellows Program coordinator since its inception in 2014, Erin from 2014 to 2017, and Chelsea from 2017 to the present. There are many moving parts to the program, and the primary responsibilities for the program coordinator are to secure funding; maintain the program's timeline; coordinate the proposal, marketing, and hiring

processes; ensure appropriate onboarding of fellows; maintain and circulate a list of best practices for project supervisors; and develop and implement program assessment. In addition to serving as coordinators, we have also both served as the direct supervisors for several IL Fellow projects.

The IL Fellows Program is supported with funding from the UNLV Library Advisory Board. Every fall, the Head of the Educational Initiatives department presents a funding request to the advisory board, outlining the goals of the IL Fellows Program, sample projects that fellows and librarians might collaborate on and the impact of such projects on the library and campus, and details of the funding needed to competitively support a graduate student fellow over the summer. In the past, we have supported one to three fellows each summer (with occasional fellowships occurring during the regular academic semester).

Once funding is secured and we know how many fellowships we can offer, the IL Fellows Program coordinator works with the Head of Educational Initiatives to identify projects and supervisors for the upcoming summer. In some years, this entails soliciting project proposals from librarians, while in other years, projects are predetermined based on department goals and current needs. For example, the need to update library online learning tutorials might be flagged as a IL Fellow project, but personal research projects that benefit student learning initiatives are also considered. Some of the projects past IL Fellows have participated in include assessing student learning, preparing instructor support materials, creating online instruction materials, testing tutorial usability, conducting student surveys or focus groups, and completing data analysis. If more projects are proposed than can be supported, proposals are collaboratively vetted with a rubric and selected based on their capacity to enrich the student's education and skills as well as the potential impact on library services and student learning.

In mid-spring, the IL Fellows Program coordinator works with the project supervisors to advertise positions to potential graduate student fellows. Supervisors draft a description of their project and the desired experience and qualifications they seek in a fellow. We usually place a call for applicants through the Graduate College, weekly student email, student paper, and library website, and we encourage project supervisors to directly market to target academic departments or reach out to graduate students they know may meet their qualifications. The hiring process typically includes a review of CVs and cover letters, followed by in-person interviews. In our capacity as program coordinator, we leave the hiring decisions to individual project supervisors and department heads, but we do field general program inquiries and provide support in interview best practices and sample questions. When a hiring decision is made, we liaise with library human resources to finalize contracts and offer letters. Graduate students who are teaching over the summer need

permission from their academic department to take on additional work, so getting contracts together can be a lengthy process. In order to make sure there is no gap in funding, we need to make sure we stay in close contact with fellows and human resources during the hiring process.

Once fellows have been hired, the program coordinator works with supervisors to ensure a smooth onboarding process. We need to make sure fellows have a secure workspace, technology appropriate to their projects, and any other necessary supplies. We also meet with supervisors and discuss best practices for overseeing graduate student fellowships and reiterate the overall program goals. Once the project starts, we leave the weekly project management to the librarian supervisor. At the end of the summer, we oversee programmatic assessment via an IL Fellow exit survey and keep a log of IL Fellow project outcomes. We also ask supervisors to send us a write-up of their experience, including any feedback and tips we can include in our best practices document for future years.

Managerial Considerations/ Philosophy

The hallmark of our program is a true partnership between librarians and graduate students that honors the experiences and disciplinary knowledge graduate students bring to the table and treats graduate students as research partners, not research assistants. A crucial aspect of this fellowship is ensuring that students feel trusted and valued by the librarians they are working with to make formative decisions about the work and complete it in a timely manner. All parties should be collaboratively learning from and with one another during the process. In addition, the IL Fellows Program is a professional development opportunity—both for graduate students and for librarians. Fellows apply their disciplinary knowledge to an information literacy context, and in doing so they gain a deeper understanding of their own field as well as the teaching mission of an academic library. Fellows work with data, literature, and research methods in real-world settings outside of the classroom, which is a valuable experiential learning opportunity. But librarians also learn how to supervise, mentor, and manage projects in what we hope is ultimately a compassionate and empowering way. For us, the IL Fellows Program goes far beyond the tangible impact of the projects themselves, and as IL Fellow supervisors, we have both found working alongside graduate students to be enriching to our own practice.

When we look at our program holistically, a few crucial considerations enable us to reach these goals. These are shared ownership and credit of the final project, preservation of autonomy for graduate students and supervisors, and encouragement of creativity and shared expertise.

Credit/Ownership

Perhaps the most important aspect of our managerial philosophy and a foundation of our fellowship program is a strong commitment to shared ownership of our research projects and ensuring graduate students have a tangible takeaway from their time as IL Fellows. Librarian supervisors are expected to structure their projects so that graduate students can take shared credit for the work they produced during their fellowship. Sometimes this work continues beyond the fellowship period (such as in the case of published articles and conference presentations); in that case, while fellows are no longer paid for their work, they are invited to continue on as research partners. We have found our graduate students to be motivated, engaged, and eager to participate in research and professional development opportunities, and our exit surveys indicate that having shared ownership in their projects is one of the most important aspects of their fellowship.

As part of our programmatic assessment, we keep a log of all the final projects that our IL Fellows produced. Since 2014, our eleven IL Fellowships have resulted in five coauthored peer-reviewed publications (with at least one publication in progress), six conference presentations (most at the national level), several new or updated online video tutorials, and one report given to our university's Director of General Education. All of these projects have our IL Fellows listed as coauthors or copresenters, and fellows can include their work on their CVs and in their portfolios. Fellows have also presented their work locally, sharing their newfound expertise with others in their departments. For example, an IL Fellow working on a project related to information literacy skills in English Composition courses presented her findings to other English graduate students at their new student orientation workshop.

Autonomy

It is perhaps apparent from the description of how our program functions that the IL Fellows Program coordinator fills a role that is similar to that of information literacy instruction coordinators more generally—we are responsible for overseeing a process that involves librarians who are not our direct reports but who are responsible for the functioning of a successful fellowship program.[6] It is a delicate balance to ensure that best practices are followed and that graduate students have a meaningful experiential learning opportunity, and this is much more straightforward when we have been the direct supervisors of IL Fellows. But since the day-to-day management of the project falls to individual librarians who have varying levels of prior supervisory experience, we need to make sure we are facilitating a process that makes space for librarians and graduate students to productively work together while honoring individual work style preferences and goals.

To that end, many of our best practices center on respecting autonomy. We encourage project supervisors to intentionally consider how they expect graduate students to check in and complete their work. Supervisors should review the project's outcomes, timeline, and responsibilities so that fellows have a holistic view of the project they will be working on. It may be appropriate to provide fellows with literature and background information to review to help set the context for their own role in the project. Clear and fair expectations should be set for the work schedule, including how often check-ins will take place, and if off-site work is permitted. We believe that graduate students should be able to set their own work pace without a supervisor having to micromanage tasks. It has been helpful to use Google Sheets to log hours, set goals, and record what work was completed in a given week so that the supervisor can maintain the overall project timeline while still ensuring graduate students are able to budget their own time and make decisions about their work. In addition, we encourage our fellows to identify professional development opportunities and use their work time to engage with those tasks (e.g., participating in a webinar relevant to their professional development).

In addition, we ask that librarian supervisors consider the varying types of work tasks that need to be completed and let the IL fellow pick and choose what they will work on any given day. This allows the fellow to balance their work on the necessary but more mundane tasks and more creative aspects of the project. For example, an IL fellow project on information literacy assessment required that the fellow download and organize tutorial responses—a vital aspect of the project, but extremely tedious. We encouraged our graduate student to also research and draft a rubric to analyze those responses so that she was able to engage in more robust work and see how her data crunching fit into the broader goals of the project. She chose to divide her workdays between these two tasks to break up the tedious work and allow for more creativity.

Creativity and Shared Expertise

A foundational aspect of the IL Fellows Program is that graduate students have disciplinary knowledge and prior learning and experience that they can use to enhance our own information literacy work in the library. When proposing an IL fellow project, supervisors should consider gaps in their own expertise that can be enhanced and addressed by partnering with a graduate student. For example, we have hired graduate students from English Rhetoric and Composition to work on assessing the information literacy skills of first-year writing students, and students with graphic design and technology expertise to create and update library online tutorials. Our IL fellows have come from academic disciplines including education, health sciences, English, design, and information technology.

As graduate students continue to develop as researchers and teachers in higher education, we also see our IL fellowship laying the groundwork to their future collaborations with librarians. Our IL fellows have indicated that they were not truly aware of the full spectrum of work we engage in as librarians, and these partnerships have been vital to underscore the importance of information literacy initiatives at our library and on our campus. We encourage supervisors to look for opportunities for their fellows to collaborate with others in our department and in our library; we invite them to department meetings and library-wide events that may be of interest. We also want supervisors to be able to serve as mentors in the research and teaching process. Graduate students are often looking for professional development opportunities and ways to diversify their CVs. Seeing the myriad research that librarians are engaged in has been helpful for our graduate students as they envision future applications of their own work as it relates to student learning. This has also helped us to grow as advocates for our information literacy work as we learn how to translate more effectively our goals and efforts to our graduate student fellows and help them understand the impact of our efforts on the broader university community.

Takeaways

For those considering a program like ours, we would like to underscore that our graduate students do not come from LIS backgrounds—UNLV does not have a graduate LIS program. We hope that librarians at campuses that likewise do not have library science students can see the benefits of working with graduate students in other academic disciplines. At the outset of our program, there was some concern about whether graduate students would find it beneficial to work in a library setting; we have found that the chance to apply their disciplinary knowledge to a real-world problem has been enticing to graduate students from many different academic programs. Our fellows complete an exit survey at the conclusion of their project; feedback such as "I think many in my higher education program would appreciate the research and the unique way in which librarians work with students," "[the fellowship] allows you to incorporate your personal experience into research," and "the fellowship is a great way to provide students the chance to manage and develop a project that shows their strengths while also allowing them to develop new skills" demonstrates to us that our graduate students appreciated the opportunity to utilize their previous knowledge and skills.

We also would argue that while the opportunity to engage in meaningful work that has a tangible takeaway has been extremely motivating for our IL fellows, the stipend aspect of our fellowship is crucial. Graduate students are often underfunded and we should not expect them to engage in robust work without compensation. The opportunity to coauthor a publication or present at a conference are

exciting prospects, but do not negate the need to appropriately compensate graduate students for their time and expertise. There are many meaningful ways for libraries to engage in experiential learning, and a paid fellowship may not be the best fit depending on the circumstances at different libraries. However, if a library does have the means to employ graduate students as research partners, our fellowship model has been a great learning experience for all involved.

The practical results of our IL Fellows Program are certainly the publications, presentations, and public-facing online videos mentioned above. But more important are the intangible benefits produced by our partnerships with graduate students. Librarians have become more comfortable with supervising and managing projects—we have developed skills in communication, goal setting, troubleshooting, and flexibility. We have, more importantly, also learned how to be mentors who strive to practice empathy, lead by example, and listen and learn from one another. Working alongside our graduate fellows has allowed us to take a deeper dive into research projects and teaching initiatives we wouldn't be able to tackle otherwise; it has also resulted in more creative, exciting, and meaningful work that enriches our practice and benefits our broader information literacy goals.

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CHAPTER 9

The Peer Scholars Program

Leveraging Paid Peer Teaching at the Libraries

Alexa Carter, Shaun Bennett, Shelby Hallman, and Danica Lewis

Introduction

Instruction is a major component of both the academic library portfolio and the academic life of many graduate students and postdoctoral scholars. However, both groups face unique challenges: graduates and postdoctoral scholars may struggle to find appropriate teaching experiences, while libraries face the combined problem of needing to keep up with the latest tools and techniques paired with a rising demand for library workshops. In 2017, librarians at the North Carolina State University collaborated with campus partners from the Graduate School and the Postdoctoral Association to develop a program that would help address the problems above and benefit all parties involved. The Peer Scholars Program, a peer instruction program designed to feature the expertise

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of graduate students and postdoctoral scholars while building a hub for peer-to-peer scholarship on campus, was launched shortly thereafter.

The program provides graduate students and postdoctoral scholars with a low-stakes, yet professional, environment in which to gain valuable skills while rewarding them with both experience and a tangible monetary payment. Additionally, the Peer Scholars Program was designed to fit into the overall instructional program at the NC State University Libraries, filling an instructional niche while still helping graduate students and postdoctoral scholars gain meaningful teaching experience. This chapter discusses the literature around peer teaching in academia and library spaces and the creation and overview of the program and culminates with a discussion of the impact and benefits of such a program to both the peer instructors and the participants.

Peer Teaching in Academia and the Library

Peer-to-peer or near-peer teaching is quite common in academia, and the benefits of peer instruction have long been established. *Near-peer* is defined here as instructors teaching students who are one step removed academically: graduate students teaching undergraduates, postdoctoral scholars teaching PhD candidates, and so on. Studies have been conducted that approach peer teaching and learning from a variety of perspectives, including the efficacy for learners, the experience for the teachers, and the overall usefulness of the experience for everyone involved. A 1996 study by K. J. Topping noted the following benefits of peer teaching: "Just *preparing* to be a peer tutor has been proposed to enhance cognitive processing in the tutor—by increasing attention to and motivation for the task, and necessitating review of existing knowledge and skills."[1] More recently, a 2013 study from the University of Adelaide investigated the impact of a peer instruction program within the university's undergraduate medical degree program, finding that "tutors reported improving their own clinical skills, consolidating previous knowledge and developing their teaching skills. All demonstrated strong interest in pursuing a formal teaching role in the future and universally would recommend the rotation to their peers."[2]

Similarly, the benefits to students in peer instruction scenarios have been thoroughly researched. In 2007, researchers from the University Medical Center in Utrecht and the Uniformed Services University in Baltimore conducted a survey of both peer learners and peer teachers to better understand the effectiveness and dynamics of near-peer teaching. The results indicated that the experience was beneficial for both groups. Among those who responded, 100 percent of peer teachers from Utrecht agreed or strongly agreed with the statement "I learned a lot about the subject matter while teaching."[3] Likewise, 83.4 percent agreed or

strongly agreed with the statement "I learned a lot about techniques of teaching."[4] The researchers noted in their conclusion that

> the majority of near-peer teachers felt that they learned a lot about the subject matter they taught, they were comfortable in their role as teacher and they would do it again. Additionally, roughly 25% of near-peer learners from both sites identified a preference to receiving their teaching from near-peer teachers as opposed to faculty.[5]

A 2016 meta-analysis of peer-to-peer teaching studies further solidified the benefits of peer teaching for both instructors and students, concluding that "generic skill development and metacognitive training benefit from peer teaching."[6] Another meta-analysis done the same year pointed out that in a peer teaching situation, the learner and teacher have a greater degree of "cognitive congruence," defined by Rees and colleagues as "the similarity of tutor and student in intellect and thought-processing."[7] They argue that "this allows peer teachers to express often complex and intimidating topics in ways which learners are better able to understand."[8]

Furthermore, peer instruction in a library setting has been successfully implemented in the past. In 2001, librarians at the University of Florida were using peer teaching techniques to extend the reach of their library instruction. Through their program, undergraduate students were able to gain course credit for giving classroom instruction and private tutoring in "basic library resources" and skills, including identifying and evaluating appropriate academic sources in the library's catalog.[9] The article discussing this program noted that, similarly to the previously discussed sources, the participants reacted positively to the peer teachers and generally felt more comfortable being taught by a peer.[10] Additionally, the authors pointed out that the librarians themselves benefited from the program, as it allowed them to extend the range of their library instruction in ways that might have otherwise not been possible.

Program Creation and Overview

Keeping the potential benefits of peer teaching in various learning environments in mind, the libraries partnered with the Graduate School and Postdoctoral Association to create the Peer Scholars Program. This partnership has been an invaluable source of expertise and connections to graduates and postdoctoral scholars. The program recruits new peer instructors by sending out calls for participants through major groups on campus, including graduate student associations, class instruction, and even college-wide faculty meetings. Select individuals may also be contacted directly at the discretion of the Peer Scholars Team, a group of four librarians who manage the program. If an individual wants

to join Peer Scholars, they meet in person or online with the team to discuss their interest in facilitating a library workshop. Individuals can meet with the team at any time throughout a semester, though the workshops may be scheduled in a later semester. These potential instructors, known as Scholars in the program, are evaluated on their workshop topic and teaching plan. However, the evaluation is designed to be a friendly, low-pressure process, and Scholars are not expected to have extensive teaching experience when joining the program. Scholars can propose either a one-and-a-half-to-two-hour workshop with hands-on components or a one-hour research talk. They are paid a competitive honorarium of up to $300 for each workshop or talk they give, regardless of whether it is being taught virtually or in person.

Once a Scholar has officially joined the program, they work with librarians to determine the logistics for each workshop. Scholars are given agency to choose to hold the workshop in any classroom space in the libraries, including the high-tech spaces such as the Teaching and Visualization Lab or the Creativity Studio.[11] They also select the date and time of the workshop, within some limitations linked to the NC State academic calendar; no workshops are held during reading days, final exams, or semester break periods. Librarians offer guidance in terms of best practices for the time of day to hold workshops based on previous experience, but Scholars are encouraged to pick times they believe will work best for them and their peers. Once a date and time have been chosen, the Scholars work with librarians to create an outline of the proposed workshop and schedule at least one practice session before the workshop date. Practice sessions are designed to give the Scholar a chance to run through the flow of their instruction, work out any potential problems or snags that may have not been apparent during workshop development, and receive feedback from the librarians about the workshop.

Workshops are publicized through the libraries' public relations channels on campus, through word of mouth, and via advertisement on the libraries' website. Anyone in the NC State campus community can register for the workshops, including members of the public, and they are free to attend. The workshops feature core research and technical skills, techniques, and tools that are crucial to graduate student success and are highly attended by early career researchers on campus.[12] From July 2017 to January 2020, the majority of attendees have been graduate students (63 percent), though undergraduates (10 percent), staff (8 percent), and faculty (5 percent) also attended workshops. The remaining 14 percent of the attendees represent a mixture of postdoctoral scholars and members of the public. At least one member of the Peer Scholars Team is present at the workshops, primarily for room and tech support. The librarians typically do not interfere in the teaching of the workshop unless specifically requested to do so by the Scholar. Once the workshop has concluded, participants are asked

to fill out an online assessment, which asks questions about the usefulness of the topic and the teaching effectiveness of the Scholar.

After a workshop has been completed and the Peer Scholars Team has compiled the assessment materials, Scholars are invited to discuss the feedback from attendees. Based on the feedback, attendance, and general success of the workshop, Scholars may have the option to teach the workshop again. They can work with librarians to revise the workshop, incorporate the attendee feedback, and schedule a practice session if needed. Additionally, Scholars may be offered the opportunity to record their workshop using Mediasite video capture and streaming services. Select workshops have been recorded based on the workshop topic demand and emerging campus needs and made available online through the Peer Scholars site.[13]

Impact on the Graduate Student Experience

Soft Skills Development

The graduate students and postdoctoral scholars who participate as instructors in the Peer Scholars Program bring a multitude of hard skills and technical expertise to the program. Through the process of proposing and developing a workshop, they also have opportunities to practice and develop additional soft skills to round out their professional skill set. This begins with developing a project pitch for the workshop they are interested in delivering. Most Scholars contact the Peer Scholars Team through an online form, where they provide some basic information about themselves, the material they are interested in teaching, and what relevant experience they have with instruction on their subject matter. Similarly to writing a grant proposal, though at much lower stakes and with far fewer formal requirements, applicants must make a case for both the intellectual merit of the topic and their ability to carry out the workshop they propose. This experience with communicating a need or opportunity and their ability to meet it can be applied in many ways, including in future grant and fellowship proposals, research statements, or entrepreneurial undertakings.

Scholars have an additional opportunity to practice verbally communicating a project pitch, as well as to develop interview skills when meeting with members of the librarian team to discuss their proposal. This first meeting is intended to be low pressure and informal, and as much emphasis is given to explaining the processes and expectations of the program as to discussing the proposed workshop and the Scholar's experience. The interviews are usually small, involving the prospective Scholar and two team members, and brief, lasting between half an hour and an hour.

When a proposal is accepted, Scholars then develop the actual body of the workshop. They can request feedback or help from librarians, but the Scholar is solely responsible for project management, and most choose to work independently until the practice session where they get feedback and advice. They typically have a few smaller deadlines to meet for creating the workshop description and materials, but this is an opportunity for the Scholar to practice project and time management skills as they craft a workshop for their peers.

Building a Professional Portfolio

One of the most important aspects of the Peer Scholars Program for the graduate students and postdoctoral scholars who participate as instructors is that it provides a professional, paid experience. As a unique résumé or CV component, it carries more weight than other unpaid teaching experiences or internships. Scholars go through an interview process, lead and manage the development of their instructional materials, and deliver instruction to participants ranging from undergraduates to faculty and the public.

As part of the program, Scholars also have opportunities and support in developing professional materials that can later be used for job or grant applications, as well as for scholarly identity management. As part of listing and advertising the workshops, Scholars have the option to meet with the libraries' External Relations department to have professional headshots taken. Some Scholars already have a headshot that can be used for workshop advertising, but for many, the program provides an opportunity to obtain a free professional photo that can also be used for their scholarly profiles, portfolios, or personal websites. Another component of the workshop listing is a brief personal statement describing the Peer Scholar instructor's background and expertise in the topic. Developing a personal statement is another necessary component of job, grant, or internship applications, and the experience of writing a statement to a focused area of technical expertise provides Scholars with a starting point for future statements.

Maximizing Expertise through Instruction

At the core of the Peer Scholars Program is imparting instruction experience and communication skills to graduate students. During the program, the Scholars experience the complete process of planning and teaching a workshop or lecture, from developing their topic to managing the classroom. Along the way, librarians help mentor the Scholars through constructive feedback, advice, and practice sessions.

Starting from the initial interaction between an interested Scholar and the Peer Scholars Team, Scholars begin receiving mentorship and learn about crafting instruction sessions. Scholars brainstorm potential topics based on their expertise

and interests. The Peer Scholars Team helps the Scholar select and scope their topic to encourage a session that is multidisciplinary and useful to attendees. Following topic selection, the Scholar progresses through the various stages of lesson planning by developing their own learning objectives and outcomes, along with teaching materials and activities. The expectation for teaching materials is that key items, such as presentation slides, will be shared with attendees during or after the session. Leading up to the session, Scholars hone their skills through lesson plan and material iterations and revisions, based on practice sessions and review by librarians. Following the workshop, Scholars receive attendee feedback they can use to continue to improve for future instruction scenarios.

In addition to learning how to develop content, Scholars also gain experience with classroom technology and management. As part of the program, Scholars select which library teaching space to use based on their workshop content and preferred layout. The available teaching spaces range from high-tech, such as our 270 degree projection Teaching and Visualization Lab, to more traditional lecture spaces, such as our single-projector library teaching labs. Regardless of the technology level of the classroom, Scholars are expected to lead the session themselves, requiring practice and orientation to the technology prior to their session. The experience with classroom technology is not limited to in-person classrooms but also includes online teaching technology, such as Zoom. Given the necessary restrictions during the COVID-19 pandemic, several Scholars successfully transitioned to virtual instruction sessions and adopted online teaching tools. Multiple Scholars welcomed the opportunity to explore virtual workshop engagement, which led to lesson plan and material revision, redesigned active learning activities for an online environment, and increased experience using new platforms.

Whether the instruction is in person or online, the Scholars gain experience managing a classroom and have standby support from a member of the Peer Scholars Team in each workshop. During in-person sessions, the Scholars lead attendees through lectures, direct individual and group activities, and handle questions. For online sessions, Scholars also incorporate additional classroom management techniques, such as using chat features and breakout rooms. For some Scholars, their workshop is the first experience they have had with managing attendees while teaching and troubleshooting any unexpected scenarios. Regardless of the instruction setting, the Scholars learn to employ patience, time management, and multitasking to maximize the instruction experience.

Skill Development for Workshop Participants

While Scholars have developed instruction and communication skills through the Peer Scholars Program, workshop participants have also benefited from

the skills and expertise shared by Scholars during workshops. Attendees have engaged with a wide range of workshop topics focused on introductory-, intermediate-, and advanced-level research skills. From hard or technical skills such as a programming language, to soft skills such as time management techniques, participants are encouraged to explore a variety of skill sets through Peer Scholars workshops, as shown in table 9.1.

Table 9.1
Skills and tools featured in Peer Scholars workshops

	Research & Technical Skills	Soft Skills	Tools/Languages
Topic	• Agent-based modeling • Building your own PC • Data analysis • Data management planning • Data mining • Data visualization • Digital game design • Literature reviews and search strategy • Qualitative research methods • Social network analysis • Virtual and augmented reality development	• Managing the writing process • Navigating graduate research fellowships, scholarships, and Fulbright applications • Overcoming imposter syndrome • Pitching research • Presentation skills • Public speaking • Scholarly branding development • Scientific communication • Stress management • Time management	• GitHub • Google Analytics • ImageJ • JMP Pro • LaTeX • MATLAB • Mendeley • Microsoft PowerPoint • NVivo • Overleaf • R & R Studio • RefWorks • Twitter • Unity • Wix

Certain topics utilize multiple sessions to build skill sets, such as with computer programming languages like MATLAB and R, while other topics have been covered in a single session. After attending workshops, participants are also encouraged to connect with Scholars and librarians as they delve further into the workshop topics or need additional research or technical support.

Conclusion and Next Steps

Within just a few years, the Peer Scholars Program has enhanced the North Carolina State University Libraries' role in graduate student success by serving as a hub for graduate and peer-to-peer scholarship in the campus community. The program offers scholars an interdisciplinary platform through the libraries to share their expertise while also providing them with unique opportunities to

develop skill sets that they can add to their professional repertoire. Throughout the program, Scholars work with librarians to strengthen professional workplace skills that are imperative to the teaching experience. These core skills can be carried into future professional roles and supplement their résumés or CVs. In addition to providing graduate students and postdoctoral scholars with an innovative experiential learning opportunity, the program has continued to expand the range of workshop offerings available to all library patrons, allowing the libraries to offer and support advanced and specialized topics that otherwise may not have been possible. As of spring 2020, the program has partnered with thirty-five graduate students and postdoctoral scholars to deliver over ninety workshops on emerging research skills and topics identified within the graduate research community.

As the Peer Scholars Program continues to grow, so do the opportunities for enhancing the graduate student experience with peer teaching and learning offerings. The Peer Scholars Team remains committed to enriching graduate student education on campus and seeks to increase the impact of the program by recruiting even more Scholars in the future. With more peer instructors participating in the program, the team of librarians aims to conduct a more in-depth program evaluation to collect feedback from the graduate students and postdoctoral researchers who have collaborated with the libraries to lead workshops. This assessment will be used to better understand the impact of this peer teaching experience on the scholars and improve campus outreach. The Peer Scholars Team also seeks to explore digital badging and certification as another method for graduate students to gain credentials and highlight the skills they build through the program. As the program expands, the Peer Scholars Team will continue to identify and develop opportunities to enhance the graduate student experience, further prepare students for professional roles, and promote peer teaching as an essential asset to the academic library learning environment.

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VOICES FROM THE FIELD

A Practicum Experience at the San Antonio College Library

Beatrice Canales

As a Texas Woman's University (TWU) School of Library and Information Science (SLIS) graduate student, my final chapter before graduation was a practicum site assignment at an academic library. I chose to do my practicum at the academic library at San Antonio College (SAC) because I currently worked at the college but not at its library and I wanted to experience working for the academic library. The TWU-SAC practicum program included the development of personal internship goals, assignments, and a reflective essay.

San Antonio College, a Hispanic-serving institution (HSP), is one of five community colleges in the Alamo Colleges system located in San Antonio, Texas. As an institution, SAC has served the San Antonio area for nearly a hundred years. Since SAC is a community college, the library serves a diverse group of community stakeholders, from first time in college (FTIC) to post-traditional students. The SAC Library is situated near the middle of campus in the same building with other campus departments.

My summer practicum experience in the SAC Library became more than a semester of field-of-study-related work experience at an academic library because what I learned and experienced was worlds different from my public library experience. I collaborated with TWU's practicum coordinator and SAC's library director, Lee LeBlanc, to design a twofold practicum assignment. The first part entailed training on the CONTENTdm platform. Then I applied my knowledge by updating the query language for the SAC Library's Digital Archives Collection project—https://texashistory.unt.edu/explore/collections/RANGR/?—with approximately eighty-six years' worth of newspaper editions. The goal of this project was to increase the equity and inclusivity in the accuracy of searching for articles within the community college library's discovery search engine. This first assignment aligned with one of my practicum goals: to learn to edit search terms using new technologies in archival work. At the end of my practicum assignment, I felt that I made a difference to the SAC community because of my assistance in improving the effectiveness of natural language and controlled vocabulary for searching. For my second assignment, my supervisor suggested I create a meaningful independent project. I chose to do a feasibility study to explore enhancing the SAC Library children's book collection and early literacy program. As part of the project, I suggested that

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the college library conduct a local survey and feature outreach events to determine the effectiveness of an updated and enhanced collection and program at a community college library.

The study included interviewing stakeholders at nearby elementary schools and conducting a literature review to learn how a community college can budget for and develop a more diverse and inclusive children's book collection. The support that I received from the SAC Library director, librarians, and staff was a meaningful aspect of collaboration for me. That support encouraged my approach to emergent literacy featuring more authentic people of color characters. In this study I suggested best practices and envisioned a community college library with a larger space for early childhood materials and an increase in funding for more diverse children's books.

I believe the best experiences in a career can began with a successful practicum. In my practicum experience at San Antonio College, I was able to learn from the Association for Colleges and Research Libraries' guideline for "Characteristics of Programs of Information Literacy That Illustrate Best Practices."[1] Originally, I choose the SAC Library as my practicum site because of my current work experience at the college, but through my time as an intern I learned why LIS schools like TWU include a practicum requirement. I did not expect, but I hoped, that my internship would be memorable. A community college library afforded me the opportunity to learn how to edit archival research and to conduct a feasibility study that was significant for the library's needs and for my exploration of academic librarianship.

Note

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CHAPTER 10

Cocreated Cocurricular Graduate Learning Experiences

Louise L. Lowe

Just as we try to adapt to these new realities, the value of higher education itself has been called into question by legislators, consumers, and even some scholars within the academy. We can no longer take for granted a public trust in the inherent value of education. We have to find ways to demonstrate that value in directly observable experiences and outcomes. As the cost of education becomes more daunting for individuals, that task will become ever more important and challenging. So now the million-dollar question: How should we prepare for this time of transition?

—Dr. Christina Drale, Chancellor,
University of Arkansas Little Rock, Fall 2018

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Cocurricular experiences, or planned activities and internships that are adjacent to academic work but not graded, provide opportunities for students to apply classroom knowledge in a real-world yet well-structured environment. Cocurricular involvement is an important part of student learning experiences, complementing classroom experiences and contributing to student learning and development outcomes.[1] The discussions about cocurricular learning experiences center around George Kuh's research and have been well documented for over a decade: these experiences positively impact academic success and student persistence to graduation, and they contribute to an increased sense of belonging, capacity for humanitarianism, and interpersonal and intrapersonal competence.[2] In this chapter, we discuss how the library at the University of Arkansas at Little Rock, a metropolitan university located in central Arkansas, developed meaningful cocurricular graduate assistant experiences. In 2018, the library recruited graduate assistants to support collaborative learning services and spaces in the library. Over time, the library graduate assistantship learning program has evolved to provide rich learning opportunities for graduate assistants, allowing the library to expand its contribution to cocurricular student learning.

The cocurricular learning happens on two levels: first, the learning opportunities that our graduate students provide their peers and undergraduate students through the library, and second, the cocurricular learning the library provides the graduate student assistants themselves. In this chapter we are focusing on the second. Over two years, graduate assistants in the library have provided point-of-need peer writing, research, and speech support; designed and delivered information literacy instruction; led focus groups; participated in ethnographic research; and conducted data analysis. Through these experiences, graduate assistants gained valuable research, communication, leadership, and critical-thinking skills. Additionally, the library provides cocreation opportunities for graduate assistants to serve as key contributors in the decision-making and lesson planning process, leading to an increased sense of ownership in their own and others' educational experiences.

To provide background and context about this initiative: the University of Arkansas at Little Rock was a university in financial crisis heading into its accreditation site visit and undertaking a comprehensive institutional effectiveness review. Facing financial challenges from years of enrollment decline, the university formed the Institutional Effectiveness Committee (IEC) to establish a baseline for developing a culture of integrated planning through a Strategic Resource Allocation study (SRA). The SRA required all university programs and departments to submit reports to be evaluated and ranked based on value, vision, efficiency, and cost. Cocurricular areas would report evidence on how well they align and support the institution's mission, how well they demonstrate

operational effectiveness, efficiency, and their overall contributions to student learning and success. The university would factor annual budget allocations based on the alignment of the cocurricular area with the university's strategic priorities.

Paradigm Shift

> *Standards and SLOs would not only establish expectations of excellence in every unit, but would also promote accountability and a shared commitment to student learning. If a unit cannot ultimately connect its value to student learning, it does not belong on a university campus.*
>
> *—University of Arkansas at Little Rock Institutional Effectiveness Committee, Strategic Resources Allocation Study, Fall 2019*

At the University of Arkansas, the library's initial version of the assistantship focused on strengthening the university academic support structure by employing graduate students to provide peer-to-peer support since many students require remediation and depend on cocurricular services to become college-ready. The library collaborated with the campus writing and speech communication centers to provide peer writing and speech communication support in the library. These partnerships allowed centrally located services with extended hours. Graduate assistants offered point-of-need support, maintained weekly journals, and conducted student satisfaction surveys. Weekly journals provided some measures for student learning but lacked structure for measuring learning outcomes. Other than general work expectations, we did not create formal learning outcomes. With an increased university focus on cocurricular student learning outcomes, we needed to shift our perceptions toward graduate student learning. The library's task and challenge: (1) How do we demonstrate our contributions to student learning and success? (2) What evidence could we provide to demonstrate operational claims and overall value?

Focus on the Learner and Learning

Outcome-based Student Learning

A group of cocurricular programs, including the library, participated in a pilot to establish a standard process for measuring and reporting cocurricular student learning. To ensure success, we needed the process to be sustainable, practical, and meaningfully mapped to university-level core student learning outcomes

(CORE). The Council of Assessment Standards for Higher Education (CAS) framework mapped to CORE and offered a vetted structure designed and written for student support services. The CAS learning outcomes model is structured around six categories called domains: knowledge acquisition, construction, integration, and application; cognitive complexity; intrapersonal development; interpersonal competence; humanitarianism and civic engagement; and practical competence.[3] Each domain is broken down into detailed learning dimensions. The dimensions of learning allow for a focused assessment approach and opportunities for alignment with priorities and initiatives. CAS provides examples of student learning outcomes and self-assessment tools for program reviews. Additionally, CAS provides alignment maps to other frameworks (LEAP [AAC&U 2007], Learning Reconsidered [NASPA 2004], Degree Qualifications Profile [DQP 2011], Disciplines [2011]), which provided additional appeal. For all these reasons, CAS became an obvious choice for a cocurricular student learning framework.

Establishing an outcome-based student learning assessment process offers cocurricular areas the ability to measure student learning and gather meaningful feedback. The results of these assessments can improve learning experiences that would help cocurricular areas make informed decisions and prioritize allocation of limited resources. Using similar forms and procedures already in place for curricular programs would mean an increased opportunity for university-wide competencies mapping. The student learning assessment process template includes six major elements:

- program purpose/mission
- student learning outcomes mapped to CAS
- learning interaction/engagement
- assessment tools (artifacts)
- summary of results
- improvement areas

The pilot provided an opportunity to shift focus from reporting operational outcomes to a greater focus on student learning outcomes for our graduate assistants. Shifting to student learning outcomes can be challenging with little to no experience creating learning outcomes with properly aligned assessment measures. Therefore, the library created a simple, practical inquiry-based approach for developing program and student learning outcomes for our program that put graduate student cocurricular learning first.

Some of the questions we asked ourselves in order to develop program outcomes: What do we want to do? Why is this important? Is something similar already being done? Who will be involved? Who are the stakeholders? Are there any challenges to be considered? How will we address these? What can we do with the limited resources, within our scope? Does it map with existing internal

or external learning frames? Does it align with institutional and library mission and values? What would it look like in action?

Some of the questions we asked ourselves in order to develop student learning outcomes for our graduate program: What is the student learning experience? What is the desired outcome? Why is this experience important to the library? To the student? How will we get the student there? Where are the why, what, and how of learning? What would it look like in action?

Participating in the pilot and using the inquiry-based approach helped the library redefine our graduate assistantship purpose and shift to learning-centered priorities. Defining a purpose that aligns with the university's and library's initiatives is the first and most critical step to building well-structured learning programs. Proper alignment creates the opportunity to map graduate assistant experiences to curricular and other cocurricular program outcomes. Furthermore, alignment is a path to gathering meaningful assessment evidence and demonstrating library impact on campus learning initiatives. It informs the why, what, and how in learning for more meaningful graduate assistant experiences.

Defining Expectations for the Library and Graduate Assistants

Defining expectations is another step that should be completed early on to make sure there is a mutual understanding between the library and graduate assistants. If possible, expectations should be part of the recruitment phase by outlining the library's expectations through a well-written job description and announcement so graduate assistants have some sense of what the experience would look like. The application process should include screening questions to filter students' motivations, expectations, skills, and knowledge. Once students are hired, a written agreement should be established between the cocurricular area and students, outlining what both parties expect from the student learning experience. Furthermore, involving students in deciding their path and cocreating meaningful outcomes increases motivation and engagement. Successful assistantships require active participation from graduate assistants and project mentors.

Welcome and Onboarding

Once hired, all graduate assistants participate in onboarding activities: orientation, peer support training, and basic communication skills training. The library orientation includes basic information about the library, campus partners, and graduate assistantships writ large. The peer support training focuses on providing quality feedback and how and when to refer questions. Communication skills training includes active listening and establishing boundaries. Graduate

assistants define their career goals, skills, strengths, and weaknesses through team-building exercises. Understanding each other's strengths and weaknesses allows for more successful collaborations. This assistantship onboarding encourages the students to seek feedback from each other and make collaborative decisions that play to each other's strengths. Teamwork and collaboration are important skills graduate assistants need to learn whether they are currently in the workforce or will be entering the workforce soon. This is also an opportunity to gather baseline information for summative assessment.

Learning Goals and Plans

After onboarding, the graduate assistants cocreate goals and learning plans. A graduate assistant has no more than three goals each semester, The number of goals depends on project complexity. Learning plans outline the purpose, expectations, and deliverables of the project. The learning plans also include student learning outcomes, which are mapped to Council for the Advancement of Standards in Higher Education (CAS) self-development, communication and technology skills, and professional competencies domains. Assessment measures or deliverables are decided from the beginning, so students have a clear target throughout their employment. The learning plan integrates opportunities for ongoing communication between the graduate assistant and project mentor to manage expectations, provide feedback, ensure accountability, and celebrate successes. Like typical millennial and generation Z students, our graduate assistants require a clear path with meaningful and ongoing interaction with the project mentor.[4]

Measuring Student Learning

Learning outcomes are typically measured using cocreated rubrics, experience reflections, or observations. Each learning outcome has some type of assessment. The type of assessment depends on the learning outcomes. Student reflections are a common assessment tool and designed to include how graduate assistants felt during the experience, what they learned through the experience, why the experience was important, and how they may apply what they learned in the future. A typical learning plan includes the following sections:

- project title
- semester
- purpose (why)
- library goal
- learning outcomes
- library responsibilities
- graduate assistant responsibilities

- weekly or monthly reports/meetings
    - highlights/accomplishments
    - challenges/problems
    - solutions/adjustments
- deliverables
    - reports
    - presentations
    - reflections
    - digital objects

Learning in Action

The current library graduate assistant learning program scope is cocreating exceptional learning services and spaces for students by students. With this purpose in mind, we seek students who have the aptitude and desire to cocreate learning experiences and library stories using data-driven evidence. We currently recruit graduate assistants enrolled in speech communication, professional and technical writing, organizational communication, learning technology, and information quality programs.

Collaborative Learning, Student-Centered Learning Spaces

In 2019, the library began a space study to maximize the use of learning spaces and gather student perception of library spaces. Graduate assistants' involvement in the space study included designing data collection tools for surveys, focus groups, and observations; conducting data collection and analysis; and reporting findings to stakeholders. Communication graduate assistants conducted observations and led focus groups, while information quality graduate assistants cleaned, normalized, and analyzed observation and focus group data. Additionally, information quality graduate assistants developed data structures and documented processes that continue to serve the library.

Throughout the process, all graduate assistants remained active decision-making partners. Because graduate assistants were cocreators and coinvestigators, their involvement afforded the library dual outcomes: the library gathered evidence supporting operational assessment related to library learning spaces, and the library could point to how students were actively involved in experiential learning. Students gained crucial skills such as project management, question development, interviewing, collaboration, data analysis, and argument development.

Collaborative Learning, Student-Centered Services

Most communication graduate assistants focus on peer learning. Daily activities typically include providing one-on-one consultations, writing scripts for instruction videos, or preparing for orientations and workshops. Graduate assistants who provide writing and speech support must meet the same qualifications required of graduate assistants at the campus writing and speech communication centers. Additionally, the graduate assistants are required to attend weekly meetings held by the campus writing and speech communication centers to ensure effective communication and consistent services. During the initial phases of working with graduate assistants, I focused on the service element and did not fully realize the potential of the applied learning experience, including program or student learning outcomes. I was concerned with quality support services and successfully integrating peer learning support with existing library service points. Although we documented successful client interactions and graduate assistants' experiences through journal reflections, we were unable to retain graduate assistants across both centers and the library. Misalignment between the library's and graduate assistants' expectations and the inability to fully integrate peer learning services with existing library service points led to a lack of student engagement. We reassigned remaining graduate assistants to other projects while we developed and proposed a more sustainable program, fully integrated with other library service points.

A second service graduate assistants revamped in this process was designing information literacy and welcome activities for first-year experience (FYE) seminars. First-year seminars are high-impact practices that promote deep learning as measured by the National Survey on Student Engagement (NSSE).[5] One graduate assistant, who recently completed a communication pedagogy practicum, wanted experience designing and delivering workshops. The workshop incorporated Kolb's experiential learning theory (ELT), which suggests "knowledge is created through the transformation of experience. Knowledge is the result of the combination of grasping and transforming."[6] The graduate student facilitated sixteen workshops that included personal stories about college life, a demonstration, highlights on popular resources, brainstorming, a social media group activity, and assessment through facilitated discussion and reflection.

While the experience provided a student learning service, the example demonstrates successful outcomes possibilities when both the library and student expectations align to create a magical moment. The library assessed evidence from two student learning experiences, including FYE workshops and applied learning through a graduate assistantship. Through journal reflection, the graduate assistant acknowledged the experience improved self-confidence and provided a sense of pride when FYE students were observed using library

resources. The knowledge the graduate assistant shared with the library also created a lightbulb moment that triggered instruction librarians to recognize the value of frameworks and educational theory foundations to improve teaching and learning. They helped our graduate assistants think critically about information, ensuring students master and transfer skills beyond assignments or immediate tasks, leading to lifelong learning and socially responsible and informed citizens.[7]

Lessons Learned

While the examples illustrate the value of graduate assistants' learning experience in libraries, the past two years allowed us to create a baseline for future success and performance for our assistantship. In my experiences, libraries have thought of graduate assistantships or other applied student experiences in one of two ways: (1) extra laborers who are ready to work and produce quality work associated with their program of study, or (2) extra laborers who are ready to work and fill staffing gaps or lower-level tasks that may or may not be associated with their program of study. Moving forward, we "must support assistants in making meaning of their experiences and guide them in connecting this meaning to future endeavors."[8] Additionally, we must provide "scaffolding, structure, and environment to facilitate and shape such learning… we should not assume students will gain powerful outcomes simply by engaging with the college environment."[9]

Continuous Improvement

The rewards of working with graduate assistants have exceeded the library's expectations. We embraced both unexpected challenges and opportunities. We are noting the lessons learned to ensure continuous improvement. The library will formalize ongoing mentor feedback, self-reflection, and self-evaluation to measure individual growth and development. We will study and apply theoretical frameworks to improve learning, motivation, and engagement. For example, CAS will be applied to additional library programs for more structured experiences and meaningful outcomes. Additionally, the Universal Design for Learning (UDL) framework will provide various pathways to meaningful and inclusive student learning regardless of students' prior experiences, knowledge, and expectations.[10] Furthermore, graduate assistants and library mentors will cocreate achievable learning experiences that align with library goals and their professional expectations.

The roles of libraries must evolve with purpose and intent while remaining open to and embracing new opportunities. Each encounter with a student is a potential opportunity for a student learning experience and an opportunity for

the library to measure student learning, including, and especially, closest encounters—our assistantships. After decades of dwindling budgets, libraries will need to evolve and embrace learner-centered programs and practices, demonstrating library value and impact on student learning. To meet new demands and expectations, libraries must embrace all types of student learning experiences and continue to champion informed citizenship and lifelong learning within our own ranks.

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VOICES FROM THE FIELD

Weeding "Wright"

Engaging Graduate Students in a Meaningful Collection Management Process

Maggie Portis, Manuela Aronofsky, and
Ella Milliken Detro

Assigning graduate assistants (GAs) collections management tasks, such as weeding, may seem unrealistic: GAs are temporary workers who may lack institutional knowledge and professional experience required to independently complete projects. Designing and supervising unique GA projects may be tricky for overscheduled academic librarians already stretched thin. However, it is crucial that LIS students gain practical experience while completing their degree. This case study, highlighting our experience, explores an innovative win-win solution for GAs and librarians:1 a meaningful project for GAs that tackled collections management with a realistic time commitment from the supervising librarian.

A desperate need for weeding was the catalyst for redefining the scope of GA work and reexamining the necessity of subject expertise at Pratt Institute Libraries (Brooklyn, NY). An assessment of the collection revealed that weeding was urgently needed: the library was running out of space while out-of-scope, outdated, and poorly circulating materials filled the stacks. Pratt's librarians designed a simple deduping project intended to quickly increase space. But the architecture librarian (Maggie) determined that a more thorough project was necessary, and, in collaboration with Manuela and Ella while they were LIS graduate students, designed a two-year weeding project targeting the entire architecture collection.

We identified three aspects of the project that contributed to its success:

1. *Subject knowledge.* Subject expertise is a basic qualification for subject librarians, and every discipline's collection has a similar structure: important publishers, core texts, and so on. The librarian Maggie posited that Manuela and Ella could use their core librarian skills along with a cheat sheet of important architecture-specific information as an entry point to the field. As the GAs spent time in the stacks and assessed individual titles, their subject knowledge grew as they noticed common authors, themes, and publishers.

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2. *Collaboration.* In addition to our collaboration, Manuela and Ella also collaborated across departments. The GAs worked with Special Collections to increase access, adding to the number of circulating items and moving a few treasures discovered in the stacks into Special Collections. Originally the project included a Technical Services GA who was solely responsible for physically processing discarded items, but this role was eventually expanded to include both Technical Services and Collection Management responsibilities. Encouraging GAs to work within multiple departments on a focused project created an experience that mimicked real library jobs. This helped the GAs develop understanding of the field at large by allowing them to explore the multiple roles librarians and professional staff fill at an academic library.

3. *Ownership.* After completing this weeding project, both GAs reported that the tasks involved were meaningful, satisfying, and (believe it or not) fun! Exploring a new subject (both GAs had little to no academic background in architecture) and having the opportunity to design a unique project was exciting. Crafting an efficient workflow coupled with realistic goals created a sense of urgency and ownership without adding unnecessary stress. As-needed support from the supervising librarian enabled academic and professional growth while avoiding micromanagement or an onerous time commitment.

The project's complexity lengthened its duration and was of some concern to library management. However, our holistic approach to the architecture section ensured that the project was completed in a single pass, and libraries must provide meaningful work experience for the GAs. Systematizing this successful project's approach has created a framework for future GA projects.

We end this case study with tips for implementing a successful GA-led weeding project in any library.

- *Create a clearly defined, yet adaptable project scope and workflow.* Define the scope of the weeding project to give it a clear structure. For example, we weeded within a specific call number range (720s in Dewey decimal) and assessed only titles with three or more copies. Well-defined goals give GAs confidence to alter the workflow as needed and grant a sense of accomplishment when the project ends.
- *Develop an efficient communication strategy between graduate assistants, the project supervisor, and other project stakeholders.* After establishing project intention, documentation strategy, and training on workflow and subject knowledge, a hands-off supervisory approach can be taken. Initially scheduling regular, brief meetings provides structure and support for GAs. As the GAs settle in to the project, they can check in

virtually or in person as needed. This project structure is not onerous for busy librarians. On average our project required an hour per week of the supervisory librarian's time. A shared virtual workspace (spreadsheet) allows for fluid collaboration across departments and easy access to information.

- *Design your project with an understanding of the unique nature of graduate assistant work.* GAs work while juggling academic classwork and secondary professional responsibilities. Because a clear project scope had been defined, regular communication among project participants established, and responsibilities limited to one project, GAs are able to develop a sense of expertise. This also allows the library to implement flexible hours and scheduling—a relief for busy graduate students with inconsistent schedules.

Note

1. Qi (Kerry) Wu, "Win-Win Strategy for the Employment of Reference Graduate Assistants in Academic Libraries," *Reference Services Review* 31, no. 2 (2003): 141–53, https://doi.org/10.1108/00907320310476611.

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Part IV

Centering the Person

Introduction

While the previous parts focused on systematic ways to design, build, and assess graduate student practicums and internships, this part widens its lens. We titled this part "Centering the Person" because the authors in this part are deeply interested in *how* managers might approach the students they work with—engaging with principles of empathy and advocacy, recognizing the forces of identity, and implementing shared goal setting.

These chapters ask big-minded questions such as, What are the larger forces at play in libraries? This book is being written in the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic, and the chapters from Kerbavaz and Dierking (chapter 12) as well as Hathcock and Wang (chapter 13) reflect on how that global pressure changes the nature of work, supervision of that work, and the opportunities after practicums end. Complementing those considerations is Hartsell-Gundy's manager profile detailing measures she took to keep her graduate students engaged and supported when their library closed on-site operations.

It shouldn't take a pandemic to remind us that libraries are not freestanding units but exist in a much larger landscape. These chapters probe the ideals and mythologies libraries have internalized and proffer their students, arguing that some of them are problematic. Dierking and Kerbavaz take issue with the frequent recommendation that students be self-advocates in their careers, arguing that this principle removes the onus from libraries and supervisors to investigate the ways that they make good work unattainable. Hathcock and Wang, in a deep conversation that touches on identity and hegemonic spaces, model how acknowledging and engaging with power dynamics within supervisory relationships can help those relationships stand on solid ground in a broader sea of pressures to assimilate, truly working toward a more inclusive library. And Blakiston (chapter 11) borrows the intellectual framework of "design thinking" or "human-centered design" to put empathy with students at the center of the professional experience in a systematic way, instead of the one-job-fits-all approach that many workplaces take.

Sometimes it can seem as if a person is supposed to automatically know how to be a manager when they are promoted. The chapter by Psoter (chapter 14) addresses this head-on in her chapter about learning *how* to be a good manager; she outlines some of the practices and processes of becoming more reflective and empathetic in your work relationships.

Turn to these chapters if you are asking yourself, "How should a relationship between a supervisor and supervisee look?" Their authors remind us that libraries *are* the people who work in libraries, and that relationships are transformative forces in themselves.

Voices from the Field

Staying Connected When the Unexpected Happens

Arianne Hartsell-Gundy

Before COVID-19 turned so much of our lives upside down, I had been managing graduate students in internships and practicums for five years and felt as if I had a relatively good handle on how to create a valuable experience for the students, myself, and the library. Moving to working remotely in the spring of 2020 made it very clear that I was going to need to change my approach for any interns I would work with in the fall while our department continued to work remotely. Of course, providing remote internships isn't new for everyone, and I suspect it may be a more common option in the future. For me, though, it was not something I had deliberately planned to offer, and I realized it would require me to adapt relatively quickly. At this writing I am in the middle of supervising this year's intern remotely, but it feels like a good moment to reflect on what has and has not worked up to this point.

To offer the internship online, the first aspect that needed to be rethought was the hiring process itself. I, along with the other two members of the search committee, needed to make changes to the position description and job ad. We felt it was important to be transparent about the unknowns, specifically whether the internship would need to be remote in the spring as well as the fall. We emphasized that regardless of the decisions of the university and the library, we would work with the intern to figure out what was best for their particular needs. We also needed to be up-front about details such as that the intern would need to provide their own laptop and have reliable access to Wi-Fi. Since the interviews would take place on Zoom, we adjusted down the number of people and the time involved with the interviews. We sent the interview questions to the candidates ahead of time, which has become our practice in order to level the playing field for students with less interview experience. Now that the interviews were held through Zoom, we thought this practice would also help with nervousness. We also added several questions related to working remotely. We were specifically interested in getting a sense of the candidates' flexibility and ability to advocate for themselves.

As I began to work with the intern remotely, I quickly realized that communication and connection would be very important since I couldn't rely on just popping into the intern's cubicle to see how she was doing. Normally

when an intern starts, I take them out for lunch with a couple of other staff members. This time I scheduled several online meetings, which I explicitly described as casual in the invitation, in order to give the intern a chance to meet people and ask questions. I have always used tools like Jabber for instant messaging and Trello for managing projects, but they are even more important now. I have also always scheduled weekly check-in meetings, but in the past I was more likely to cancel or shorten them when things became busy, and the intern and I would check in more informally. Since our weekly meetings on Zoom have been our most consistent way to keep in touch, I've treated them as critically important for both the intern and me each week. The interns in our department are always invited to our department meetings, trainings, and workshops to help them feel connected to our work. As part of the learning experience, I set up informational meetings with colleagues across the library. For this online internship, I've made a special point of continuing to set up these meetings throughout the semester because I realized that the opportunity for serendipitous connections with library staff, such as striking up a conversation walking across the parking lot with someone, wouldn't be possible for this intern. Based on what I have heard and seen, it seems as if these approaches have helped her feel empowered to ask questions and become involved with our projects.

Another important aspect of this experience for me has been acknowledging that this is an unusual time and being patient with myself and with the intern. For both our sakes, I have found myself being more flexible with deadlines and expectations. She has expressed to me the very understandable difficulty she has had staying on schedule. Class time, homework, internship projects, and personal tasks all are taken care of in the same physical space, making it harder to mentally switch between commitments and carve out the time needed. I am aware, too, of how much harder it has been for me at times to concentrate and to remember all the details that go into supervising an internship as we all cope with living during a pandemic. Still, there have been some aspects that have been easier. For instance, scheduling is much easier when commute time isn't a factor. If she needs to meet with an advisor or classmate in the middle of her internship schedule on a particular day, she can easily do it. We just adjust her hours up and down on a given day as needed.

Luckily for me, the current intern is very good about making meaning out of the work she is doing and advocating for her own needs. Overall the internship has gone more smoothly than I expected, though there are some adjustments I plan to make in the spring. For one, in the fall we set the intern's hours at fifteen per week, which is fewer than normal. I don't regret this decision because at the time I didn't know what my capacity would be and what kinds of tasks we would have. I have found, though, that going from nineteen hours,

as before the pandemic, to fifteen hours has been a challenge, especially with the emphasis we place on getting interns involved with all aspects of our work, including attending a lot of meetings. In the spring we will move back to nineteen hours, which I think will help her become even more connected and involved. I also plan to spend some time in the early spring talking about her goals for the second semester. Usually I have one or two projects in mind that I want an intern to work on, but then I also spend some time early on finding out more about what the intern wants to learn and do. This past semester I have done a bit more of just assigning projects than I normally would, probably as a way to feel some sense of control in what has been an uncertain time. I would also like to find more ways to connect. I never realized how much I relied on physical cues, like just walking by the cubicle to see if an intern looked confused or stressed. Typically, I also rely heavily on doing things like inviting an intern for coffee from time to time as a way to chat more casually. Personality-wise I am not a huge fan of icebreakers and conversation games, but I do think I need to consider new ways to create a more comfortable space for conversation and reflection when connecting remotely, maybe by just building in more casual time for conversation while meeting on Zoom.

As always, supervising an internship is a tremendous amount of work, and this year has provided more challenges than normal. Still I find working with graduate students to be such a meaningful experience for me personally, as I always learn so much from their perspectives. This semester I especially benefited from the optimism and enthusiasm that an intern often brings to their work. At this moment it is hard to imagine what the future will hold and whether I will continue to have interns who will work remotely, but I do plan to take some of these lessons with me. No matter what configuration these learning experiences take, being more flexible, transparent, communicative, and empathetic are all good ways to help make a graduate student's experience positive.

CHAPTER 11

Crafting the Internship

An Empathy-Driven Approach

Rebecca Blakiston

Context

Internships at the University of Arizona

At their core, internships are for student learning and career preparation. Students aim to get hands-on experience in a professional environment, building specific competencies and skills and deepening their understanding of a particular field and potential career path after graduation.

At the University of Arizona, students are encouraged and often required to complete real-world experiences as part of their degree programs. The 100% Engagement initiative, an outcome of the university's strategic plan in 2013, called for "100 percent of our students to have the opportunity to engage in integrating and applying their knowledge through real-world experiential learning." [1] In response to this initiative, the School of Information added an internship requirement for its master's in library and information science degree in 2015.[2] The school has approximately two hundred students in its program, with the majority being distant students who are seeking local or remote opportunities. Even students who aren't required to complete an internship as part of their program often seek one out as a way to supplement course instruction and strengthen their qualifications and future job prospects.

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Most graduate-level internships hosted at the University of Arizona Libraries are designed as structured learning experiences, so they are unpaid and compensated through academic credit. The time and effort required for a student to complete an internship is equivalent to a three-credit course, which is nine hours per week during a regular (fall or spring) semester. Departments across the library host interns regularly, including Student Learning and Engagement, Research Engagement, the Health Sciences Library, and the University of Arizona Press. The majority of library interns are graduate students seeking master's degrees from the School of Information, though interns have come from a range of disciplines and have also included high school students, undergraduate students, and PhD students. Some of our library internships are publicly posted, competitive positions, whereas others are individually tailored to specific students. This book chapter focuses on those tailored experiences.

Internships in User Experience

As graduate students in a variety of disciplines explore potential career paths, they often run across positions in the evolving field of user experience (UX). A growing number of companies and countries across the world are recruiting for UX positions, including largely UX researcher and UX designer roles.[3] Researcher positions often appeal to students studying the social sciences, such as psychology, sociology, and anthropology. Designer positions, on the other hand, often appeal to those students studying graphic design, digital media, and visual communications.

There is also a natural connection between the study of library and information science and the field of UX. The School of Information's program includes competencies such as organization of information, research methods, and information and communication technologies.[4] As students find themselves studying information-seeking behavior, information architecture, website usability, and digital information systems, they may find they are well positioned for careers in the field of UX.

The UX Team at the Libraries

At the University of Arizona Libraries, the UX team was established in 2017. At its inception, it included three full-time positions: UX strategist, UX designer, and content strategist. The team was also given funding for student support, ranging between one and four student and graduate assistant positions. The students come from varied backgrounds and, while some specialize in particular areas, such as user research or data analysis, they tend to get a breadth of experience overall and could be described as UX generalists.

Centrally housed within library administration, the UX team acts similar to an internal design agency, supporting the work of projects and initiatives library-wide. There are over three hundred employees across the library, and so the work of the UX team is ever-changing. We collaborate regularly with web developers and programmers, project and product managers, marketing and communications staff, and research and instruction librarians. In addition to the day-to-day UX activities such as prototyping and usability testing, we regularly provide consultations and training for staff to expand our UX capacity and foster UX thinking library-wide. Given the varied nature of our work, we are never short of interesting projects to work on that provide unique and meaningful opportunities for student interns.

Internships on the UX Team

The UX team hosted four graduate student interns between 2017-2020. Two graduate students seeking their master's degrees in library and information sciences completed internships in the spring and summer of 2018. A graduate student seeking her master's degree in information completed an internship in spring of 2019. Then in spring of 2020, the UX team hosted its first independent study student, who was completing her PhD in psychology and linguistics. Each internship was for credit and unpaid. It was especially important to us that these projects, as unpaid labor, benefited the students' learning as much as, if not more than, a university course.

Applying our expertise in user-centered design, we individually crafted each internship project using a design thinking, empathy-driven approach. Design thinking is a framework for human-centered decision-making and innovation, often used in product design and strategy. It can be broken down into three nonlinear stages: understanding, exploring, and implementing.[5] In addition to using this framework to design products, services, and websites, we can use it to craft the internship experience.

Understanding the Student

Building Empathy

The first step in tailoring an internship project to a student's expectations is developing a deep understanding of the student. Using a student-centered philosophy, we ask: What are their goals and challenges? How might we design an internship experience that aligns with their goals and minimizes their challenges?

A great tool for answering these questions is cognitive empathy, an intentional practice for developing an understanding of others. Indi Young describes cognitive empathy as "purposely discovering the underlying thoughts and emotions

that guide someone else's decisions and behavior."[6] On the UX team, the graduate students had contacted us directly to seek out internship opportunities. We knew they were interested in getting experience in the field of UX, but at first we didn't know much more than that. So we incorporated cognitive empathy practices into our early communication with all potential interns.

For us, the main tool for building empathy and understanding has been an initial one-on-one conversation, mimicking the format we use for a semi-structured user interview.[7] I schedule a thirty-minute conversation with the potential intern where the aim is for me to more deeply understand what motivates, drives, and challenges them. While there is an element of sharing what the UX team is working on and what potential opportunities might be, there is a focus first on deep listening in order to gain understanding of the student.

To prepare for the conversation, as one would for a user interview, we identify a small set of open-ended questions. These guide the discussion while also leaving plenty of room to ask follow-ups and for the student to share other relevant experiences, concerns, or questions. In the field of UX, we often use personas as a tool to describe users' goals, behaviors, and constraints, helping us build empathy and encouraging us to make more user-centered decisions.[8] This framework of goals, behaviors, and constraints is also helpful when building empathy for a potential intern.

Identifying Goals

By understanding the student's goals, we can design a more beneficial internship experience that aligns with their professional aims and career aspirations. To identify the student's goals and motivations, we ask questions such as: What most interests you in working for this team? What are your career objectives? How could this internship experience help you reach your personal, academic, or professional goals?

For example, we heard from one student who wanted to improve their presentation and communication skills with colleagues to make them a stronger collaborator and colleague. We heard from another student that they wanted to get their feet wet with as many UX methods as possible to prepare for a career as a UX consultant. By asking these questions, we check our assumptions and better know how to focus a project so that it is most valuable to the student.

Identifying Behaviors

By understanding the student's behaviors, existing skill sets, and past experiences, we can better match them to potential opportunities. To learn more about the student's behaviors, we ask questions such as: What is your previous work

experience? What type of work do you enjoy doing? What is something you recently learned, and how did you go about learning it?

This becomes especially important as we try to align the project with existing organizational priorities. Through this process, we have learned, for example, that students have experience with particular technology and systems, social media and marketing skills, and campus-level partnerships and networks that could be leveraged.

Identifying Constraints

Finally, by understanding any scheduling, technology, or access limitations, we can better match an intern with an appropriate project. To uncover their challenges and constraints, we ask questions such as: What other obligations do you have this semester (e.g. other jobs, academic schedule, personal commitments)? What is your schedule and availability? What sort of support or accommodations do you need to be successful?

For example, you may discover that a student already works full-time, uses assistive technology for communication, or needs to work remotely. On the UX team, understanding these constraints has helped us design projects that were more remote and asynchronous or more suited for a short-term summer time frame.

Articulating the Design Challenge

In the design thinking process, at the end of the empathizing phase we can use what we learned to define the problem statement, design challenge, or point of view. To articulate the challenge in a way that encourages exploration of ideas, people often use the "How might we… ?" framing.[9] In the context of internships, we can use this as an opportunity to summarize the student's goals, behaviors, and constraints. For example: How might we provide the intern with hands-on experience with as many UX methods as possible, leveraging her research expertise and campus networks, in a remote setting? Or: How might we integrate the intern into library-wide projects, incorporating their existing expertise with library systems, during the summer months?

Exploring Project Ideas

Ideating

Once we understand the goals, behaviors, and constraints of the potential intern, it is time to explore potential project ideas. In the design thinking process, the exploratory phase includes rapid ideation, where we are encouraged to think

creatively and build upon each other's ideas to come up with a variety of potential solutions.

On the UX team, internship project ideas have come from a combination of the supervisor, colleagues, and the interns themselves. Presenting a variety of ideas and then building upon one another's ideas has been common. This process can be done both through real-time conversations and asynchronously over email.

At this point, it also becomes important to align the student's goals with organizational goals to identify a project that is both appropriate and practical. While the focus so far has been understanding the student, it is also critical to understand the current goals and challenges being faced internally by ourselves as supervisors, our colleagues, and our organizations. It might be helpful to review strategic priorities at a department, organization, or institution level to discover the most impactful opportunities.

Iterating

In most cases, during or after the initial conversation, I have provided a list of potential projects based on our conversation. For example, our design challenge for the spring 2019 intern was: How might we expand the intern's UX design skill set and build her campus network, leveraging her organizational and event-planning skills, in a mostly remote setting? I proposed a few project ideas as a starting point, including

1. contributing to the pilot of a UX lab in the student union, a campus collaboration
2. improving student experience as it relates to the Student Success District renovation project and rooms and spaces in the library
3. assisting in an inclusive design workshop series, a campus collaboration with disability resources
4. helping create a UX@UA website, organizing UX@UA events, and helping organize a UX Fest campus-wide

After several iterations, we ultimately merged the first and fourth option to land on: Supporting and fostering UX practices campus-wide, including planning UX professional development events and creating a UX@UA website.

Another example was our summer 2018 intern. In the understanding stage, we had discovered

- Goals: more experience with collaboration and teamwork across a large organization
- Behaviors: work experience in circulation and Alma
- Constraints: eight weeks during the summer term

We also looked at the library's existing priorities and projects to see where he might fit in. We were implementing Alma and Primo later in the summer,

so much of the UX team's work was going toward testing and customizing the Primo interface. He happened to have experience working with Alma and Primo, so this was a perfect fit.

Identifying Solutions

In table 11.1, you can see the internship projects that were ultimately identified based on the interns' skills and goals, as well as the organizational needs.

Table 11.1
Intern projects identified

Intern Goals	Intern Behaviors	Organizational Needs	Project Identified
Communication, facilitation, and leadership	Migrating to Alma, circulation, customer service	Implementation of Primo	Usability testing of Primo; full member of project team
UX methods; something for a portfolio	Prototyping and design, administrative support, event organization	Needing a website for UX@UA; needing more support for meetup events	Participating in UX@UA leadership team; designing a website using empathy maps, personas, usability testing
UX research methods	Qualitative research, psychology and linguistics	Addressing complaints about quiet study rooms	Library environments project
General UX methods, library experience	Marketing and communications, graduate student programs	Graduate student support	Graduate student journey mapping

Prototyping

Prototyping is often part of this exploratory stage. Prototypes are representations of ideas and are starting points for gathering input and continuing to iterate.[10] Artifacts that you can prototype and share with potential interns and colleagues include project proposals, learning outcomes, and job descriptions. By prototyping your ideas and gathering feedback before finalizing them, you have a

chance to think through both feasibility and alignment with the intern's goals and expectations.

Implementing the Internship Project

Once we identify an internship project, it's time for implementation. We have found that user-centered design practices continue to be helpful throughout the course of the internship project, for example:

- Observing. We notice what is working well and identify any pain points or challenges.
- Iterating. We are willing to shift focus and stay flexible through the course of the project.
- Empathizing. Continually, we intentionally build up our understanding of the intern and their experience with the goal of being able to support them better.

Providing a Professional Experience

A shared goal for all interns is that they want to get an authentic and meaningful professional experience. Because of this, integration into the work environment is critical. The UX team considers our interns as integral members of the team and the organization more broadly, referring to them as our colleagues and offering them regular credit and recognition for their contributions. This integration into the organization is further demonstrated by

- including them on our team UX organizational chart
- adding them to the staff directory on the public website
- adding them to the Slack channel we use for team communication
- inviting them to attend and participate in weekly team meetings
- when possible, including them in cross-departmental opportunities
- when possible, providing them with a dedicated workspace alongside their colleagues

At the outset, we provide a structured, lightweight onboarding process for all interns. This includes, at minimum, reviewing the job description and work expectations together, providing them with readings, introducing them to communication tools such as Slack and Trello, and giving them a tour of the workplace.

Since leadership is often one of the student's goals as well as an important skill sought out by future employers, we often ask interns to be leads on some aspects of their projects. This provides them with the experience to make decisions, solve problems, and communicate their work. It also allows them freedom to shift gears and focus on their own learning and what will be most helpful for them. At

the end of her internship, one of our interns said she appreciated this autonomy and being treated like a professional rather than "just an intern."

Offering Support and Mentorship

To provide ongoing communication, support, and mentorship, as well as a structure for continued iteration of the internship projects, we have regular (usually weekly) one-on-one meetings between intern and supervisor. These meetings are intern-driven. Questions the supervisor uses as a starting framework are: What have you been working on? How can I support you this coming week?

We also regularly ask reflective questions to better understand how things are going and where we can iterate. For projects broken into structured phases, we try to incorporate reflection at the end of each phase. These questions are along the lines of: Are you getting the right level of guidance? How are you feeling about where things are at with the project? Are you where you expected to be at this point in the project? How can we better meet the goals we established at the outset of the internship?

Delivering Outputs

Many students also value having a tangible end product at the end of their internship. This can be something like a slide deck, an article, a blog post, or some other artifact they can include in their résumé or portfolio. This can strengthen their candidacy for future jobs as it gives them something to point to as an example of their work. For our interns, tangible outputs have included presentations to the library and at conferences, Medium publications, empathy maps, journey maps, and websites.[11]

Reflecting and Acknowledging

At the closing out of an internship, students have a final meeting with their supervisor and receive a documented evaluation. Recently, we have also facilitated an internship retrospective activity. This provides a framework for the interns to share their experience and help us continually iterate on our process. In spring 2020, our retrospective was framed as the 4 Ls Exercise.[12]

1. Loved
2. Longed for
3. Loathed
4. Learned

This framework allowed us to discover what worked well, including regular meetings, a supportive team environment, timelines, and communication tools. Both interns agreed, for example, that they loved the weekly check-ins as

an opportunity to get feedback and discuss ideas. We were pleased to hear one intern learned "a lot more than expected" and "would recommend it to others." We also learned more about what we could improve upon next time, including providing design interns more experience with technical aspects of design work, such as how websites work on the back end.

Internships are important professional milestones for graduate students and deserving of recognition at their conclusion. The work of the UX interns has also been of great benefit to our organization, so we make a point to celebrate their work. Ways to acknowledge intern accomplishments include

- sharing their work at a library staff meeting
- writing about their work in internal or external newsletters
- mentioning their contributions in publications related to their work
- hosting celebratory lunches or other social events
- giving signed thank-you cards and personalized gifts

Conclusion

As illustrated in this chapter, principles of human-centered design can inform better internship experiences for graduate students. By focusing on the student's individual goals, skill sets, and constraints, we can identify and craft the most valuable and rewarding experiences, setting them up for future professional success.

Heaps of thanks to our graduate student interns from 2017–2020: Rachel Brown, Zuleima Cota, Gardie Lueders, and Louis Migliazza. Also thanks to the 2019–2020 internship task force for their hard work and inspiration: Armando Cruz, Kathryn Conrad, Lisa Duncan, Annabelle Nunez, Nicole Pagowsky, Jerry Perry, and Megan Senseney.

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VOICES FROM THE FIELD

Intern Self-Advocacy and the Mutual Benefits of Collaboration

Samantha Wilairat

LIS interns and librarians alike should note the value of collaborating with professional library staff during a LIS internship. In any library, there are ways for LIS interns to integrate into a librarian's ongoing project or potential opportunities for an intern to propose a new direct collaboration opportunity. However, without thoughtful design of the internship program and self-advocacy by the intern, internships may be nothing more than technical positions or busy work.[1]

Throughout my time in graduate school, I interned at the Strauss Health Sciences Library at the University of Colorado Anschutz Medical Campus. My boss began the internship by having me share with her job descriptions of positions I would like to apply for after graduation. She encouraged me to seek out collaborative opportunities at the library that would help me gain relevant work experience and make me a competitive applicant for the jobs I found interesting. This exercise helped me feel empowered to self-advocate and create learning opportunities within my internship that aligned with my professional goals. I was able to say no to tasks that did not align with my learning goals and to pitch projects that did align with areas that I wanted to grow in. My boss also shared with me that throughout my internship I should consider myself a working librarian despite not yet having the official letters tacked behind my name. This mental shift helped me to feel comfortable viewing my work with librarians as a mutual collaboration.

Make Direct Collaboration Happen

LIS interns should consider taking the initiative to ensure that collaboration with a library professional will happen. Upon beginning the internship, interns should propose informational interviews with all librarians within the department, as well as librarians in departments in which the intern is interested in learning more about. An informational interview will allow rapport to build naturally and will give the intern insight into specific areas of interests or projects each librarian is working on. The intern should make their professional interests known so library staff know when to invite them to join committees, suggest potential projects, or suggest networking connections.

Creating a polished project proposal is one way for interns to self-advocate. I would encourage interns to write proposals to suggest projects they are passionate about. It is always helpful for interns to garner support from the department head as well, which may make librarians more likely to accept the proposal to collaborate. Interns come from a variety of backgrounds both personally and professionally. They should be sure to leverage their skill sets when offering to collaborate. For example, while working as a medical librarian intern at the Strauss Health Sciences Library, I was able to use my teaching background to cocreate an assessment project and later present it at the Medical Library Association 2020 Conference.

Benefits to the LIS Intern

My firsthand experience indicated that there are many benefits to the intern from entering a collaborative working relationship. This collaboration may allow the intern to have more opportunities to learn important twenty-first-century skills and to present at conferences than they would doing independent projects or clerical work. For example, through my collaboration with librarians, I've learned how to effectively work remotely with others across multiple digital platforms and how to take an active leadership role in project management.

Additionally, collaboration will allow for integration into the greater library community.[2] By working with various library professionals, the intern has the opportunity to build a personal learning network that they will benefit from throughout their career.[3] Most interns are looking to gain meaningful work experience and explore new areas of librarianship.[4] Collaborating with librarians may also create a portfolio of evidence that may be used in job interviews.

A more immediate benefit of collaboration is shifting the perception of the intern from student to colleague. The traditional hierarchy of interns ranking below permanent employees is called into question when interns are allowed to work side by side with library professionals. An example of successful intern-librarian collaboration is the speedy creation of a COVID-19 LibGuide that I completed with two librarians.

Benefits of the Library Work Environment

Librarian and intern collaboration is a mutually beneficial relationship.[5] On a purely practical level, allowing interns to work as if they are already professionals expands the work capacity of the department and lessens the workload

on librarians.[6] Further down the road, a student's positive internship experience could improve the reputation of the institution within the library school community, which could lead to successful recruitment of future interns or permanent hires.[7]

The library staff member collaborating directly with the intern has the opportunity to learn skills from the intern that they may not have learned in library school, such as updated technology skills. The intern may also offer a fresh perspective, and their motivation to submit proposals to conferences and journals may create additional opportunities for the library staff member to publish. This reinforces the idea that in order to remain relevant and avoid burnout, librarians must be continuous learners.[8]

Takeaways

LIS interns should advocate for opportunities to collaborate directly with library professionals in order to make the most out of their library internship and gain hands-on experience.[9] Librarians should support intern efforts to propose collaborative projects in order to invest in the future of the profession and allow themselves to learn from the intern.

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CHAPTER 12

Beyond Individualism

Self-Advocacy and Mentorship in LIS Graduate Student Employment

Kristin Kerbavaz and Amber Dierking

Introduction

Graduate students in master of library and information science (MLIS) programs face competitive job markets, and while many students work while studying, it is a challenge to gain meaningful and relevant work experience. This chapter discusses the role of advocacy in the graduate student work experience. We argue that self-advocacy, while a practical necessity for many graduate students, is problematic due to its roots in neoliberal ideals of individualism. Drawing on our own recent graduate school experiences, we will explore ways that self-advocacy both helped and harmed us. We will ultimately suggest alternative ways that mentors and student supervisors can reduce the burden of self-advocacy for their students.

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Professional Landscape

The difficult and frustrating nature of the library and information science (LIS) job search is well documented. New graduates, in particular, often struggle to obtain their first post-MLIS position despite the copious on-the-job experience they acquire during their degree programs. In 2002, Sproles and Ratledge's analysis of the previous twenty years of entry-level job ads concluded that gaining on-the-job experience before obtaining a professional degree was all but mandatory to meet the requirements listed.[1] Geary and Hickey's 2019 study shows that 96.4 percent of current students are employed—many working over thirty hours per week or holding multiple jobs.[2] The struggle to land a permanent postgraduation position is likely due in part to how libraries have followed the broader trend in higher education toward adjunctification, increasing part-time and contract positions in lieu of continuing appointments.[3]

Students and new graduates are particularly vulnerable to the effects of precarious, nonpermanent, or otherwise uncertain work. Rodriguez and colleagues point out specific effects of the cumulative financial impact caused by this work, such as costs for multiple moves, overlapping rents, broken leases, childcare, and commuting.[4] The trend toward adjunctification and precarious work leads to "a state of material and psychological vulnerability resulting from uncertain pay, schedules, hours of work, or employment duration and lack of access to the social protections and benefits usually associated with full time employment."[5] Although accepting precarious positions can often be necessary to gain experience, these positions simultaneously create barriers of additional stress, uncertainty, and unrealistic expectations that detract from the ability to fully focus on one's long-term career goals.

The nature of this precarious work reinforces inequalities, as it forces the individual worker to absorb additional costs and "risks leaving out or pushing out people who are less likely to have the necessary resources."[6] Individuals who lack those resources may be less able to accept precarious positions as students or new graduates and consequently struggle to meet the experience requirements for full-time, permanent positions. Moreover, Rodriguez and colleagues have also found that "completing one term position at an institution was more likely to lead to more contingent work there than full-time work at that institution,"[7] as 66 percent of those rehired were rehired into contingent positions.

In times of economic uncertainty, we have seen these issues exacerbated. Cannady and Newton have discussed this phenomenon regarding the 2008 recession, stating that "there will be more competition in an already tough job market, and job seekers will be facing a unique set of challenges."[8] The same holds true during disasters like the COVID-19 pandemic, as precarious workers and new hires are often the first to be furloughed or laid off, while hiring freezes make the elusive full-time continuing entry-level position even harder to attain.[9]

Ever-increasing requirements for entry level positions hinder students and new graduates in their search for meaningful, discipline-relevant work experience.[10] The studies of Sproles and Ratledge, Reeves and Hahn, and Tewell all conclude that the amount of experience requested in entry-level job listings is increasing.[11] In his pilot study of successful applicants for a sample of fifty job listings, Tewell found "evidence that entry level positions are not likely to be filled by applicants with experience of one year or less."[12] Of successful candidates for the entry-level jobs in Tewell's sample, 75.8 percent were not actually entry-level individuals. With such slim odds, it is no wonder so many capable, prepared recent graduates struggle as they enter the job market. Taking into account the competitive nature of job searching, the ever-increasing expectations in entry level-positions, and the trend of entry-level positions being filled by individuals with more than one year of experience, it has been and continues to be essential to gain relevant and meaningful work experience before or during one's MLIS studies in order to land a full-time position in the field.

Advocacy in Graduate Student Employment

Williams and Schoultz define advocacy as "speaking or acting on behalf of oneself or another person or an issue with self-sacrificing vigour and vehemence."[13] In this chapter, we will primarily be discussing advocacy for the self, or self-advocacy. The term *self-advocacy* has historically been used primarily in the context of critical disability studies.[14] In this chapter, we will use the term *self-advocacy* to mean the actions of LIS graduate students who are promoting their own best interests. Self-advocacy in this context is the act of identifying, communicating, and working toward one's desired outcomes. In the authors' experiences, self-advocacy was what allowed them to navigate their student work opportunities and ultimately gain the experience they needed for a full-time role. It led to proactive pursuit of student jobs, internships, and graduate assistantships. It was a practical tool that helped convince them to apply for additional scholarships and grant funding. It was the push needed to say no to opportunities that were not in line with their end goals. Adopting the role of self-advocate, students must speak and act in their own self-interest, creating structure and intentionality within their work to meet specific needs and professional goals. To be effective self-advocates, students must be able to articulate what they want and pursue the individual steps needed to get there.

Despite the practicality of self-advocacy, it is a problematic solution. Self-advocacy can be individualistic in its reliance on flexible self-sufficiency. By "individualistic," we refer to individualism as an economic philosophy, where there is "faith in the capacity of individual action and ambition, working through

the market, to create wealth and to bring about progress."[15] Individual choices and actions are held in high esteem under individualism, invoking the myth of meritocracy, where all responsibility for success and blame for failure to succeed is transferred onto the individual rather than structural inequalities.

However, this framing of individualism does not fully capture how the individualistic aspects of self-advocacy can be problematic. We propose that the unilateral reliance on self-advocacy can be referred to as maladaptive individualism: individualism that is ultimately self-detrimental. Individualism becomes maladaptive when, in order to maintain the ability to be self-sufficient and make choices in the future, one gives up a degree of present autonomy. Despite awareness of what healthy self-advocacy could be, one knowingly oversteps that boundary. Maladaptive individualism is closely related to Berg and colleagues' concept of the "resilience narrative," which "encourages adaptation to these conditions [of exploitation, inequality, and harassment] instead of resistance."[16] They call this resilience narrative a "band-aid for systemic issues."[17] Similarly, maladaptive individualism allows the individual to momentarily survive the pressures they experience, but fails to address the root causes of those pressures. Systemic issues are allowed to continue, and both the individual and their peers are forced to continue finding individual solutions to those issues' effects.

One pressure that seems to demand self-advocacy is the balance between experience and excessive workload. The apparent solution to this challenge is saying no and setting boundaries. In practice, however, particularly at the high-stakes junction of graduate school and a professional career, this is nearly impossible to perfectly execute: it can be difficult to know how much experience will be enough and all too easy to overextend oneself. In the words of one of the authors, being in this circumstance "makes it feel like my life is a triage situation before anything even goes wrong." Knowing that she had likely said yes to a dangerous number of things but cognizant that those experiences would be critical for her looming job search, the author carefully considered each obligation and identified one or two each semester that could be dropped if necessary. Having this built-in pressure valve relieved a significant amount of stress, regardless of whether or not she actually used the pressure valve. While this strategy was very effective, it is also an example of maladaptive individualism; it ultimately enabled her to take on an unhealthy number of responsibilities at the expense of other aspects of her life.

This emphasis on individualism is foundational to neoliberalism. Gill and Donaghue provide three main characteristics of neoliberalism as a political and economic force: "increasing individualization, withdrawal of the state, and introduction of market logics and rationalities into ever more spheres of life."[18] Neoliberalism also prompts movement toward flexible workforces and deregulated free-market economies, incentivizing precarious work while simultaneously

minimizing the importance of collective responsibility.[19] Under this neoliberal individualist paradigm, all responsibility and blame for failure to succeed is transferred onto the individual rather than structural failings. In this environment, self-advocacy may function as a practical coping mechanism that helps one stick the Band-Aid of resilience on one's circumstances, but it also forces the individual to buy into these ultimately harmful precepts.

In their book *Austerity Blues,* Michael Fabricant and Stephen Brier track the history of public education's political-economic context. They show how neoliberal policies were not always prevalent in public higher education but have "seeped into the governance and practice" of our public institutions, leading to a "fiscal landscape of continuing disinvestment" of public funds from higher education.[20] Academic libraries, as part and parcel of higher education, are affected by these policies too—pushed to do more with less and adopt business strategies of efficiency and productivity with metrics and measurable outcomes.[21] As the pervading influence of market logics is felt in higher education and libraries, the individual worker often faces pressure to demonstrate the value of their labor in economic terms,[22] taking on increasing responsibilities to make their labor indispensable to the institution. This pressure to say yes to new responsibilities is exacerbated by power dynamics: it is particularly impactful for students and early career librarians, those presently in precarious roles, and individuals who are members of marginalized communities. Even if individuals in one or several of these circumstances want to advocate for more boundaries, a better work-life balance, and so on, they may decide it's not worth the risk. Just as women have been shown to face penalties and higher social costs relative to men when negotiating higher compensation,[23] similar risks may apply to all those attempting to advocate for their boundaries when they are already disadvantaged by existing power dynamics.

Although it can be a useful tool, self-advocacy cannot be considered the primary solution to the challenges that graduate students face while looking for and working through meaningful work experiences. While self-advocacy may help in navigating one's immediate needs and building a foundation for future success, it also plays into narratives of resilience and patterns of maladaptive individualism that allow unhealthy work cultures to persist. Such a tool should not be lauded as a singular solution.

Alternatives to Self-Advocacy

In an ideal workplace, institutional support for graduate student employees and early-career professionals would render self-advocacy unnecessary. Support structures like professional development funding for graduate student employees, formalized peer groups and mentoring programs, networking opportunities, and training in best practices for prospective mentors would resolve many of the

challenges that will be addressed in this part. These structures would relieve the pressures of advocacy for both students and the mentors who support them. We encourage those with institutional power to provide the kinds of support that their student employees need to be successful. In circumstances where institutional support is lacking, however, there are still alternatives to self-advocacy that help us to resist its neoliberal individualist approach by building communities of support.

One of these alternatives is peer advocacy, which can be robust in MLIS programs, where students are bound together by common experience and circumstances. The authors observed several forms of peer advocacy during their time as students, many relating to information sharing. Job ads were regularly shared over various social media platforms, posted to email lists, and messaged directly to specific individuals who would be most interested. This allowed potential applicants to benefit from their peers' unique connections or existing professional networks. Crowdsourcing interview questions was another of the most impactful forms of peer advocacy observed by the authors; particularly popular was the *Hiring Librarians*' "Interview Questions 'Database,'" a crowdsourced spreadsheet of questions and accompanying metadata that both supports applicants in their interview preparation and helps to normalize expectations of the interview process.[24] Other forms of peer advocacy observed included the exchanging and reviewing of application materials and the open discussion of the application processes even in cases where multiple individuals were in competition for the same position. These open exchanges of information were essential to clarify the implicit expectations and norms of hiring in the profession. Remarkably, considering the job market, these interactions emphasized collaboration over competition. Solidarity through peer advocacy helped combat the individualistic demands of self-advocacy while still promoting student success.

Another key alternative to self-advocacy is intentional and proactive mentorship. By mentoring graduate student employees, more experienced librarians can help lessen the load of self-advocacy on their students. Both authors benefited hugely from mentorship during our time as graduate student employees: mentors helped us identify and pursue appropriate opportunities, target our work responsibilities based on our own desired learning outcomes, and prepare for interviews. We cannot overstate the impact of these mentors on our learning, our work experiences, and our careers.

While some mentorship relationships may be formalized by mentorship programs or supervisory relationships, others arise more naturally. Any member of a student's growing professional network may serve as a mentor, including instructors in the graduate program and library staff at the graduate institution. The fact that students may have multiple informal mentors at a time—and, indeed move between mentors as their interests and needs grow and change—is

appropriate considering the complexity of the LIS professional landscape. MacKinnon and Shepley note that "A 'one size fits all' approach to mentorship is not viable in a time when the career paths of many academic librarians no longer follow a direct route."[25] Having multiple informal mentors can allow graduate students to develop a more holistic understanding of library work.

A key element of a successful mentorship relationship is the activeness and intentionality of the mentor. Finding mentors can be a daunting process for graduate students, who may know that mentorship is valuable but struggle to identify their exact needs and select an appropriate potential mentor while they are at such an early stage of their career.[26] Potential mentors have the opportunity to alleviate this pressure by proactively offering support; this can include mentoring students themselves or leveraging their networks to connect students with professionals whose skills and experiences are relevant to students' goals. Because of the value of informal mentorship, this support does not need to be formal or intensive to be meaningful.

The care and intentionality of the mentor are key to the success of the mentorship relationship; mentorship is an unequal power dynamic, and mentors can inadvertently cause harm if they do not take care to consider the unique goals, needs, and circumstances of their mentee. A vital consideration for mentors is the prioritization of mentee agency and learning once a mentorship has been established. Some mentorships can fall victim to "academic cloning," in which experienced faculty encourage graduate students and junior faculty to follow their own career paths as closely as possible. While the experiences of established librarians are valuable for graduate students to learn from, this cookie-cutter approach fails to consider differences in lived experience, approaches, and priorities between mentor and mentee. To support mentee agency and ensure that the graduate student has a meaningful experience, "the mentor should inquire about the intern's goals and objectives for this particular experience, as well as broader career aspirations."[27] This prioritization of mentee needs can be supported by the mentee's own reflective practice. MacKinnon and Shepley recommend that mentees regularly reflect on their needs, goals, and growth areas "to identify opportunities for purposeful mentorship."[28] Reflective practice allows the mentee to advocate for their own needs within the mentorship structure: where individualist self-advocacy demands that students both identify and solve problems for themselves, this supported self-advocacy allows mentors to provide assistance that is intentional and targeted.

While the focus of each mentorship opportunity will be different depending on the experiences and needs of the student, there are three main areas in which mentors can support their graduate student employees. The first goal of a successful mentorship should be to illuminate what Lacy and Copeland call "tacit knowledge,"[29] which we have previously referred to as "implicit

expectations." They found that the student mentees in their program primarily sought a greater understanding of day-to-day work and workplace expectations, as well as work experience and help with the job search. Intentional mentorship that surfaces tacit knowledge, they say, allows mentees to build confidence and build an understanding of professional expectations that they otherwise might not have been exposed to. Alderman and Milne refer to this as the responsibility to interpret for students, empowering them to make their own decisions.[30]

One expectation that requires a great deal of interpretation is that of when and how to say no. Both authors struggled to identify what amount of experience was enough, resulting in a delicate balance of bandwidth and responsibilities that necessitated the pressure valve escape mechanism described earlier in this chapter. While this strategy was ultimately effective, it was also a response to an avoidable scenario of overwork. Mentors can support their graduate student employees by initiating conversations about workload and helping their students interpret and prioritize the many demands on their time and intellectual output. While saying no is an important kind of self-advocacy and self-care, it must also be acknowledged that asking students to navigate the implicit expectations of the profession without support is unjust and harmful. Lacey notes that the very concept of self-care is "complex and often problematic," as it requires access to time, money, and resources.[31] As Andrews observes, "Establishing boundaries is only useful if you have the means to aggressively defend them, or if you are already respected."[32] The cultural expectation of self-care fails to acknowledge the responsibility of the organization to establish clear expectations and promote boundary setting.[33] In this way, expectations of self-care operate under the same neoliberal individualist paradigm that informs ideas of self-advocacy, putting the onus of survival on the individual rather than promoting a healthier work environment. By proactively setting workload expectations for students under their supervision, as well as helping students identify opportunities and strategies for boundary setting, mentors can both lessen the demands of self-advocacy upon their students and give the students the tools to navigate boundary setting in future roles.

The second main area of focus for graduate student mentorships is the job search, which requires a mix of skill building and tacit knowledge. Lacy and Copeland found that "advice from their mentors gave [students] confidence that they were on the right track or, if not, what was needed to correct their course of action."[34] This general validation of a student's strategy and direction helps to surface areas of conflict between implicit professional expectations and a student's understanding of the requirements they face. Mentors can also provide more targeted support in several areas. The ability to articulate how one's experience is transferable to a particular position is key to success in the job search,

and this successful positioning relies on the applicant's understanding of the library landscape. As Lacy and Copeland note, "Only candidates who know what is expected of them can demonstrate to potential employers how they would fulfill the job requirements."[35] Mentors can work with students to interpret job postings and brainstorm strategic application materials. They can also help students develop good questions to ask their interviewers. Asking the right questions, both to identify potential red flags and to demonstrate the applicant's thoughtful research and knowledge, is an important interview skill that can be difficult to develop. Lacey remembers, "It took time for me to learn to ask the right questions in job interviews… ,"[36] an experience shared by both authors of this chapter. Early mentor support can help minimize the need for trial and error in high-stakes interviews, helping students be more successful in their job searches by sharing the mentors' experience and understanding of tacit expectations of what constitutes a good question.

In addition to interpreting tacit knowledge, mentors can wield their relative institutional power in a variety of ways to benefit their mentees. The most basic and essential form that this internal advocacy can take is bringing students to the table. Hands-on opportunities to learn about facets of library employment like scholarship and service help students build the kind of practical institutional and professional knowledge that helps them be more successful in interviews and in their future positions. One of the students interviewed by Lacy and Copeland recalled, "…my mentor just signed me up and she was like 'okay, you're going to come with me to all these things.'"[37] One author also remembers a mentor who went above and beyond by using her discretionary budget to pay for conference registration and poster printing fees on her student's behalf. This generous act not only enabled the author to gain valuable experience at professional events she would otherwise have struggled to afford, but also relieved the author of the burden of asking for financial help. Mentors can support their mentees in a variety of ways, depending on mentee needs and available resources. While we do not mean to suggest that financial assistance is always appropriate, possible, or necessary, we include this example to demonstrate that proactive action coming from a place of empathy can have a profound impact on mentee's experience by mitigating the pressures of self-advocacy.

Advocacy becomes especially important for mentees from underrepresented identities, who often experience additional structural barriers. One of the librarians interviewed by Lacy and Copeland discussed the way that his identity as an African American man impacts the way he approaches his work; he said he shared the "considerations that I have that other librarians don't have"[38] with the student he mentored, helping that mentee navigate identity-specific tacit knowledge. This mirrors the experience of Mitchell, who reflects that

> as a black woman in a field where upwards of ninety percent of the demographic is made up of non-people-of-color, fostering relationships with [other Black women in libraries and archives] has been crucial to learning of career opportunities, navigating difficult times within my career, and building a future that I desire for myself and my peers.[39]

Building a supportive community of peers and mentors is important for all graduate students and new librarians; for Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (BIPOC) and people with other marginalized identities, there is added value in peers and mentors who share their identities and lived experiences. Yet, as Mitchell points out, the vast majority of the LIS field is made up of White women. Martinez-Cola notes, this "under-representation of faculty of Color in the academy ensures the chances that students of Color will likely look to White faculty as mentors."[40]

How, then, can White mentors best support the BIPOC they mentor? Advocacy is a large part of the answer. Both of Martinez-Cola's positive mentor archetypes take on the responsibility of advocating for their mentees rather than requiring self-advocacy from them. The "Nightlight" archetype uses their power to shed light on "the often unspoken rules [of academia]."[41] Martinez-Cola gives the examples of intervening when a student is expected to speak on behalf of all members of their identity group or making a point to recognize a mentee's scholarship, which can be especially helpful in combating imposter syndrome. Another archetype, the "Ally," combines this advocacy with self-reflection, taking responsibility for the labor of self-reflection and self-education. Martinez-Cola also notes that the Ally's mentorship moves away from deficit thinking to a model where the mentee's "credentials, intelligence, and contributions are already assumed to exist,"[42] reaffirming the mentee's place in their chosen profession. This focus on helping students combat imposter syndrome through affirmation and respectful treatment aligns with the findings of Cress's 2008 study of college persistence: "Students who feel that faculty treat them with respect, give them honest feedback about their ability, challenge them intellectually and give them emotional support are less likely to perceive negative campus climate or prejudice."[43] Mentor interactions with their students can have a profound impact on their mentees' experiences on campus. By combining advocacy with intentionality and reflective practice, mentors can help relieve the burden of self-advocacy on their BIPOC mentees and support them as they navigate their student employment and job search experiences.

Conclusion

This chapter has explored self-advocacy's value as a tool for navigating the sea of paid and unpaid work experiences students face during their graduate programs. As ever higher quantities of work experience become essential to gaining relevant, full-time, entry-level positions, students must find a way to ensure these

work experiences are meaningful and in line with their career goals. Self-advocacy, used as a tool to manage these workloads and work toward specific desired outcomes, functions as a practical short-term solution to these challenges. Ultimately, although students may find value in practicing self-advocacy, relying exclusively on this tactic falls prey to neoliberal individualist rhetoric, where the blame for failure to succeed is foisted unfairly on the student. Instead, by providing resources, clarifying implicit expectations, and centering the student's experience, communities of peers and mentors can share responsibility and alleviate the burden of self-advocacy on individuals.

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VOICES FROM THE FIELD

Wayfinding and Gapminding

An Integrated Approach to Developing a Library Internship Learning Experience

Emily Cukier and Terri Artemchik

Since the fall of 2017, Loyola University Chicago has offered MLIS graduate students part-time, temporary internships. Each internship provides instruction and reference experience, plus special projects aligned with the individual intern's professional goals and interests. This structure offers space for what we think of as *wayfinding*, the process of seeking information and experiences to decide among possible future paths, and *gapminding*, or filling experience gaps to smooth pursuit of those paths. This profile details our process over the 2019–2020 academic year to cocreate an internship experience to propel Emily to a career in librarianship that reflects her aspirations.

The internship is designed around the intern's interests, competencies, and curiosity. Core duties such as first-year information literacy instruction and reference service reflect standard library experiences, while other pieces enable free-form wayfinding. Interns learn the functional areas of the academic library and make connections by interviewing the libraries' faculty and staff and participating in committee and department meetings. In particular, interviews efficiently capture a vivid portrait of a library professional, including their career path, day-to-day work, and professional philosophy. Through these interviews, Emily learned not only about diverse roles and experiences in the library profession, but also about strategies librarians used to develop their own careers.

> *[Emily:]* I began the internship with two overarching goals in mind: get library work experience for my CV and learn if my personality is a "good fit" for an academic library. I undertook the internship as a prototype experience—a low-investment exercise in gathering information about a potential career path—which is a tactic I learned from William Burnett's *Designing Your Life*. I wanted to immerse myself in multiple library functions that could be components of future jobs, such as research consultations, information literacy instruction, instructional design, and resource creation.

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One librarian I interviewed suggested conducting a "gap analysis" to identify desirable elements missing from my résumé. She suggested I brainstorm skills the internship could supply and prioritize those that would be needed sooner, were common to multiple career paths, and hard to get outside of an academic library. This planted the seeds for Terri and me to develop our gapminding philosophy.

Early in the internship I attended the Midwest Data Librarian Symposium, which sparked my interest in research data librarianship. Between attending the symposium and combing job boards, I compiled a list of career options and desirable skills for data librarians and saw that my background was light on data-related domain knowledge and skills. I took this concern to Terri, and in our regular meetings, we designed projects to develop and demonstrate data-related experience.

[Terri:] I supported Emily by seeking project collaborators in departments relevant to her interests. While Loyola does not employ a dedicated data services librarian, some librarians serve technological roles that incorporate data librarianship skills. We worked closely with them to find a long-term project that could use Emily's data interests and scientific background: a metadata cleaning and migration project to prepare digital specimen records from Loyola's herbarium for upload to a public portal. This project included evaluating metadata schemata and controlled vocabularies for plant specimens, finding specialized metadata validation tools, and creating a metadata application profile to map local elements to elements suitable for specimen-sharing portals.

Emily also built her data skills in smaller-scope projects that combined data manipulation and everyday library functions. She assisted colleagues with coding, data analysis, and visualization for library assessment projects. She developed and taught a workshop on good data hygiene for her library colleagues. She also independently created a research guide on data visualization. These projects produced tangible evidence of her skills and helped her appreciate different ways those skills could support key library activities. Being in the posi-

tion to support Emily's professional goals as well as finding ways to benefit the libraries was extremely fulfilling.

Wayfinding and gapminding are iterative, intertwined processes to guide career development when the ultimate goals and desires are uncertain. Emily began her internship without a fixed idea of how to use her interests and skills in a library setting. We cocreated the internship experience to let Emily's personal self-reflection guide her own process for developing skills and building real-world experience with them. Her next steps toward a career in research data librarianship are to seek an entry-level librarian position at a research-oriented institution and concurrently build skills in data management and analysis technologies through additional coursework.

Based on our experience, the following steps can help students and supervisors create similar wayfinding and gapminding experiences in internships:

- Reflect on students' personal strengths, interests, skills, and goals.
- Find low-investment information-seeking experiences such as interviews and conference participation.
- Analyze gaps to identify and prioritize needed skills that the internship could supply.
- Build relationships with colleagues to identify projects to generate tangible evidence of experience.

CHAPTER 13

Two Sides of the Coin

Sharing Perspectives on Work and Identity between a Graduate Student and an Academic Library Manager

April M. Hathcock and Lingyu Wang

Introduction

In this joint chapter, we—Lingyu, a former academic library scholarly communications graduate student specialist, and April, an academic library scholarly communications manager—reflect on our two years working together and the unique opportunities for learning, collaborating, and mentoring that have arisen. Following a conversational style, we discuss key points in our collaboration and relationship, including how we each came to enter the library and information science (LIS) profession, what noteworthy projects highlighted our work together, how we brought our identities into our work, and finally where we see our work going in the future as situated within broader professional and social landscapes. In reflecting on our work, we adopt the critical lenses of identity and

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communication, given that we both belong to identity groups that are largely underrepresented in the library and information profession. We highlight the ways in which mentorship and collaborative work have helped us explore the interrelated boundaries of professional and personal identities. We hope that this chapter serves as a case study for strong relationship building and support between managers and graduate student workers, which can be used to better prepare the next generation of diverse library and information professionals.

We wrote this chapter during a time of change and uncertainty, when the COVID-19 pandemic is posing serious questions for academic communities: scholars, students, and library workers are forced to adopt new modes of collaboration and communication; local communities and digital counterparts have come to support people in their work and everyday life; xenophobic and racist policies are dividing communities and putting certain groups under further marginalization and risk, while countering social movements are striving for the better and reshaping the world we live in.

In writing this chapter, we situate ourselves in the current climate when reflecting on and contextualizing our past work. By doing this, we hope to bring to the fore unifying ideas and practices for change (i.e., praxes) that can serve to build more inclusion in our work, both during this pandemic and in the future.[1] One thing we both have taken away from our relationship is a recognition of the need to engage praxis from the outside world to benefit the "insides" of higher education and academic libraries. This conversation—written asynchronously, in a back-and-forth style during a time of social distancing and large-scale quarantining—represents our reflections on how we can use our work and identities to bridge gaps in our professional and personal lives. From these reflections, we end by offering recommendations for how others can work to make this kind of inclusive change making a reality.

Our Conversation

Forging Paths in LIS

April

Congratulations on finishing your master's program and embarking on your doctoral studies! It has been such a joy to work with you, Lingyu, and I am excited to be able to collaborate on this book chapter and other scholarly projects to come. There is a sense of accomplishment that can come from reflecting on our separate paths and the ways those paths have come together in our working relationship.

In fact, one of the things we have in common from the start is that neither of us took a direct path to this work. Having started my professional life as a corporate lawyer, I made the transition to librarianship after realizing corporate law did not

quite offer me the career satisfaction I was seeking. It was a fairly meandering path that led me to scholarly communications librarianship.[2] I have spent the last decade in the LIS profession working in a public library system, at a community college learning center, and in an academic law library before coming to my current area of scholarly communications librarianship for a multidisciplinary academic research library at New York University (NYU).

It is so fulfilling to be able to reflect on this trajectory, but also to witness someone else's, like yours! What about you? What kind of meandering path led you to the LIS field?

Lingyu

Thank you April! I've been so lucky to have worked with you over the past two years. Without your mentorship, I would not have known the world of libraries. Looking back at the time when I just started my master's program at NYU, or further back when I was an undergraduate, I definitely did not imagine finding my place in the libraries.

The beginning of my path was actually quite (stereo-)typical of international Chinese students in the United States: I was studying electrical engineering and computer science, looking to work in the then fast-growing tech industry. However, soon I realized that I wanted my work to be culturally and socially meaningful for more people, not just profitable for the industry. I turned to more humanistic fields and tried user interface design, graphic design, film production, and so on and settled with film and media studies for a while, with focus on visual culture and ethnography (which I later realized is actually a form of archive).

In terms of library jobs, I started as a part-time front desk assistant in the media resources center in my last few semesters in college and enjoyed the occasional film and documentary archival projects that we did there. When I started my work as a graduate student assistant at NYU, and as we began to take on more complex and impactful projects, the library job turned out to be intriguing and rewarding on its own. Eventually, I decided that LIS is the place to combine my engineering skills with humanistic thoughts and social awareness, under the common goal of making valuable intellectual works accessible.

While I am still figuring out where my work will go in this relatively new field, what would you like to share about your work? What are some thoughts or inspirations from your background that have shaped your approach to LIS and scholarly communications? What parts of your work do you find enjoyable and relatable?

April

LIS work is incredibly interdisciplinary and that interdisciplinarity can often be rooted in very practical methodologies found across different fields. Excitingly,

the work I do now in scholarly communications librarianship draws directly on the skills, experiences, and expertise I have cultivated throughout my academic and professional trajectory. The path may have been meandering, but the stops along the way have been meaningful! From legal practice, I learned how to analyze complex issues and provide guidance to colleagues and researchers while empowering them to make informed decisions about their own work. From public library work, I gained an appreciation for information equity and the importance of providing access to knowledge to all people and communities. In the course of my community college and academic law library work, I honed my teaching skills and learned to cultivate a reciprocal relationship between a learner and an educator. Now, as I work with my campus community on issues of rights, access, and ownership of scholarly materials, I bring all that experience to bear in meeting, and learning from, the needs of the people with whom I work.

Truly, there are many things that I enjoy about this work, but one at the top of the list is the variety of projects we get to encounter, working in the scholarly communications field. I know we got a chance to work on a lot of different things during our time together. What were some of your favorites, some of the projects that really stand out?

Lingyu

We have had a lot of different projects indeed! Now that you mentioned information equity and access, I think those are also agendas that I really care about and enjoy working on. For me, the most memorable project we have done in this direction is the research on open access policy, which is now part of the library's larger goals. I think the concept of open access touches back on the promise of scholarship and academia: to produce ideas that improve basic human conditions. Besides that, I have come to understand that opening up access not only changes the economy of scholarly publishing, but also opens up academia for broader conversations, like what we are doing right now, so that we can produce new forms of knowledge that reflect the values and experiences of more people.

On another note, to me, open access seems to be a very common and somewhat mythical ideal about digital technology that has brought about heightened connectivity and interactivity. Myth or not, what we are seeing today is a rising mindset of conversing, communicating, and exchanging ideas as broadly as possible. This may sound a bit like the 2000s Internet Utopia, but I believe it is crucial to keep the optimism and work for the better even in a divisive and confusing time. I look forward to the future of scholarship, when more people can read scholarly works and share their reflections, joining the scholarly conversation. Even though digital tools are still presenting us with lots of problems to solve, I still believe in the positive possibilities brought by open, civil, and well-informed conversations.

Personal Identities in Scholarly Communities

April

It is so true what you say about the power of scholarly communications residing in open conversation. As you point out, that is the very basis for the conversational format we chose for this book chapter. In fact, one of academic librarianship's basic tenets for information literacy is "Scholarship as Conversation."[3] We teach students to recognize scholarship as an interplay among scholars, both within and across disciplines. Moreover, as with any conversation, identity plays a major role in the creation and sharing of ideas. Scholarship, like librarianship, is not neutral,[4] and the context of identity affects all aspects of what we know and how we value that knowledge.

For me specifically, personal identity is very important to my work. As the second-wave feminists have been known to say—and as my fellow queer Black woman library worker, poet, and activist Audre Lorde has acknowledged (most notably during a talk critiquing a 1979 humanities conference at NYU)—"The personal is political!"[5] I think the personal is also professional. Librarianship, particularly academic librarianship, is very White, colonial, able-bodied, middle-class, cisgender, and straight; and the work can be very isolating for those of us who do not fit into those dominant identities.[6] As a queer, cisgender Black American woman of Native descent (Mvskoke Seminole, Cherokee, Gullah/Geechee), I often find a disconnect between the ways I engage with knowledge in my personal life, through my cultural identities, and the ways in which knowledge is created and valued in my professional academic spaces. It is very much a situation of what W. E. B. Du Bois calls the "double consciousness," a concept that especially resonates for many scholars from Indigenous and People of the Global Majority (People of Color) backgrounds.[7] I come from cultural identities where oral, community-based knowledge is valued and shared but work in an environment where written, single-author-based authority is elevated. It can be frustrating to try to dismantle the White supremacy, patriarchy, ableism, colonialism, and cis- and heteronormativity of the profession and to incorporate my broader concepts of scholarship into the often rigid confines of academic work. What about you? Have you felt the effects of your identities as you navigated the professional and educational space of the academic library?

Lingyu

The personal is political and professional, indeed! Thinking explicitly about identity is not just about affirming one's background, it's also about reflecting on the broader implications and unexamined premises of one's work. For me, the most influential identity is the identity as a Chinese international student, and this identity has a lot of complexities. Being a Han ethnic Chinese comes

with many privileges (including international mobility itself), since Han ethnicity is the dominant majority in Mainland China. However, reflections about these more under-the-surface identity differences do not always make sense for my Chinese peers. Adding onto this is the simplified Asian racial identity (and in fact, most naive skin-based identities) in the United States. In terms of the academic communities, these identities are putting students and scholars from drastically different social and cultural backgrounds under the same umbrella term.

This issue is also reflected in language. In an early project that we worked on, we researched the incorporation of different languages into scholarly publication. Back then I did not fully realize the importance of that incorporation, but now in retrospect, I see that language is part of the basis for nuanced cultural identities, and incorporating more languages into circulation can help scholars and students manifest their identities in their own terms. More often than not, terms devised in American English to represent other cultures are poor estimations and misfits, and these mistranslations can be even bigger problems for local researchers who are not bilingual as their international peers are.

A bit more on transnationality and cross-cultural communication: I think NYU, or generally, higher education in the United States, is quite distinctly transnational and cross-cultural, which is an advantage and a privilege. A lot of our projects speak to highly diverse communities within our NYC campus, across NYU's global campuses, and from many other institutions in different places. Some of these communities are scholarly ones, while others may not be scholarly in the strict sense. These crossings of borders also make this conversation between us two possible in the first place. What do you think these perspectives across borders could bring back to local conversations? Beyond the scholarly content that libraries deliver, what can our work bring to students, scholars, and just ordinary people who do not have the privilege of cross-border mobility, or for other reasons have been living in largely homogeneous communities?

April

This border crossing and bridge building is such a vital potentiality of scholarly communications. Just as we in academic libraries teach our communities that scholarship is a conversation, we also encourage students to view this scholarly conversation happening even beyond the ivory towers of academia. We aim to recognize the expertise of thinkers and knowledge creators wherever they may be, whether academic or not, because "Authority Is Constructed and Contextual."[8] When we allow the concept of scholarship to broaden through open conversation, we are better able to hear and welcome new ideas. Thus, we make space for people—researchers, students, instructors, community members,

and the like—to bring their personal identities and expertise into knowledge creation and to stimulate equitable exchanges across differences.

A great example of the possibilities in building broader, more inclusive conversations within scholarly communications is our work with the Femifesto. Femifesto: A Feminist Framework for Radical Knowledge Collaboration is a project, centered on multilingual, global, equitable knowledge creation and dissemination, that we have been working on with our colleagues Sandra Enimil, Ivonne Lujano, Charlotte Roh, Gimena del Rio Riande, and Sharon Farb.[9] Started as our accepted proposal for the 2019 Triangle Scholarly Communication Institute,[10] the Femifesto has grown into a framework and community committed to elevating and celebrating different ways of producing and sharing cultural knowledge. It is rooted in feminist principles, such as an ethic of care, and seeks to build more globally inclusive and equitable scholarly communications.

Gendered and Hegemonic Spaces in the LIS

Lingyu

Talking about sexism and gender identity, I hope we can discuss the *Femifesto* project in some more depth, because this project has been a big thing for me, and I will continue to work on it even after I move to my new program. Often, when people talk about informational platforms, I find that their discourses of technical neutrality and mathematical rationality have a somewhat masculine undertone that aims at some fixed, idealized technological perfection, while *Femifesto* raises different questions for us to think about. As I'm still processing everything about *Femifesto* and feminism, could you say a bit more about these principles? What roles do gender identities and feminist perspectives play (or could they play) in scholarly communication?

April

It is so great that we have the opportunity to talk more about *Femifesto* because I love the work we are doing there and the fact we are able to continue working on it together. One of the crucial foundations of that project—and of feminism, in general, to me—is our explicit focus on *intersectionality*. Intersectionality, a term first coined by Black feminist legal scholar Kimberlé Crenshaw, was meant as a means of taking feminism beyond the White, middle-class cisgender women's perspective and introducing a lens of race, class, and other markets of identity and oppression.[11] It has since, importantly, grown to go beyond feminism as a concern for cisgender woman and femme gender identity to encompass the struggle for all forms of oppressed gender identity, with interlocking lenses of race, class, queerness, disability, and other forms of being.[12]

So this intersectional approach that we apply to the Femifesto is absolutely crucial and provides a powerful framework for what we do in scholarly communications. Just as our intersectional Femifesto is about making space for voices, ideas, concepts, and knowledge that arise out of a variety of interconnected marginalized identities, so too should scholarly communications be focused on opening up to and centering a variety of voices and ways of knowing. The capitalist, White, Western, colonialist, ableist, patriarchal, cis- and heteronormative way of creating and sharing knowledge should no longer dominate the scholarly narrative.[13] As you and I experience in our own identities, there are so many more ways of knowing we can and should hear from, and in the academic library world, we have a responsibility to help bring those narratives to the fore. The way we approach gender identity is one important area where we can do that.

Lingyu

I see. The concept of intersectionality is indeed a powerful way to bring diverse experiences and identities into the picture. I can see it paving the way for establishing more complex Chinese identities that I mentioned before, and it can also help with, say, being an Asian person, living with a certain variant of Sinophonic culture, AND identifying as queer.

On the more practical level, it seems to me that librarianship itself is not as masculine as the knowledge structure it represents is. Telling from my personal experience, people taking care of libraries (at least in China) are usually female. I tend to perceive that the basic, everyday jobs in libraries are more about taking care of rather than producing intellectual products. These jobs often require carefulness, attention to detail, and affective labor, which are considered not productive or merely reproductive, and therefore feminine. I also see this division as part of the division between public space (exclusively for men) and domestic space (to which women are confined). How do you find library work and scholarly communications in relation to these gendered discourses?

April

Oh, absolutely, library work in North America, as in China, is very feminized. In general, about 80 percent of professional library workers in North America identify as women, though the gender differential evens significantly in large academic research libraries.[14] Nonetheless, it is important to note that as you progress up the administrative ladder, the gender differential shifts considerably, with more men serving in library leadership roles.[15] Thus, librarianship in the United States and Canada is a largely feminized profession, in which more women conduct the lower-level and lower-paying care work while more men tend to lead organizations and conduct the higher-paying and higher-valued strategic and generative work of the profession. Of course, it is vital to recognize

that much of these analyses about the gendered nature of library work anywhere in the world tends to fall under binary cisgender-normative lines, essentially erasing the experiences of nonbinary, transgender, and genderqueer professionals. Nonetheless, even as we take into account the experiences of colleagues who identify with all forms of gender marginalization, without fail, the gendered nature of library work translates into expectations of normativity and performativity that can be very harmful.

This gendered stratification within librarianship is particularly acute in fields like scholarly communications, digital scholarship, and digital humanities, where the distinctions between reproductive and productive work combine are deepened by the use of technology.[16] In many ways, it all hearkens back to the days of classic Western notions of knowledge creation, where the solitary cisgender heterosexual White man genius scribbles in isolation, producing wisdom, which he will then pass to his doting wife to organize, type, disseminate, and archive for time immemorial. Library and information work may have evolved in many respects, but when it comes to gender expectations, it has not changed as much as it could or should.

Lingyu

That is so true. That image of a solitary genius is just so all over the place! Even today, in many team-based research projects that actually require collaboration, seldom do you see credits given to collaborators or contributors who are lower in rank. The resulting image—and many times the expectation—of researchers is still the way it was in the classic Enlightenment times.

For another aspect of gender identities, I think we are now moving toward a mindset that things don't have to be well defined or rigidly categorized. Instead, gender identities can be something that is fluid, blurry, and even self-contradictory at times (that's also why I don't like to label myself with gender or sexual orientation). The same idea also applies to other kinds of identities, especially when it comes to cultures. While the whole social system of statistics uses clear categories to count, evaluate, and rationalize everything, and while sometimes these categories can seem like the only ways we can build our life, the real world has far more exceptions and uncertainties—which is why social systems of all kinds keep running into abnormalities and needing fixes.[17]

Building Empowered Mentoring Relationships

April

Yes, yes, yes! Fluidity is key. That is exactly what I was talking about when I spoke earlier about navigating the "double consciousness" of academic library work as a person from underrepresented identities.[18] We can and should find ways to

incorporate this fluidity into our work and make room to bring our whole selves into our scholarship. When we are able to see more aspects of our own identities in the fluidity of our work, we can more readily make space for others, especially those who may not feel welcome in academic spaces to begin with.

Ultimately, what it all comes down to are conversations and relationships, just as we are demonstrating now in this chapter. One of the aspects of our relationship that I have found to be most important is mentorship, and not just me mentoring you! I find professional and personal mentorship to be so important, especially as a person navigates their identities in academic spaces.[19] It has been a pleasure for me to mentor you as you explore more about LIS work in general, and scholarly communications work specifically. It has also been a pleasure to be mentored by you as you have taught me so much about the ways in which scholarly communications and academia can be improved for people newly entering the field, particularly those coming from different cultural and disciplinary backgrounds. For example, you mention the work we did on language and scholarly communications; your take on that work—as someone for whom English is not your first language but who nonetheless has to work in a largely monolingual English scholarly environment—added so much to my understanding of the importance of language inclusivity. In fact, we even ended up incorporating language inclusivity as a principle of the Femifesto, based in part on your perspectives.

I know what my experiences of navigating identity in my work have been like, but it is always important to learn about and from the experiences of others, and you have offered me some very powerful insights. How do you feel about mentorship as it relates to our work and identities?

Lingyu

Mentorship is definitely beneficial for both sides of the relationship! I also find that when I give advice to younger students interested in library studies and careers, I'm constantly realizing things that I did not previously notice in my own work.

I find that mentorship is about having meaningful, open exchanges of ideas in and around the work environment. It is not just teaching facts, but figuring out. When we navigate the profession, the workplace, and our own identities through this mutual process, we are not just getting facts about a definitive reality, but we are shaping the reality at the same time. A lot of conversations between us are not about how things are, but how things can be—from the format of our projects to the understandings of each other's community, from the way we can use the office space to the way we position our work in the field of LIS. Also, beyond workplace mentorship, I think the conversational, processual fashion of working is actually transforming the knowledge structure and work culture of LIS (and academia, generally) as well. It really goes above and beyond.

April

I agree with you completely. It is no mistake that this emphasis on conversation and relationship serves as such a controlling theme of this piece. As conversations deepen through engagement with openness and identity, LIS, and academia more broadly, is becoming more inclusive in important and exciting ways. That is why I am so thrilled to have folks like you joining the profession and helping to navigate these issues. Your personal scholarship on archival memory and social justice movements, for instance, is an area of study, and an area of conversation, that is much needed in our profession, and I can't wait to see where you go with it.

Looking Forward

April

Speaking of next steps, as you get ready to embark on this next phase of your academic and LIS career, how do you see yourself working to break down these barriers within scholarship and the academy? How are you hoping to continue to engage in this work as you progress in your career?

Lingyu

That is a grand question, and I will spend the good part of the upcoming years looking for a substantial answer. The broader answer is that I'll be looking for a way to better archive and represent social movements, and where I am now is looking at archives of street arts and social media arts. I want to know that beyond the material-centric approaches that we use in archives right now, and beyond the attention business of social media platforms, what kind of knowledge structures we can build these archives on. In other words, how can we create archives to reflect the crucial and diverse experiences, perspectives, values, and identities? I think this is how I situate my future work right now, and this is how I want our discussion in this whole chapter to fold into my own research.

Also, I want to take this chance to address the extraordinary time that we are going through—in the midst of (on the brighter side) the Black Lives Matter movement and (on the darker side) the COVID-19 pandemic. People are now bringing so many agendas that are long overdue to the front. The COVID-19 pandemic has really put caregivers in central positions, and ideas of care and communication have become prominent. On the other hand, the series of protests and movements ignited by the killings of George Floyd, Breonna Taylor, Ahmaud Arbery, and many other Black people have woken a lot of people who were unaware of other communities or of their own privileges. Academia will have to adapt to these changes, if not lead them.

This may sound a bit opportunistic, but I think the coming years will really give us a good chance to address and fix what has long been problematic in universities and libraries. Digital tools are now essential for teaching, open access is even more urgent and meaningful, intersectional feminist discourses are gaining more momentum, and the concept of education itself is also under reexamination. Data policies, socio-spatial data collection, health data, public health research, social movement archiving, social media archiving, new modes of community engagement… I believe these are all projects we can expect to work on.

Just for speculation, what do you think our new normal (in terms of our work, of course) would be like after this period of big changes? What larger changes in academia can we expect? What new mindset will we be working with? How will we work with our identities and communities in the new normal?

April

You know, I don't think it is opportunistic at all: in fact, I agree that now is a pivotal moment for reflection on what it means to engage in academic library work. It is important now as we find ourselves in the midst of major societal change, as well as for the future as we settle into a new normal. As you note, we now have a unique opportunity to examine critically the failings of the LIS profession and academia, to reckon honestly with the ways in which our processes and practices have helped to perpetuate inequity and injustice. Everything we have been discussing here about relationships, identity, and conversation is key to this examination. It all reminds me of the work you and I have done on developing a soon-to-come open access policy for NYU and our work on setting up a task force to review privacy practices in the library. Both of those projects arose out of a recognized need to build more equity and justice in our academic and library spaces. We can hope to build a more equitable and inclusive space for our profession only if we engage in these kinds of conversations openly, where folks—particularly those who have been marginalized—are welcome to bring their many and varied identities to the table. With that in mind, one last note I'd like to make about our conversation: it is important to point out that the majority of the people we cited in this piece are people who identify as Indigenous or People of the Global Majority (People of Color), and we did this intentionally in recognition of the political nature of citation.[20] Our citation choices are just one example of how we all can engage in building more equity into our academic spaces.

In terms of using this moment to look forward, you're right that digital tools can play a key role in this moment of critical examination, but I also think it will take more than a few community-organizing Zoom calls or crowdsourced anti-racism reading lists. This moment requires an iterative process

of self-reflection and systemic community action. We must examine ourselves and the role we play in the profession and in this moment, while also bringing those reflections to our professional communities to make meaningful collective change. That kind of process is very difficult and requires a lot of vulnerability, but it is absolutely worth doing. The future of our profession depends on it. Speaking of the future of the profession, as we close our conversation here, what advice would you give an entering or prospective LIS graduate student worker?

Lingyu

Thank you so much for the remarks, April! I totally agree that working with the local is just as important as, if not more important than, the digitized projects. This is a time when we are more connected to both the digital realm and our local fellow people. Now that I come to think of it, maybe the only thing that is missing now is the illusion that one can live in a digital world of pure concepts and shape one's own world without ever getting troubled by the reality.

For my fellow graduate student workers, my big takeaway from the past years is that we—all of us who have come across this text at some point—are first and foremost humans, and then students, scholars, library workers, and so on. Therefore, whenever we want to pursue something like a project, a career, an expertise, or a form of knowledge, we want to remind ourselves that what we do will eventually go to people just like us (in terms of humanity) but also different from us (in terms of identity). For me, I have gained a lot from asking who I am and what I care about as a person, as well as who they are and what they care about—"they" being whoever are on the other side of my work. As April and I have been discussing throughout this whole chapter, the personal is political and the personal is professional, or actually, both the political and the professional eventually boil down to the personal. Both realms are eventually about everyone in relation to everyone else, before all the physical and conceptual boundaries can set us apart.

April

So well said, Lingyu. What a great way to end a great conversation. I look forward to all we are able to build for our profession in the future!

Conclusion

It is our sincere hope that this chapter has served as an example of the kind of reflection, empowerment, and praxis that is possible in a relationship between an academic library manager and a graduate student worker. With a focus on our work in scholarly communications, and bearing in mind our belonging to identities underrepresented in LIS, we reflected on the ways our professional work

is contextualized through personal identity and has potential to enact change in the world around us. In particular, this conversation reflects a few important lessons that have guided the way in which we build and maintain our relationship of openness across our personal and professional lives.

First, we approach our relationship as graduate student worker and academic library manager by explicitly acknowledging and challenging the existing external power structures inherent in our relationship. While we realize that our work together has come from our respective roles as worker and manager, student and professional, we both acknowledge and question those roles to center more equity and mutuality in our interactions. April has been and continues to be just as interested in learning from Lingyu, as Lingyu is in learning from April. We recognize that while our professional and educational positions may attempt to dictate a hierarchy between us—and at times in our work, that hierarchy is unavoidable—we still maintain the openness of our relationship through a recognition of what each of us equally has to bring to and receive from the table.

Second, as we explicitly acknowledge existing power dynamics, we seek to build trust in each other in increments as a solid foundation to our relationship. Over the years, we have built trust in each other's work practices and work ethics, starting with small opportunities to demonstrate trust: in working together, Lingyu has learned to trust April to work thoughtfully to come up with new projects, while April has learned in the course of those projects to trust Lingyu to work thoughtfully on assigned tasks. We know that we will not hold back our critiques and praises for each other's work, and we know that regardless of our respective takes on a project, we respect each other as people. These opportunities for trust can even be entirely mundane, such as relying on each other to read and reply to email, but noting these small elements and taking small steps to affirm them can help a lot with building a relationship. From these small building blocks of trust, we have built our relationship, always with an explicit acknowledgement of our power dynamics.

Finally, we make a point of bringing our work into our broader communities, building on those incremental moments of trust. We find it immensely helpful to work together in larger communities—in our case, one example is the Femifesto group. In the group we are equal members, so we can share ideas with fewer hierarchical concerns. In addition, since we both work to bring diverse new projects to the library profession, we find a lot of support and inspiration from a group where people share similar motivations. Even after Lingyu's employment at NYU Libraries ended, the Femifesto community has always helped us stay in touch and build a lasting and supportive relationship.

While every manager-student relationship is as unique as the individuals involved, we nonetheless offer our own relationship as a case study, through the lens of open conversation, to demonstrate the possibilities these relationships

have for building a more inclusive LIS profession. By openly acknowledging power dynamics, building trust in increments, and bringing work into broader community relationships, we have crafted a strong relationship that goes beyond the roles of manager and student. We are colleagues who look forward to many more years of mutual learning, growth, and collaboration.

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CHAPTER 14

Reflections of a First-Time Manager

Building Trust for a Successful MLIS Practicum Experience

Jodi A. Psoter

Introduction

The Research and Instructional Services (RIS) department within Duke University Libraries (DUL) is committed to creating an ongoing, sustainable practicum student program. Specifically, we hope to create a department-wide program that builds on previous experiences the department gained from hosting MLIS students in the past while streamlining the current operational process. In spring 2020, RIS established a departmental goal to develop a more consistent approach to advertising for, recruiting, selecting, and onboarding practicum students. As a small group began working on aspects of this goal, the pandemic arrived. With encouragement and support from the head of RIS, the department shifted to remote work, but we continued to receive requests from students wanting practical experience in the field or needing experience to receive course credits

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required to graduate. In fact, there seemed to be much more interest since many libraries cancelled or postponed practicum positions completely. For the purpose of this discussion, please consider the idea of a practicum interchangeable with a field experience or an internship.

The RIS practicum experience is designed intentionally as an introduction to academic librarianship, structured as a learning experience. While some practicum experiences are built around very specific projects or developing a particular skill, the practicum I offer introduces the MLIS student to subject librarianship, giving them what I refer to as a buffet of experiences. Written to recruit students who have had no prior academic library work experience and are seeking a practical experience while learning about subject librarianship, my practicum position description also states that students must receive credit through their library school for their work. We are unable to offer students funding, but we do offer a variety of learning opportunities tailored to the student's interests in a supportive and safe environment.

From May 2020 to May 2021, I managed four practicum students, all supervised virtually. While this has been one of the best working and learning experiences of my library career, it was also one of the most time-intensive and emotional experiences. As a new manager, I learned so much during the virtual practicum, from the students as well as about managing. Most importantly, I learned that there is great value to graduate students to participate in virtual practicums and to host sites in offering them. Moreover, with the distance learning and field experience requirements of some MLIS programs, there is a need for virtual practicums within the MLIS community. Remote work has taught us that some aspects of managing and teaching work best in person and some thrive in the virtual environments. During my first year of managing, I personally learned a number of lessons from managing students virtually that I can apply as the Duke community moves forward and returns to campus. This chapter offers new managers strategies for managing graduate students as well as practical examples and lessons that I learned while implementing a successful, streamlined practicum experience for MLIS students in the Research and Instructional Services department at Duke University Libraries.

Taking the Plunge into Offering the Remote Practicum Experience

I tend to dive right into things, so in May 2020, when an MLIS student emailed DUL explaining that due to COVID, her summer internship was cancelled and asking if we could help her, how could I say no? It absolutely occurred to me that I would be supervising a student virtually, during a pandemic, not knowing the fall plan for the university or the libraries, with little time to prepare. The

student and I had an open, honest conversation about all the unknowns. She assured me that she was flexible and could adapt to change. The head of RIS and I started working on a plan and identifying projects that were appropriate for the practicum student and could be completed during a compressed summer practicum schedule. Just after the student began working with RIS, the university announced that all fall classes would be virtual. In a quick pivot, we spent the majority of the practicum focused on learning new technologies, reviewing instructional strategies for distance learning, and making our first (for both of us!) instructional videos.

This was, for me, an overwhelming start to managing. As with most everyone, I was working extra both at work and in life. My student, who had a professional career outside librarianship, was working with me thirty hours a week for one month. She needed daily feedback on her work so she could move forward with departmental projects. My own schedule included learning how to use Zoom while instructing a group of summer undergraduate researchers, moving my parents to Durham, and, of course, the pandemic planning required for everything from grocery shopping to doctor's appointments. Mentally it was exhausting. This period was also exhilarating. I quickly realized that with graduate students, the manager is part supervisor, part coach, and part mentor. The managing portion was my biggest challenge. The energy and the enthusiasm that our student brought to work every day was contagious, making the coaching easy. This first experience of mentoring a graduate student in the field of librarianship brought me back to the basics and reminded me why I love being a subject librarian. Even in the middle of a pandemic, the month working with this student made me sparkle. While this experience was intense, I am glad I embraced the opportunity. I was ready to continue working with students and growing as a manager.

Getting Started: Recruiting and Selecting Students

One of the goals for the RIS practicum program is to advertise and recruit in ways that allow us to build a diverse pool of potential practicum students. There are four graduate library programs in North Carolina, each of which I send an announcement to about our virtual practicum. Since the RIS practicum is unpaid, no formal interview process is required. I see this as being positive for the selection process. The dynamics and relationship-building opportunities shift when a manager can have an informal conversation versus a formal interview. The question became how I could have this conversational aspect with students yet make sure I was gathering relevant information that would help select the best candidate.

My solution was to gather interview questions from hiring managers in DUL and select the best ones that would guide the conversation. A colleague and I review applications and select three or four students who we want to learn more about. Having a colleague team up with me proves invaluable when reflecting on the strengths and weaknesses of students. We share the questions with the students in advance, creating, as I envisioned, a casual, structured conversation in which we get to know the person and they get to know more about DUL, RIS, the practicum, the librarians, and me. My colleague and I then select one or two students to whom we will offer the position. As I experimented over the past year, I learned that hosting two students concurrently is ideal. While it requires more organization, two students working together and learning from each other takes some of the pressure off the manager.

Providing Structure

Practicum students are a unique population. They are graduate students taking classes, so they have syllabi and schedules and deadlines and grades. In a complete role reversal, we take them into the library environment for self-directed work, quick turnaround times, and, as all subject librarians know well, constant scheduling changes since you never know who might reach out and what they might need. To mitigate culture shock and keep us organized, I created a series of Google folders and Docs using Google Drive. The system is not quite a syllabus, but the weekly organizational structure provides a tentative timeline for the work and required deadlines for the semester.

Setting up these documents involved a hefty amount of time initially, generally ten to twelve hours of my time for every eight hours worked by the students. Since I am intentionally recruiting students with no prior library experience, the initial work allows for a highly structured scaffolded learning experience that maintains room for flexibility. With an initial framework for a practicum established, the prep time decreased dramatically in future semesters. Each document has the week's dates, a description of our topic for the week, learning goals, check-in meeting agenda, and a weekly to-do list. The documents have evolved over the past year based on feedback from the students. Much of their evolution has to do with how the students use the documents. One student used the Google Doc to answer our weekly check-in questions—"What did you do?" and "What are you planning to do?"—before our scheduled weekly meeting. Another student used the Google Doc to ask questions about projects or departmental meetings. A third student loved checklists so she would check items on our to-do lists as they were completed. *The lesson learned here: Make sure to turn ON the Alert option for the document in both Google accounts so you know when someone asks a question or modifies a document.*

A one-semester practicum is intense for the students and the manager. In an effort to provide some stability and consistency, I schedule the two students and me to meet at the same time every week and follow the same format during this time. For the fall and spring semesters, I scheduled the weekly check-ins for four consecutive hours per week. The hours are marked on my calendar as busy to prevent meetings or consultations from being scheduled. (Note: The students generally have to schedule eight to ten hours per week to meet their course requirements. I consider the additional four to six hours as flextime: students work on projects, completing required hours at their convenience.) Depending on the weekly topics, questions asked, and even the general mood of the students, we may meet for an hour, leaving lots of time for individual work, or work as a group for the entire four hours, making sure to take stretch breaks! Initially, I scheduled these extended meetings as a way to recreate the face-to-face time that we would naturally have when physically in the library. I continue to use this scheduling format as the extended dedicated time proved useful and allows us to dive deep into topics and for the students to ask in-depth questions without feeling rushed.

Creating Connections

Having this structure allows me to focus on building connections with my students, particularly early in the practicum. For many people this is the most difficult and draining part of supervising, yet it is the most important and hardest to learn. You are laying the foundation to build trust: for you to trust your students and for them to trust you. The concept of trust has many meanings, especially when considered from a managerial point of view. What does trust mean to the person you are supervising? Are you able to create trust in a virtual practicum? How do you show a person they can trust you? How do you do this quickly at the start of the semester?

We all have different personalities resulting in various managerial styles. I encourage you to think about how you can be true to yourself while incorporating elements that are key to building trust:

- Consider sharing details about you.
- Have a willingness to be vulnerable.
- Regard the students as colleagues.
- Establish a safe space.

The quickest way to build trust is to demonstrate your authenticity through your actions. I ask questions about students' lives, share details of my own life, and, since we have been virtual, have even had the honor of meeting children and parents. I share my experiences in librarianship: the good, the bad, the successes, and the failures. I trust that the students are going to do what they say they are

doing to do. I demonstrate through my actions that we can be ourselves and create a space where we can all be vulnerable.

It takes time to build trust, but creating a space where students are able to express themselves is the key ingredient. *A major lesson I learned the past year is to continuously encourage students to ask questions*. Early on, students really think that my saying "Ask me anything" is just an expression and that I do not really mean it. My emotional investment pays off with students showing their vulnerability as the type and tone of questions asked over the course of the semester changes. General questions such as "Why did you become a librarian?" are traded for more specific questions such as "What do I really need to wear to my job?" and "What do you do if you don't get along with someone you work with?" The growth of mutual trust allows for open and honest communication.

Learning to Manage

Before taking on the challenge of managing practicum students, I spent the previous semester shadowing the head of another department with a long-standing practicum program (see chapter 4), observing and learning as she supervised her department's practicum students. I listened closely as she guided, never micromanaged, the students through their practicum experience. From my observations, she encouraged creative thinking, asking questions, and opportunities to experiment. Success or failure was not the motive; the focus was on the learning experience for the students. Additionally, my supervisor provided me with suggested readings in the area of mentoring and supervising, often connected to a challenge I was facing or specific to what a student might be experiencing. While I did have a brief shadowing experience, much of what I learned has been by trial and error. My weekly check-ins with students provide opportunities for immediate feedback. Some managerial concepts that I found most relevant and immediately useful, while learning to supervise graduate students include these:

- *Begin with expressing expectations.* Being explicit about expectations can help students navigate the practicum more effectively, help them adapt quicker, and make the experience less stressful. I have noticed that a common practice for students is to send emails to their course instructors by putting the assignment in the subject line and attaching a document. This email practice might work for academic work but is less appropriate in the workplace. Clearly stating an office norm early on—in this instance to provide context to the sender for what you are sending and why you are sending it—can help prevent confusion for library staff and students.
- *Ask many, many questions.* A critical mistake I made, more than once, is not asking enough questions. In one instance, I assumed the version of LibGuides used by a student in her coursework was the same version we use at Duke. By failing to ask the right questions, I created a situation

where a project I thought would be completed quickly required an unanticipated time investment for the student as they learned how to navigate the software.

- *Help the student understand context and impact.* Be sure students understand the connection between the work they are doing and the impact of the overall project. Telling students why a project is important and the impact that it will have for the library shows the value of their work. Additionally, it helps to connect the project to the broader learning experience. For this introductory practicum, I try to scaffold the projects, building skills while connecting the skills to the learning. *Lesson learned here: clearly state deadlines, why the deadline is nonnegotiable, and the impact that missing the deadline will have on the overall project timeline.*
- *Recognize the value of prior experiences.* Given that experiences are such an important part of who a person is, take a close look at a student's life skills. It helps to show how their prior experiences connect to the field of librarianship and the current learning environment. The manager can leverage their strengths in a new way or in a new context. A student shared her research experience from writing a thesis and its influence on patron interactions. Another student, who is also an artist, created a marketing flyer for a library book club, a project that combined her other passion with learning to use Canva.
- *Seek support from colleagues.* Other managers can be a huge source of support as you are learning to manage. Chances are someone within your organization has experienced your current situation. Seek out the expertise you need, from shadowing to advice to ideas. My colleagues all have different strengths, so it helped me to identify different individuals over the course of the past year from whom I could learn. An important component has been a supportive supervisor who understands the time investment with supervising students and the attention they require.
- *Prepare for the hard talk.* One area that I was completely unprepared for is how to handle an underperforming practicum student. I was nervous about isolating the student and losing contact since we were not working in person. I scripted questions designed to determine if the student was aware of the issues and offered feedback in the form of observations and explanations. Having written out questions and practiced the conversation with my supervisor, I was able to be supportive and empathic, yet explain how not meeting a deadline had implications for the team regarding the final deliverable. To create accountability, I ended with the question, "What next steps do you want to take to get the project back on track?"

Guiding the Learning Experience

As I mentioned, a one-semester practicum is intense for mangers and students. It reminds me of using Google Maps: you drop the yellow person icon onto the map and suddenly they are in the center of activity. Similarly, we are bringing students into an organization so they can learn and participate in our daily activities. Given that we expect them to learn, ask questions, and complete projects, the manager must acclimate the students quickly. At the beginning of each semester, I have an idea of some departmental and subject-specific projects on which the practicum students can work. However, I leave a lot space for things to evolve as I learn more about the students and as I receive last-minute faculty requests. Some approaches that I have found useful in guiding the learning experience while building trust include these:

- *Build in extra time for meetings.* I allow for a bit of time for general chatting and greetings, usually at least ten or fifteen minutes. I will often share something that happened at work or in life, often funny, occasionally stressful. This time gives students a chance to relax a bit, ask me questions, and get to know each other. It reminds them that there is life outside of work.
- *Encourage exploration.* The first week of the practicum, I require students to explore the DUL website, particularly the staff section. I ask that they write a one-page reflection sharing what is new to them and things they are unfamiliar with, and to select three or four library staff members they would like to meet with over the semester via virtual coffee breaks. This open exploration gives me ideas about their interests and insight into what they find unfamiliar, all of which I can then incorporate into the learning experience over the course of the semester.
- *Balance your needs with those of the students.* The time I schedule for weekly check-in meetings is time dedicated to the practicum students. I turn off email and chat and devote my full attention to their needs. As we work, I take notes and follow up in the next day or two. My down time, and I communicate this repeatedly, is evenings and weekends. I remind students to ask questions before Friday afternoon, especially if they plan to work on a project over the weekend.
- *Provide organizational information.* The focus of my practicum experience is an introduction to subject librarianship in academia. There are a wide variety of liaison activities that librarians may participate in which depend on the librarian, the discipline, departmental needs, library goals, and the institution's strategic goals. To get a flavor of the variety of liaison activities possible, students read a document describing the DUL best practices for subject librarians. This document details areas that a subject librarian might be involved in and provides specific examples. The head of RIS takes

time to meet with each practicum student and review the overall library organization chart, making sure to explain acronyms and verifying they understand library jargon in the context of our organization.

- *Connect the learning experience to a project.* A quick way to get a student involved and see a final product is to have them create a library blog post. For example, our spring 2021 practicum students were able to contribute to a departmental project to highlight diversity in DUL's collections through blog posts. To date, the practicum students have written about neurodiversity, outsider artists, and Black women Olympians. A bonus for this project is that students have something tangible and public to add to their résumés.
- *Prepare for the job search.* We recognize that professional development related to applying and interviewing for jobs is not the focus in MLIS education. During the 2021 semester, the head of RIS suggested we trial a professional development series. The group, which consisted of five RIS practicum students and three RIS librarians, explored subjects such as reading job descriptions, understanding the difference between a CV and a résumé, and writing a description of the practicum experience for their résumé. I shared stories about my epic failure of a phone interview and the time I traveled to an interview with two different shoes in my luggage! Based on feedback, the chance for the students to ask any questions they wanted in a nonjudgmental environment and receive honest answers was a highlight in the five-part series.

A Practical Project

Without a doubt, the most common request I receive from students is opportunities for instruction experience. Duke, as an institution, focuses on in-person instruction, and the DUL librarians work to build relationships and earn trust from faculty. Given these constraints, classroom instruction opportunities for the practicum students are hard to create during a one-semester or a virtual practicum.

My solution is to provide students with a project called Teach Me. I create a scenario based on my previous work while incorporating the interests of the student. Below is an example I wrote for a student who had no teaching experience and an interest in outsider artists. In preparation, the student peer-reviews my instructional videos for a freshman writing course. Then the student creates a lesson plan and teaches the lesson. Throughout the project, I am available to answer questions from the fictitious faculty member's point f view and assist with lesson planning. My role changes to the part of a freshman college student when the practicum students teaches their prepared instruction session.

Example: Teach Me Prompt

> You are a subject library at a university, and a faculty member has requested that you teach a library instruction session for her introductory writing class called Outsider Artists. This is a course designed to teach writing skills to freshman using the overarching theme of outsider artists. Twelve students are enrolled in the course. The class meets two days per week for one hour and fifteen minutes. The final assignment, for this course, is a 3–4-page research paper on a topic of the student's choice. It could be a specific artist, a type of art, art in a specific geographic region, etc. Your job as the subject librarian is to design a lesson plan that teaches library instruction geared toward the assignment and the faculty member's request. You know that the students will need to know how to search for books using the Duke Library catalog. You also know that articles will be useful, so you plan to demonstrate at least one subject database. There is not enough time to show archives, newspapers, or art gallery–related materials (remember this a class for freshmen, so basic research skills are your goals) but you plan to create a course guide (imaginary of course!) for the students that they can refer back to. The faculty member has specifically asked for a Zotero demo and for breaks in the lesson so the students can practice the skills you are demonstrating to them. Your task is to write a lesson plan (include learning goals—bullet points are fine) for this library instruction scenario. You will walk through the lesson plan with me, practicing the teaching portions.

Shifting from Managing to Coaching

I have noticed that sometime around midsemester, my role shifts from manager to coach. Rather than writing it, I collaborate with the student to create their to-do list for the following week. My supervisor refers to this process as "steering within boundaries." This concept is reflected in a series of questions that I use at midsemester meetings to ensure the students are getting as much from the experience as they can, learning what they are interested in, and providing feedback on how our department and I can improve the overall experience. Because we have established open and honest communication over the course of the semester, the students return the favor by being honest and forthcoming in their accolades and criticism of their practicum experience. I provide questions to the students ahead of our scheduled meeting so they have time to think over

their response, giving us more time to discuss the details. The questions that have generated the most useful discussions are these:

- *Are we meeting your learning goals?* Asking this encourages students to review the learning goals written before we began the practicum. A review helps me to determine if I am steering the students in the right direction or if a goal needs rewriting.
- *What else do you want to learn? What further opportunities do you want to explore?* Keeping the focus on the practicum as a learning experience gives students the opportunity to share concepts they have heard about and which they would like to learn more about. Based on their feedback, I have added topics such as critical pedagogy, lesson planning, and the research cycle as topic of the week to our weekly meeting agendas.
- *What have you enjoyed the most and why?* By determining what part of the subject librarianship buffet a student has enjoyed most, I can be sure to include more of that activity as we move forward. Multiple students have mentioned they found the virtual coffee breaks with DUL staff, where they learn more about different types of jobs in a library, to be one of their favorite activities.
- *What have you found the most useful or applicable?* All four students that I have worked with mentioned the connection between theory and school curriculum with the hands-on learning and professional work of the practicum. As one student stated,

> Although I have not taken a course on academic libraries and library instruction, I can see how learning about the theory behind it and seeing it put into practice are two very different learning experiences. Theory can sometimes introduce the implication that there is one best way of doing something, but... there are many different best practices based on the needs of the library instruction session.

A non-traditional student noted her appreciation of my connecting subject librarianship to her prior experiences.

> ... she [Jodi] did not negate the value of my previous experiences and accepted them as valuable contributions. I think that is important to note if older candidates are considered for the practicum. It also applies to those with nontraditional careers or paths to being librarians that she recognized the value of previous experiences and how skills might transfer.

- Additionally, the professional development workshop series and our assistance with preparing for the job search received five-star reviews. One student described how the workshops inspired her to update her résumé.

> The professional development series should be a must-have for all future practicum students and interns. So much practical advice was covered in this series. I plan to overhaul my résumé post-practicum with everything I have learned from the series.

- *Are there things you would like done differently? What and how?* If I have built a solid relationship and established trust, the student responses are honest and forthcoming with this question. Their responses guide me to adapt my approach to working and supervising based on their strengths and weaknesses. Additionally, some responses have challenged me to rethink my initial approach for how to give students a particular experience. For example, to have students learn about virtual reference, they shadow me during my chat shift using the shared screen feature in Zoom. Based on student feedback, I learned that shadowing is useful, but perhaps answering previous chat questions, as one student suggested, would be a more effective use of time. This would also allow a guaranteed opportunity to practice answering a variety of real reference questions.

Future Directions

The suggestions and recommendations from DUL staff, my experiences this past year, and all student feedback will be considered as RIS continues with the next steps to build and improve the practicum experience in our department. External issues will influence my practicum, which RIS will need to think about and discuss. I am not sure if this is the case at a majority of library schools, but the ones I worked with this past year considered the virtual practicum to be the exception during the pandemic. Given how a virtual option allows for more diversity, equity, and inclusion in the selection process, I hope to see library schools continue to accept worksites as virtual. If virtual practicums become a norm, structural considerations when the supervisor is on campus and the primary mode of instruction is in person will need to be addressed. Additionally, it has been a while (a long while!) since I attended graduate school. I would like to talk with coordinators of practicums and field experiences at library schools in North Carolina to learn more. What experiences do students need for a successful transition to their career? What other practical applications of classroom work would benefit practicum students?

As I continue to manage and coach MLIS students, I see a need to learn more about management philosophy and to develop my supervisory and mentoring

skills. As I consider what steps I can take to develop as a manager, my learning goals for the next year include these:

- Identify and read relevant books and articles.
- Explore learning opportunities related to managing.
- Participate in a coaching skills course offered by Duke.

You may have noticed in the author information that my job title is librarian for chemistry and statistical science. While the practicum that I currently offer is general, my true passion for information is with the sciences. I would like to structure a practicum so a student would get real in-depth search practice with key science databases; engage with topics such as data management, open access, standards, and patents; and learn skills in specific science subject areas such as structure searching in chemistry or the USGS mapping program. *Is there enough interest to create a practicum focused on science librarianship?*

Conclusion

Managing students during a practicum really is an amazing experience. One does not often have the opportunity to stop and think, but I have been able to ponder my role in my position, my role as a librarian, and my contributions to Duke. This has allowed me to be able to connect the academic coursework to the learning experience, showing students the impact of their work. I also found that this shift in job duties, the different aspect of work that is required for managing and coaching, is a welcome break from research and instruction. Rather than being challenged to find information, I am finding the missing piece, whether it is teaching, collections, consults, and so on, of the student's graduate education and giving them the opportunity to grow.

It is harder to define and describe the hidden labor of managing. I find myself heavily invested in the success of each student, taking turns in the roles of supervisor, mentor, teacher, coach, and motivator. This aspect of managing is a giant time commitment and requires an unexpected emotional component. The initial work was overwhelming. In fact, my weekly check-in meetings are energy draining for me. It is so worth the effort, though, to build trust with the students, learn from them, and see them develop over the course of the semester.

I struggle with managing and do not anticipate that changing in the near future. As I write this, I worry about being able to balance my on-campus work with the virtual practicum experience and my responsibilities in work and my personal life. Luckily, I have been fortunate to work with great students, all of whom understand that we were learning together and all of whom were eager to learn more about librarianship. The students have continually impressed me with their abilities to synthesize and connect the various parts of subject librarianship as well as large amounts of information in a relatively short time. I recently offered an unpaid practicum to two students for the upcoming semester. They

are both enthusiastic, vibrant, intelligent people. They will challenge me, exhaust me, and teach me new things. Students are open to learning, and we can learn much from working with them. If you have the opportunity and the desire, I highly recommend offering a practicum experience and sharing your knowledge with the next generation of librarians.

About the Authors

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Beth Filar Williams is an associate professor and serving head of the Library Experience and Access department at Oregon State University since 2015. As a practicing librarian for over twenty years, working in a variety of libraries in Maryland, North Carolina, and Colorado, she has hosted dozens of MLIS interns, field placements, practicums, international students, graduate assistants, and virtual-only students.